IMPROVISING
Jazz Piano.

by John Mehegan

A brilliant and instructive treatise on jazz piano improvisation, by one of the most distinguished writers on jazz technique. Deals with all aspects, including a survey of piano styles from 1900 to the present day.

Chapter 1

The Harmonic Vocabulary (Introduction)

The principle of jazz improvisation involves the abandoning of the melody and the creating of new ideas from the resources of the harmony (chord changes) of a tune, arpeggios, modes, ornamental tones, etc. Because of this, it is essential that the student have a clear and concise idea of the use of harmony in dealing with jazz improvisation.

The diatonic system dating back to the 17th Century forms the basis for the jazz harmonic vocabulary. The diatonic system divides into two sub - systems, the triad system and the seventh chord system.

The Triad System:

The student is advised to be very familiar with the twelve major scales and, at least, the twelve harmonic minor scales before proceeding with this text.

Lesson: Play the scale - tone triads of Fig. 1 through Fig. 13 in both hands, with the left hand in the octave immediately below the right hand, until they can be played automatically from memory in any key.

Fig. 1 Key of C

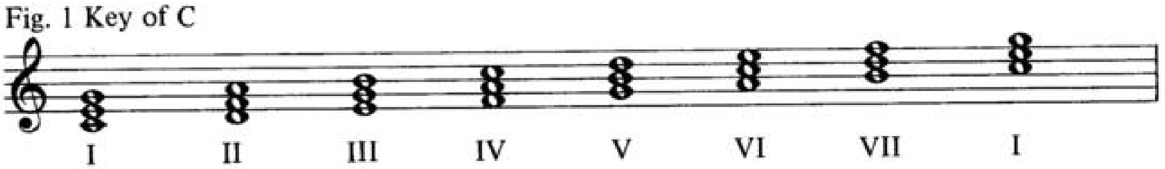


Fig. 2 Key of G

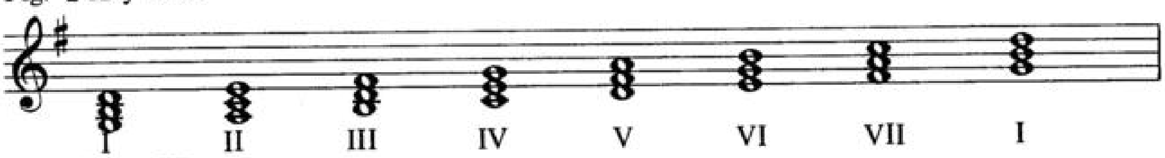


Fig. 3 Key of D

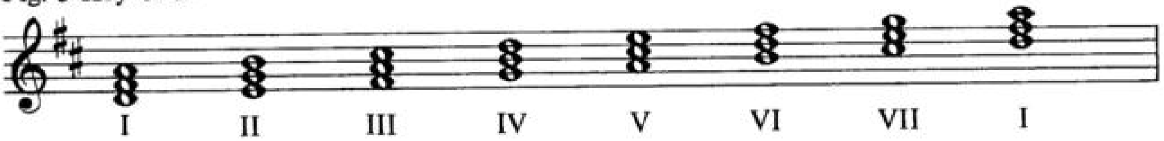


Fig. 4 Key of A

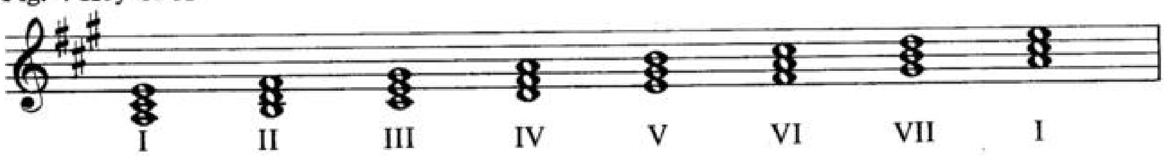


Fig. 5 Key of E

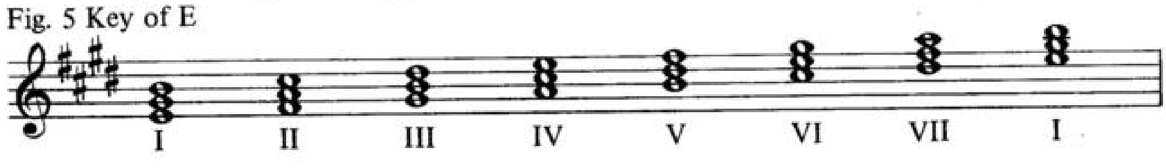


Fig. 6 Key of B

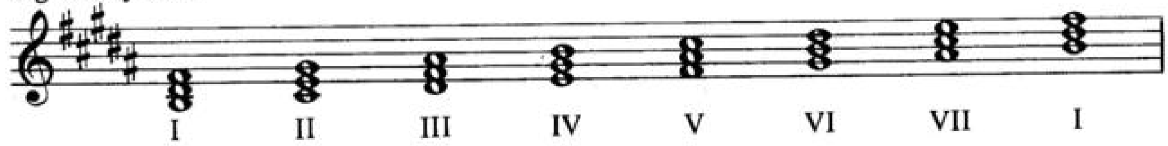


Fig. 7 Key of F♯ (Enharmonic of G♭)

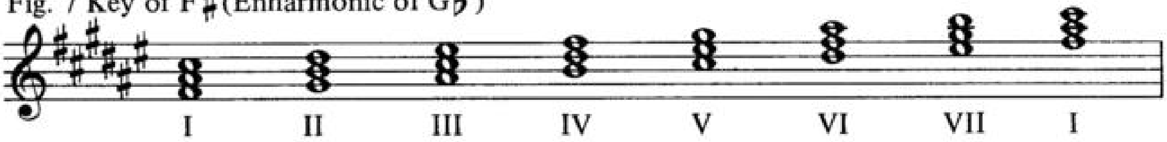


Fig. 8 Key of G♭ (Enharmonic of F♯)

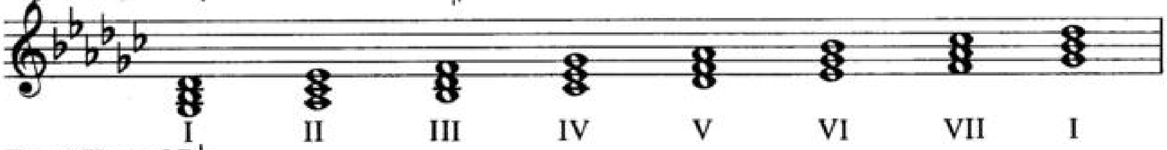


Fig. 9 Key of D♭

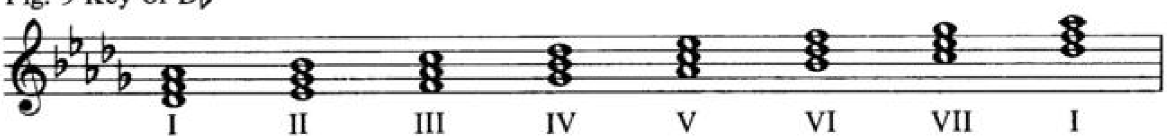


Fig. 10 Key of A♭

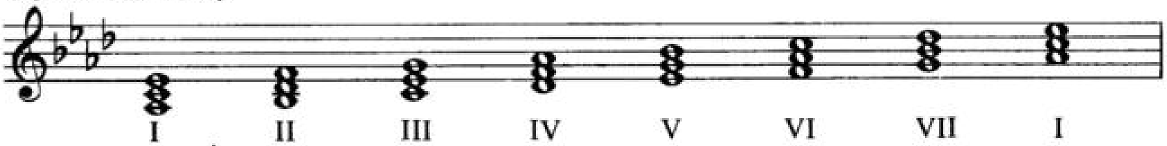


Fig. 11 Key of E♭

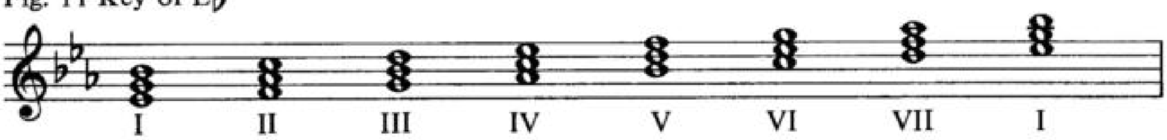


Fig. 12 Key of B♭

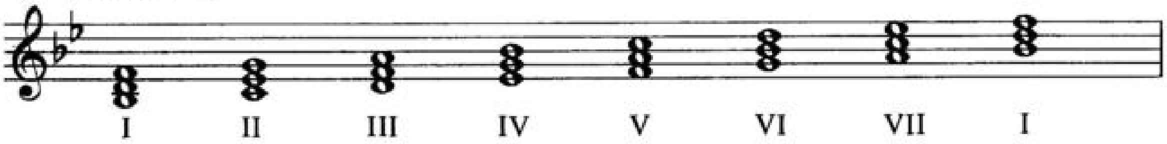
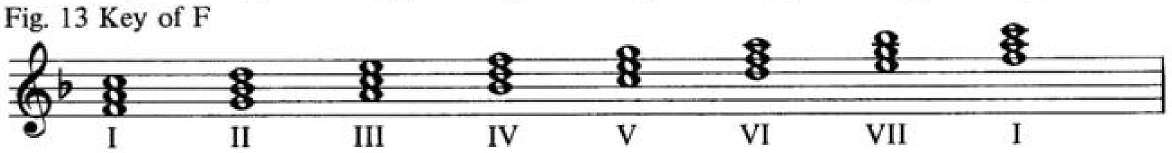


Fig. 13 Key of F

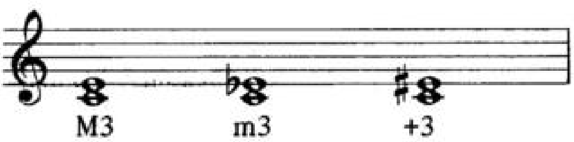


Intervals (Part 1)

These triads consist of three alternate scale tones sounded simultaneously.
The interval between the lowest and middle note is a 3rd; the interval between the lowest and highest note is a 5th.

Rule: If the upper note of a 3rd is contained within the diatonic major scale of the lower note, it is major (M). If it is lowered, it is minor (m). If it is raised, it is augmented (+).

Fig. 14.



Thus, in the Key of C:

I Based on the scale of C, C-E is major (M)

II Based on the scale of D, D-F is minor (m)

III Based on the scale of E, E-G is minor (m)

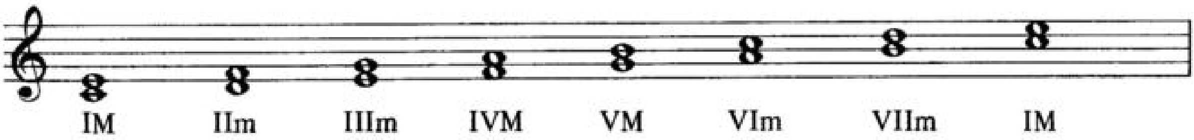
IV Based on the scale of F, F-A is major (M)

V Based on the scale of G, G-B is major (M)

VI Based on the scale of A, A-C is minor (m)

VII Based on the scale of B, B-D is minor (m)

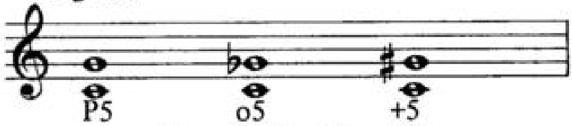
Fig. 15



This is true in all keys

Rule: If the upper note of a 5th is contained within the diatonic major scale of the lower note, it is perfect (P). If it is lowered, it is diminished (o). If it is raised, it is augmented (+).

Fig. 16



Thus, in the Key of C:

I Based on the scale of C, C-G is perfect (P)

II Based on the scale of D, D-A is perfect (P)

III Based on the scale of E, E-B is perfect (P)

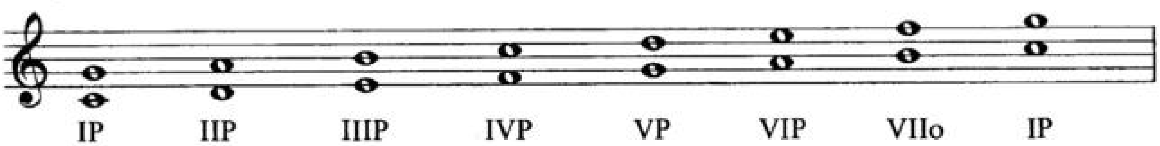
IV Based on the scale of F, F-C is perfect (P)

V Based on the scale of G, G-D is perfect (P)

VI Based on the scale of A, A-E is perfect (P)

VII Based on the scale of B, B-F is diminished (o)

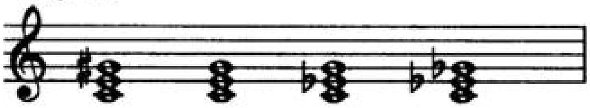
Fig. 17



This is true in all keys

Combination		Position	Chord Quality
3rd	5th		
M	+	See note	augmented (+)
M	P	I - IV - V	major (M)
m	P	II - III - VI	minor (m)
m	o	VII	diminished (o)

Note: The augmented triad does not appear in the major diatonic system.(It does appear in the minor diatonic system.) It is included here because of its common usage in tunes.

Fig. 18

C+ . CM Cm Co

Rule: In any key,I, IV and V are major: II, III and VI are minor: VII is diminished. The augmented triad is added to the system.

Letters versus Numerals

Throughout this text the student will notice the interchangeable use of letters and numerals. Depending upon the specific problem under consideration, both are permissible. Illustrations,such as the Harmonic Vocabulary in which no key center is involved,obviously submit to lettered spelling; on the other hand, chord progressions or chord charts of tunes involving a key center demand the use of numerals in order to give the student a sense of key center unity which every experienced jazz musician uses as a natural process whether or not he or she is intellectually aware of the use of numerals. Numerals or figured bass (basso continuo) evolved during the Renaissance,and for some five centuries has been the classical vocabulary employed in music schools throughout the world. Ironically, improvisors in the classical tradition have historically employed numerals when performing in order to be free of the bondage of notation. Letters have never been employed (except for simple identification) in the classical field. The use of letters began in the early part of the of the present century; they were originallyemployed bythe publishing industry to assist the average purchaser of sheet music in identifying ukulele or banjo chords. Since many of the early jazzmen were gifted but untrained musicians, they accepted the lettered chords as a readily available language in order to communicate with each other. However, when jazzmen perform, they "pre - hear" the next chord or phrase through a natural numerical estimate of where they are and where they are going. An added advantage involving numerals in progressions and chord charts should be apparent to the student. One set of numerals gives instantaneous twelve key facility since the numerals work for all keys. Otherwise, it would require twelve sets of letters to allow for transposition.

Chapter 2

The Seventh Chord System

Lesson: Play the scale - tone seventh chords of Fig. 1 through Fig. 13 in both hands until they can be played automatically from memory in any key.

Fig. 1 Key of C

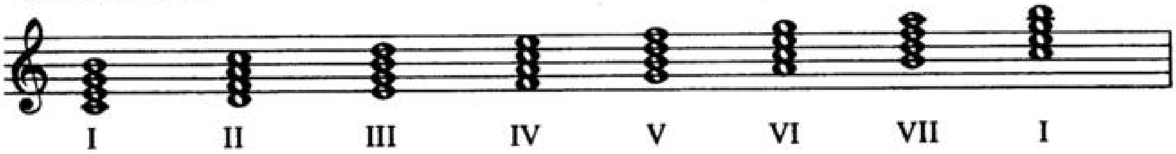


Fig. 2 Key of G

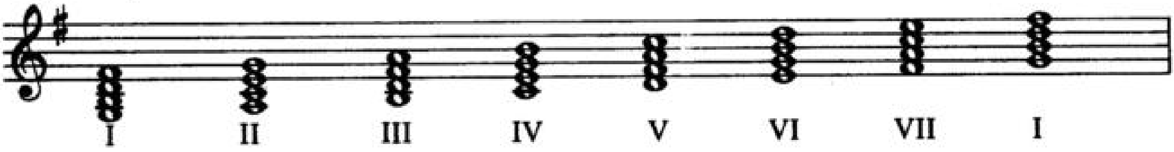


Fig. 3 Key of D

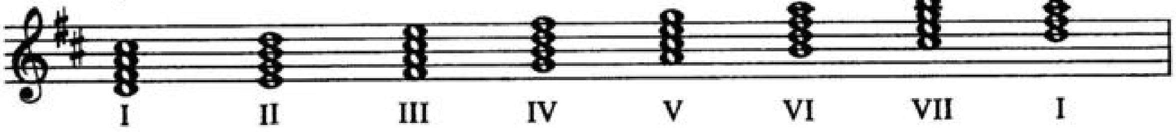


Fig. 4 Key of A

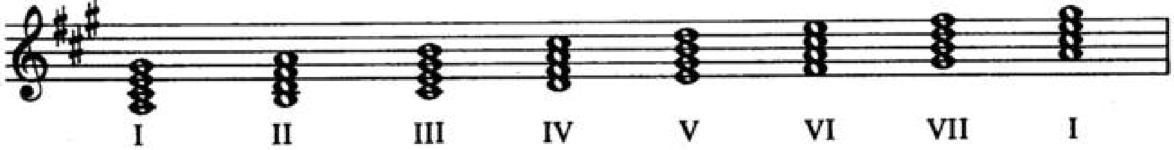


Fig. 5 Key of E

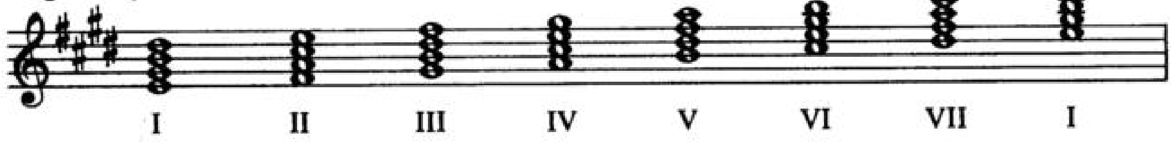


Fig. 6 Key of B

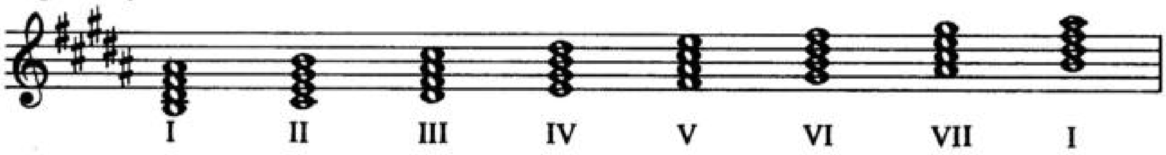


Fig. 7 Key of F♯ (Enharmonic of G♭)

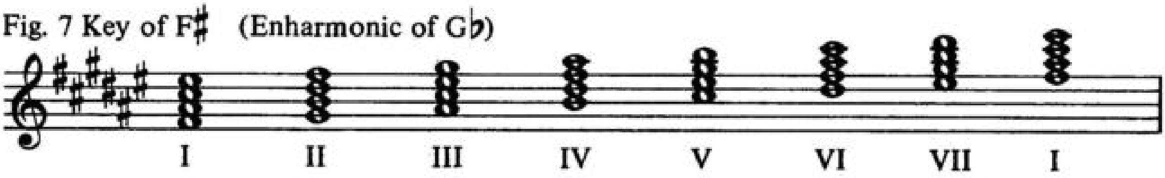


Fig. 8 Key of G♭ (Enharmonic of F♯)

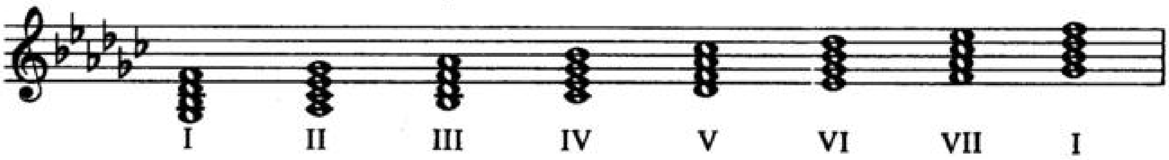


Fig. 9 Key of D♭

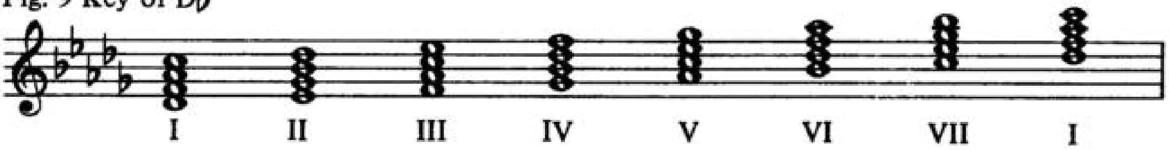


Fig. 10 Key of A♭

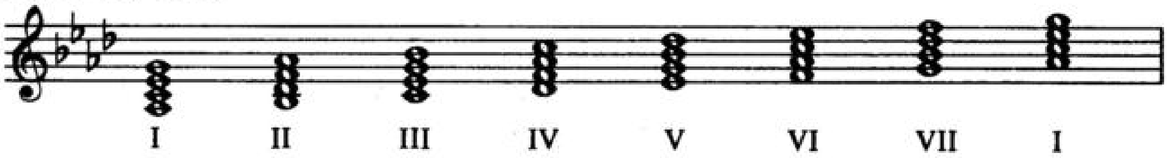


Fig.11 Key of E♭

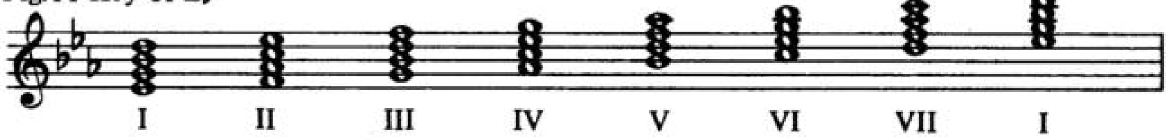


Fig. 12 Key of B♭

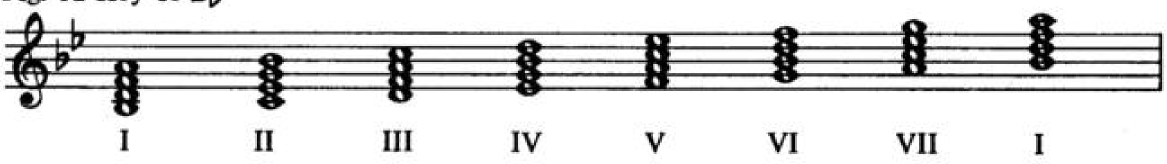
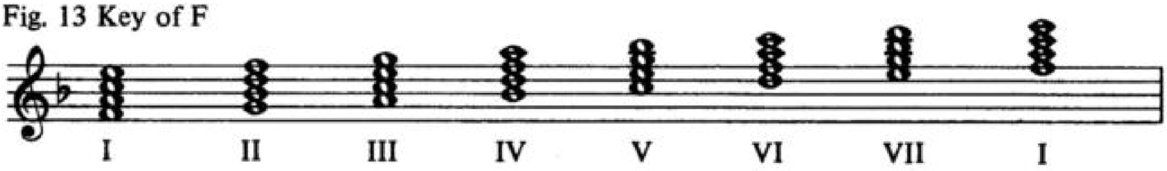


Fig. 13 Key of F



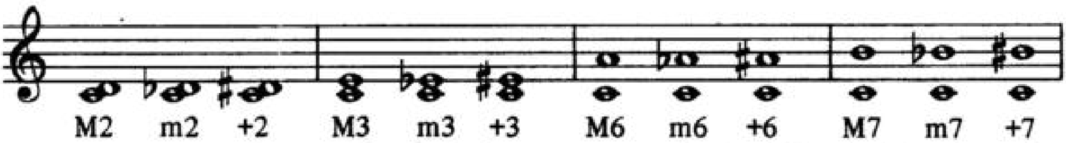
Chapter 3

Intervals (Part 2)

On Pages 7 and 8 rules for thirds and fifths were presented. The following indicates the general rule for all intervals:

If the upper note of a 2nd, 3rd, 6th or 7th is contained within the diatonic major scale of the lower note, it is major (M). If it is lowered, it is minor (m). If it is raised, it is augmented (+).

Fig. 1



If the upper note of a 4th, 5th or 8th (octave) is contained within the diatonic major scale of the lower note, it is perfect (P). If it is lowered, it is diminished (o). If it is raised, it is augmented (+).

Fig. 2

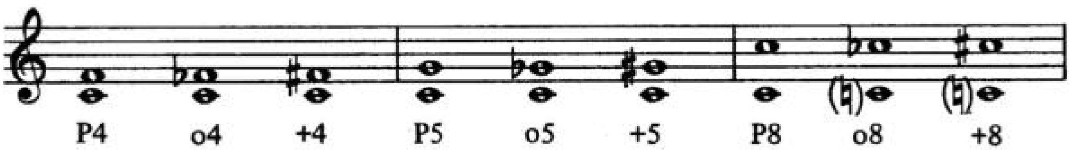
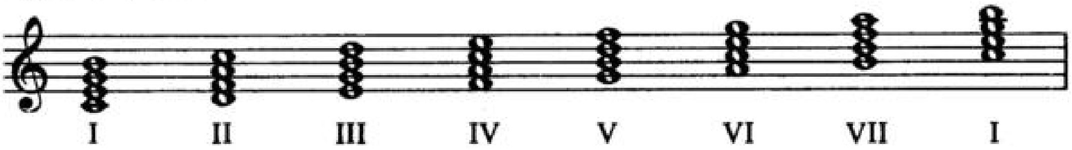


Fig. 3 Key of C



I Based on the scale of C, C - E is major (M)
II Based on the scale of D, D - F is minor (m)
III Based on the scale of E, E - G is minor (m)
IV Based on the scale of F, F - A is major (M)
V Based on the scale of G, G - B is major (M)
VI Based on the scale of A, A - C is minor (m)
VII Based on the scale of B, B - D is minor(m)

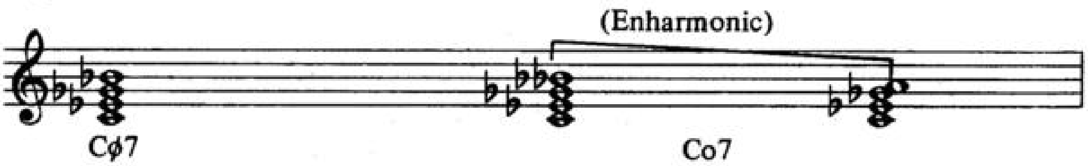
I Based on the scale of C, C-G is perfect (P)
II Based on the scale of D, D-A is perfect (P)
III Based on the scale of E, E-B is perfect (P)
IV Based on the scale of F, F-C is perfect (P)
V Based on the scale of G, G-D is perfect (P)
VI Based on the scale of A, A-E is perfect (P)
VII Based on the scale of B, B-F is diminished (o)

I Based on the scale of C, C-B is major (M)
II Based on the scale of D, D-C is minor (m)
III Based on the scale of E, E-D is minor (m)
IV Based on the scale of F, F-E is major (M)
V Based on the scale of G, G-F is minor (m)
VI Based on the scale of A, A-G is minor (m)
VII Based on the scale of B, B-A is minor (m)

In all Keys:

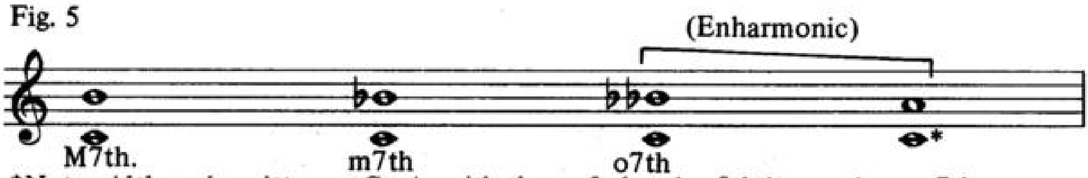
Combination			Position	Chord Quality
3rd	5th	7th		
M	P	M	I - IV	major 7th
M	P	m	V	dominant 7th
m	P	m	II - III - VI	minor 7th
m	o	m	VII	half diminished 7th*

*Note: The term "half diminished" may be new to the student although it has wide usage in the classical nomenclature and, mainly through the efforts of the late Bill Evans, has begun to appear in contemporary jazz originals. The term is derived from the fact that the "full" diminished 7th chord (as we shall see) employs two diminished intervals (o5, o7), whereas the "half - diminished" chord employs only one diminished interval (o5).

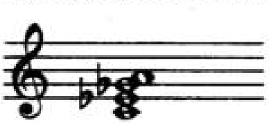
Fig. 4

The Diminished Seventh Chord:

The diminished seventh chord does not appear in the major diatonic system. (It does appear in the minor diatonic system.) This chord contains a minor 3rd, a diminished 5th and a diminished 7th (lowered twice from the seventh scale position). (See Fig. 5)

Fig. 5

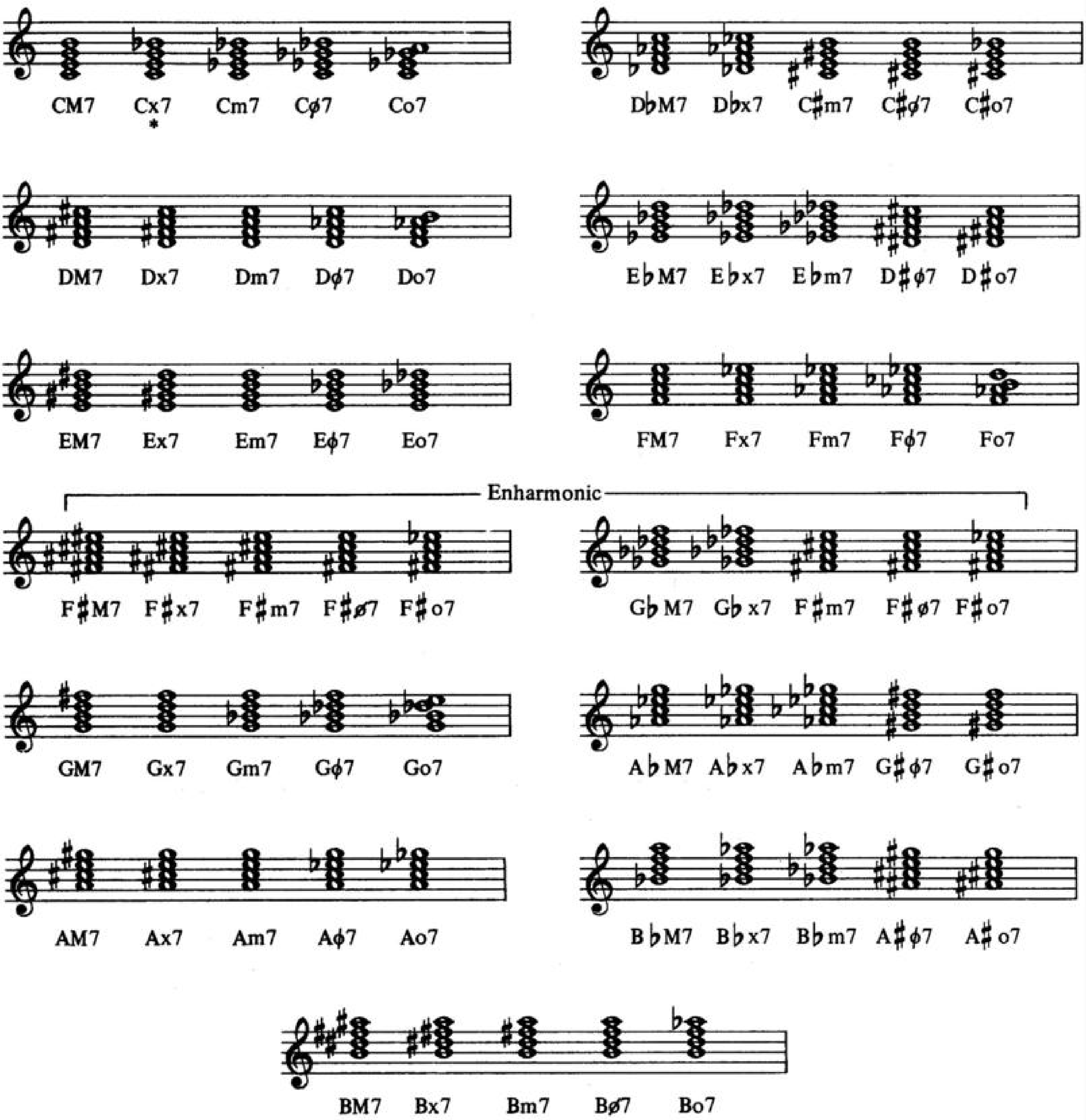


*Note: Although written as C - A, with the m 3rd and o 5th it remains a o7th.



The Sixty Chord System

Fig. 6. illustrates the Sixty Chord System used in jazz harmony. It consists of five different qualities which can be applied at any point on the keyboard.
There are twelve tones in the octave, each capable of supporting the five qualities; thus, the Sixty Chord System.
Transferring to sharps on m, ø, and o is for ease of "spelling" these chords.

Fig. 6

*Note: The use of the symbol x for the dominant chord is explained in the following chapter.

Chapter 4

The Seventh Chord Symbols

The Major Seventh Symbol:

With the exception of the recent use of a triangle symbol (△), the traditional major symbol has always been either M7 or maj7. In this text the symbol M7 will be used.

The Dominant Seventh Symbol:

The traditional dominant symbols have always been 7 or 9 or 13 (C7, F9, etc.). The historical reason for this lay in the harmonic vocabulary of early jazz which employed the major triad, the minor triad, the diminished triad, the augmented triad and a fifth chord which demanded the use of the seventh,thus the 7 chord. Since all the seventh chords contain a seventh of some kind, it is apparent that the symbol 7 is improper. In this text the Juilliard symbol x7 will be used to indicate the dominant chord in any form (Cx7, E♭x7, B♭x9, etc.).

The Minor Seventh Symbol:

The traditional symbols for the minor seventh chord have been m7 or min.7. In this text the symbol m7 will be used.

The Half Diminished Symbol:

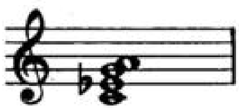
The half diminished symbol is only beginning to enter the public area. Traditionally it has been treated as minor 7♭5(m7-5) or its first inversion minor 6 (m6). The symbol for half diminished is ø7 and will be employed in this text.

The Diminished Seventh Symbol:

The traditional symbols for diminished have been a zero (o) or dim. The text will employ o7 in referring to both intervals and chords.

The Minor Sixth Symbol:

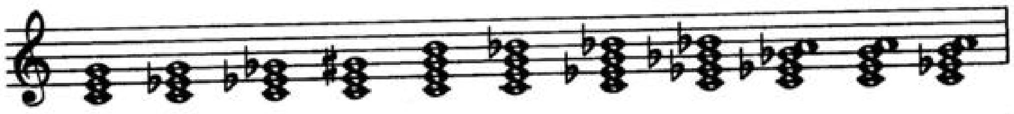
The term minor sixth (m6) can mean different things at various times, e.g. sometimes Cm6 means a minor triad with an added sixth. (See Fig. 1)

Fig. 1

But, in some notation, the term Cm6 can really mean Aø7.Cm6(first inversion of Aø7) is the more familiar approximation of Aø7or Am7♭5. In this text all root position ø7 chords will be indicated as such; the minor sixth chord will appear as minor added sixth (m^{+6}) to avoid confusion with "6" as employed in inversions to be studied later. The same is true of major added sixth (M^{+6}).

Symbol Summary:

M^T = major triad
m^T = minor triad
o^T = diminished triad
\+ = augmented triad
M7 = major seventh
x7 = dominant seventh
m7 = minor seventh
ø7 = half diminished seventh
o7 = diminished seventh
M^{+6} = major added 6th
m^{+6} = minor added 6th

Fig. 2 Key of C



CM^T Cm^T Co^T C+* CM7 Cx7 Cm7 Cø7 Co7 CM^{+6} Cm^{+6}

*Note: The augmented triad is not indicated by "T" since the augmented chord does not appear in the seventh chord system.

See the complete Harmonic Vocabulary in Chapter 8 for further illustration of the total system.

Chapter 5

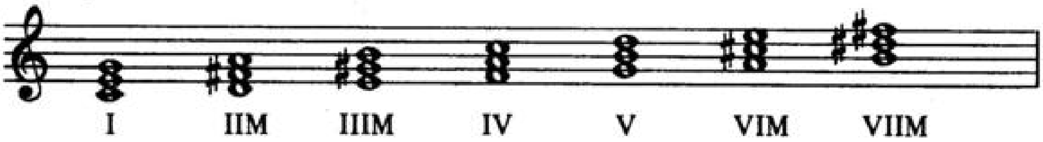
Altered Triads

The triads appearing in Chapter I and the seventh chords in Chapter 2 are shown in their primary functions; in other words, as the scale naturally forms them.
If our use of harmony was limited to these primary functions we would be unable to perform even the simplest jazz material.
Fortunately, the diatonic system readily lends itself to alteration. These alterations sub - divide into secondary functions and tertiary functions.

Secondary Functions:

Rule: A secondary function involves the raising or lowering of the 3rd and/or 5th of a triad; or the 3rd, 5th and/or 7th of a seventh chord to form a new chord or quality on any tone of the scale. (See Fig. 1)

Fig. 1



In Fig. 1 the triads I - IV - V are naturally major;
II - III - VI are minor which required raising the third in each case;
VII is diminished which required raising both third and fifth in order to form major.

The following alteration table **describes the intervals to be altered in order** to form various triad qualities. **(See Fig. 2)**

Fig. 2

Quality		Position
M	I - IV - V	
Alteration: ♯5	♭3	♭3 ♭5
New Quality: +	m	o

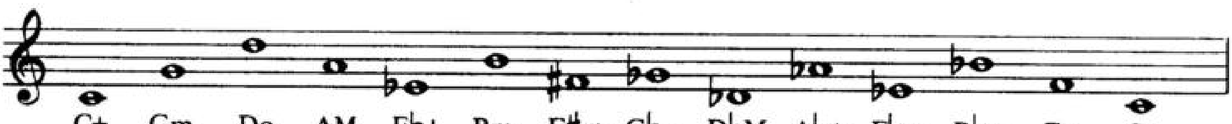
Quality		Position
m	II - III - VI	
Alteration: ♯3 ♯5	♯3	♭5
New Quality: +	M	o

Quality		Position
o	VII	
Alteration: ♯3 𝄪5	♯3 ♯5	♯5
New Quality: +	M	m

Quality		Position
+		none
Alteration: ♭5	♭3 ♭5	♭3 ♭♭5
New Quality: M	m	o

n:

Complete the following triad qualities. Check your result against the Harmonic Vocabulary in Chapter 8.



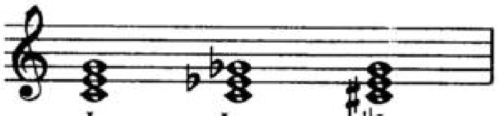
C+ Gm Do AM E♭+ Bm F♯m G♭o D♭M A♭+ E♭m B♭o F+ Co

Tertiary Functions:

Rule:

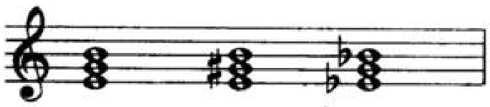
A tertiary function involves raising or lowering an altered or unaltered chord chromatically out of the key. (See Fig. 4)

Key of C



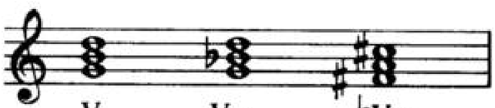
I Io ♯Io

(secondary) (tertiary)



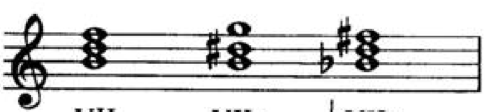
III IIIM ♭IIIM

(secondary) (tertiary)



V Vm ♭Vm

(secondary) (tertiary)



VII VII+ ♭VII+

(secondary) (tertiary)

Rule:

In the chromatic harmonic system of jazz any chord can be built on any tone in the chromatic scale by altering, lowering or raising any chord in the diatonic system.

Chapter 6

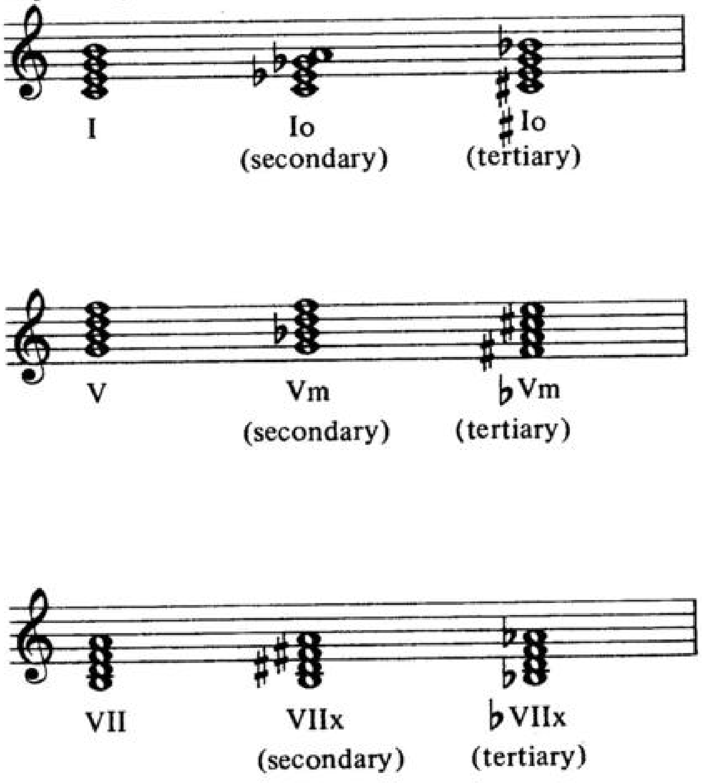
Altered Seventh Chords

Triad harmony is used extensively in rock, country music and folk music as it was in Dixieland jazz from 1900 to 1920. In this period the only 7th chord employed was the dominant 7th but, gradually, through the twenties and into the early thirties, the seventh chord system began to replace the triad system until by 1934, with the development of the Goodman and Ellington bands, the seventh chord system with its extensive use of 9ths, 11ths and 13ths became the lasting language of jazz.

Secondary and Tertiary Functions:

As indicated in Chapter 5, the secondary and tertiary functions are formed by altering the 3rd, 5th and/or 7th or by lowering or raising the chord chromatically. See Fig. 1.

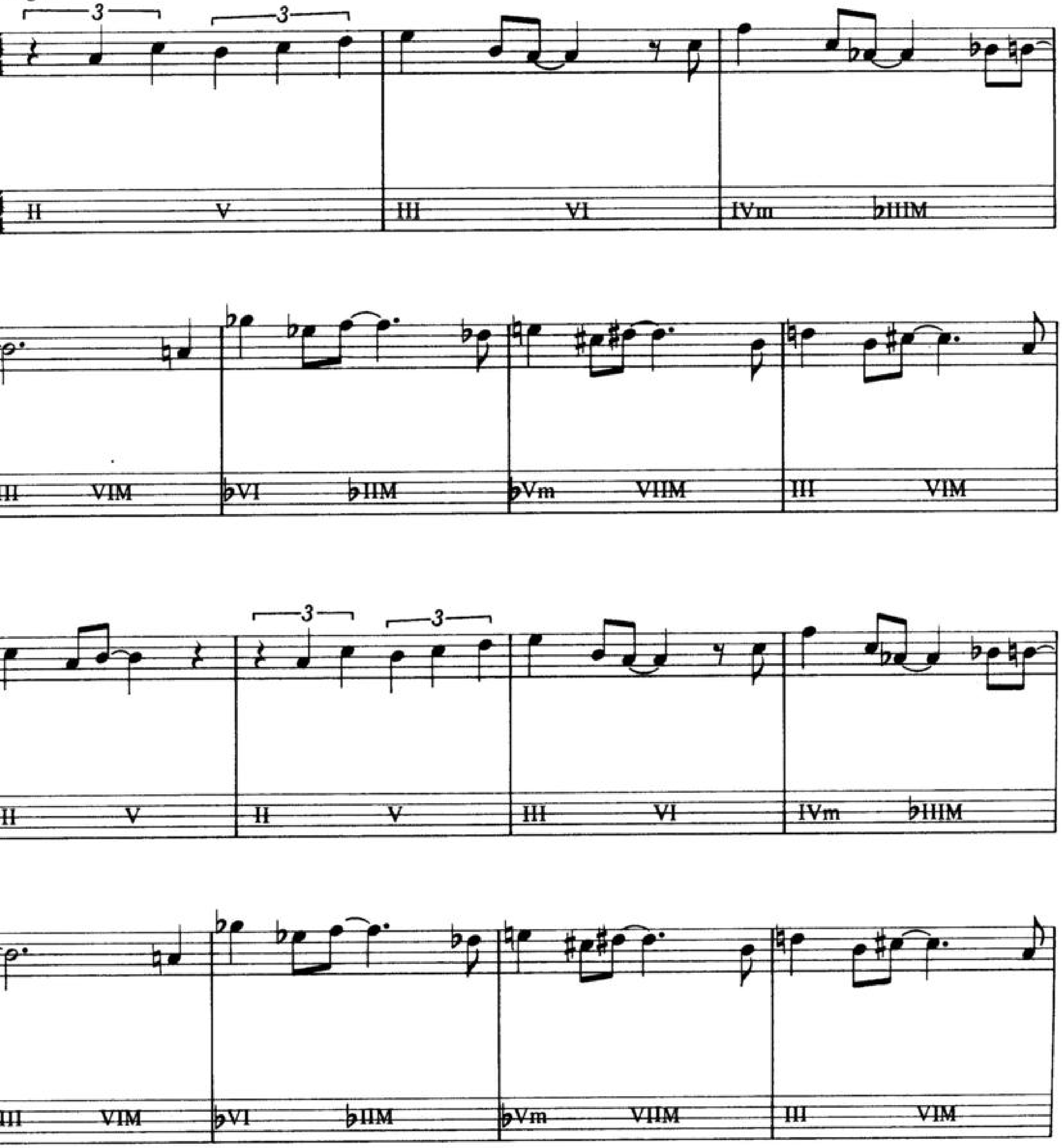
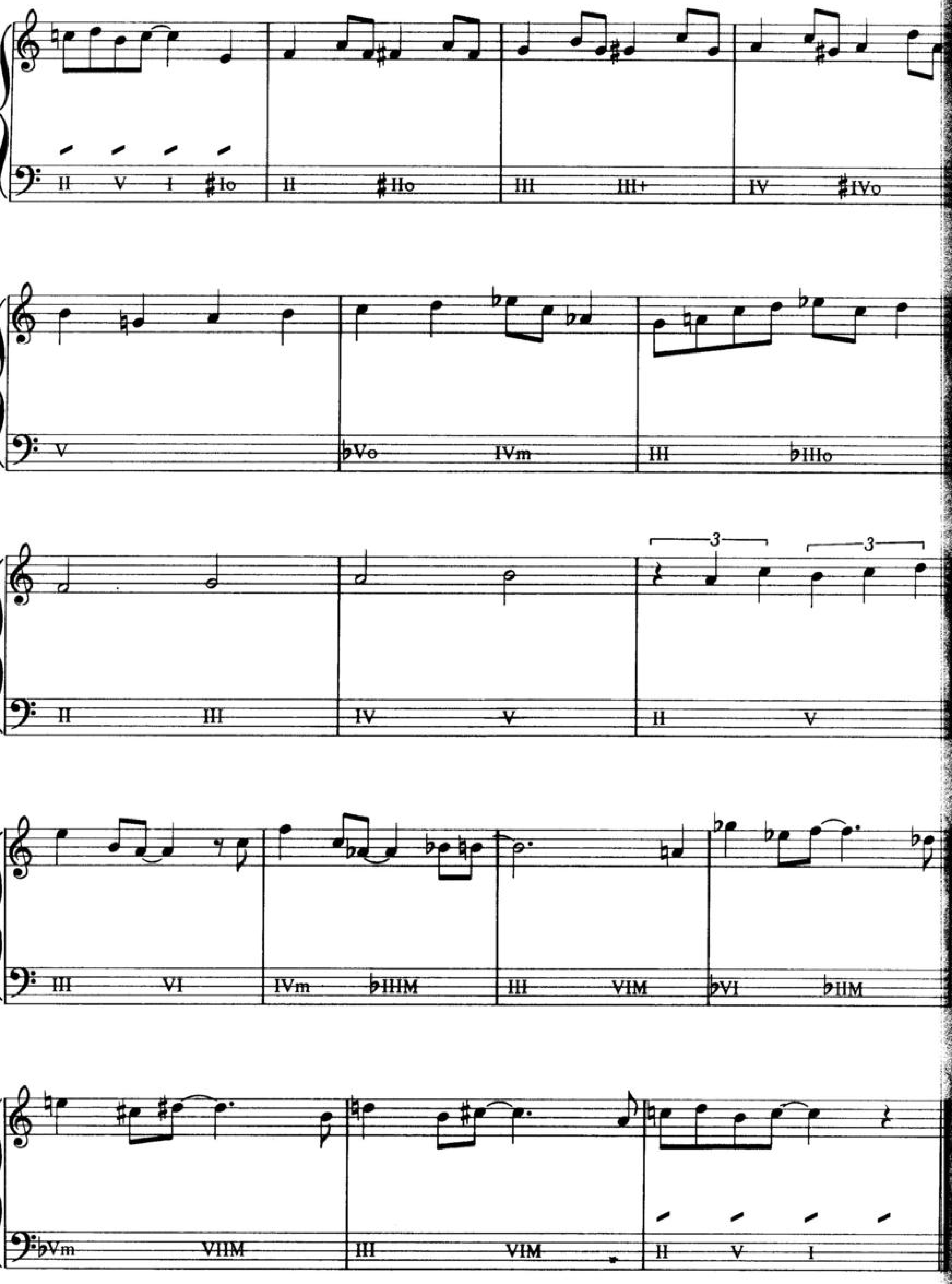
Fig. 1 Key of C



on:

Fig. 5 is an original tune employing the triad chromatic harmonic system.
The use of the symbol T will not be necessary since the piece consists entirely of triads.
Practice Fig. 5 until it can be played without hesitation.

Fig. 5




II V I #IIo
II #IIo
III III+
IV #IVo
V
bVo IVm
III bIIIo
II III
IV V
3 3
II V
III VI
IVm bIIIM
III VIM
bVI bIIM
bVm VIIM
III VIM
II V I

The following alteration table describes the intervals to be altered in order to form various seventh chord qualities.

Fig. 2

Quality M7 — Position I - IV

Alteration	♭7	♭3 ♭7	♭3 ♭5 ♭7	♭3 ♭5 ♭♭7
New Quality	x7	m7	ø7	o7

Quality x7 — Position V

Alteration	♯7	♭3	♭3 ♭5	♭3 ♭5 ♭7
New Quality	M7	m7	ø7	o7

Quality m7 — Position II - III - VI

Alteration	♯3 ♯7	♯3	♭5	♭5 ♭7
New Quality	M7	x7	ø7	o7

Quality ø7 — Position VII

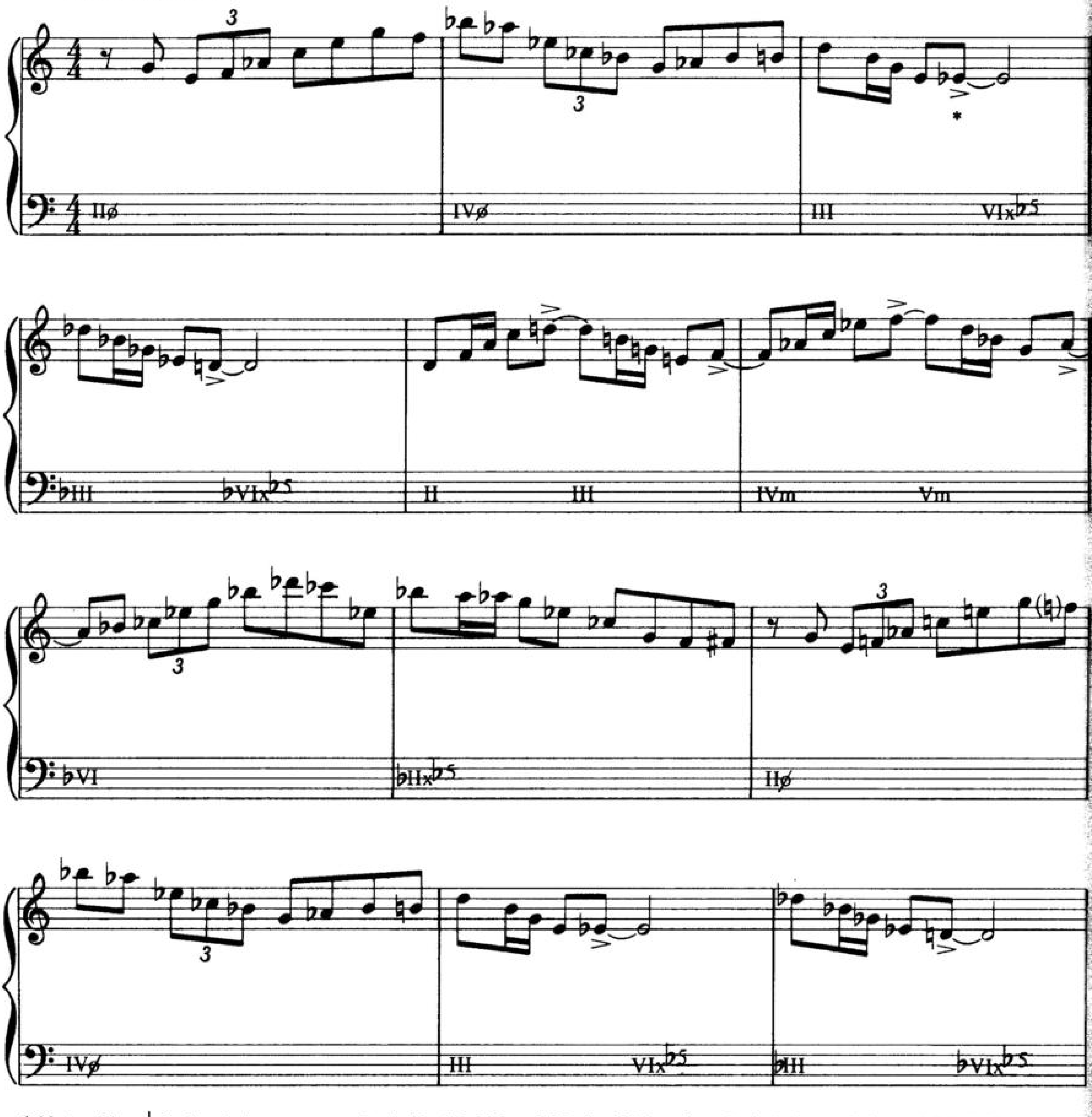
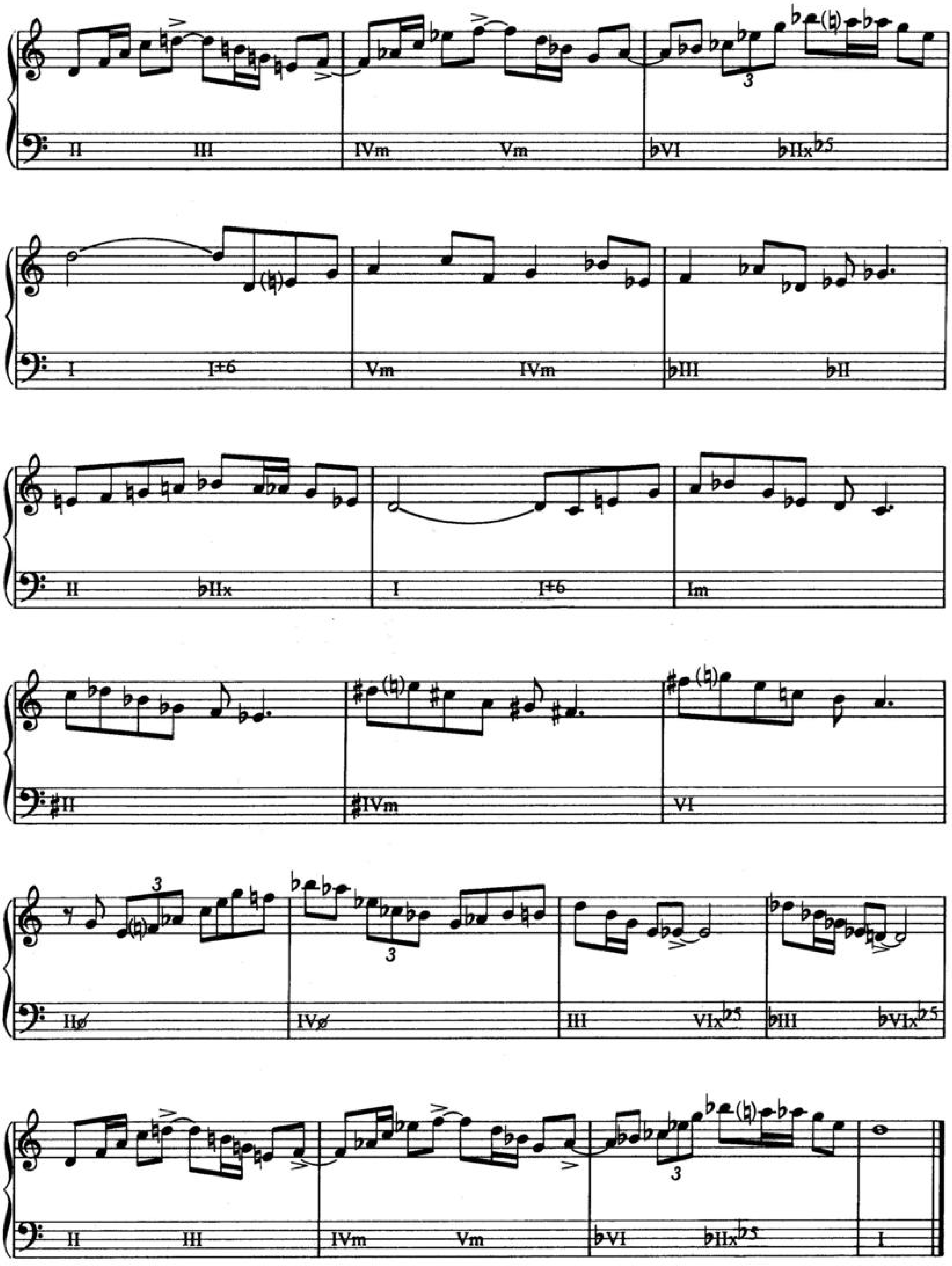
Alteration	♯3 ♯5 ♯7	♯3 ♯5	♯5	♭7
New Quality	M7	x7	m7	o7

Quality o7 — Position none

Alteration	♯3 ♯5 𝄪7	♯3 ♯5 ♯7	♯5 ♯7	♯7
New Quality	M7	x7	m7	ø7

Lesson:

Fig. 3 is an original tune employing the seventh chord chromatic harmonic system.
The use of the Arabic numeral 7 will not be necessary since there are no triads in the piece.
Practice Fig. 3 until it can be played without hesitation.

Fig. 3 Key of C

* Note: The x♭5 chords in measures 3, 4, 11, 12, 27 and 28 should be played with the anticipated (tied) figures; also the m chords in measures 5, 6, 13, 14, 29 and 30.


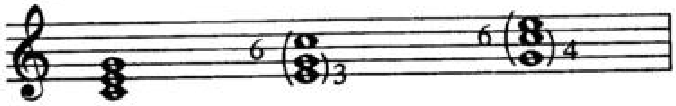
II III IVm Vm ♭VI ♭IIx♭5
I I+6 Vm IVm ♭III ♭II
II ♭IIx I I+6 Im
♯II ♯IVm VI
IIø IVø III VIx♭5 ♭III ♭VIx♭5
II III IVm Vm ♭VI ♭IIx♭5 I

Chapter 7

Inversions

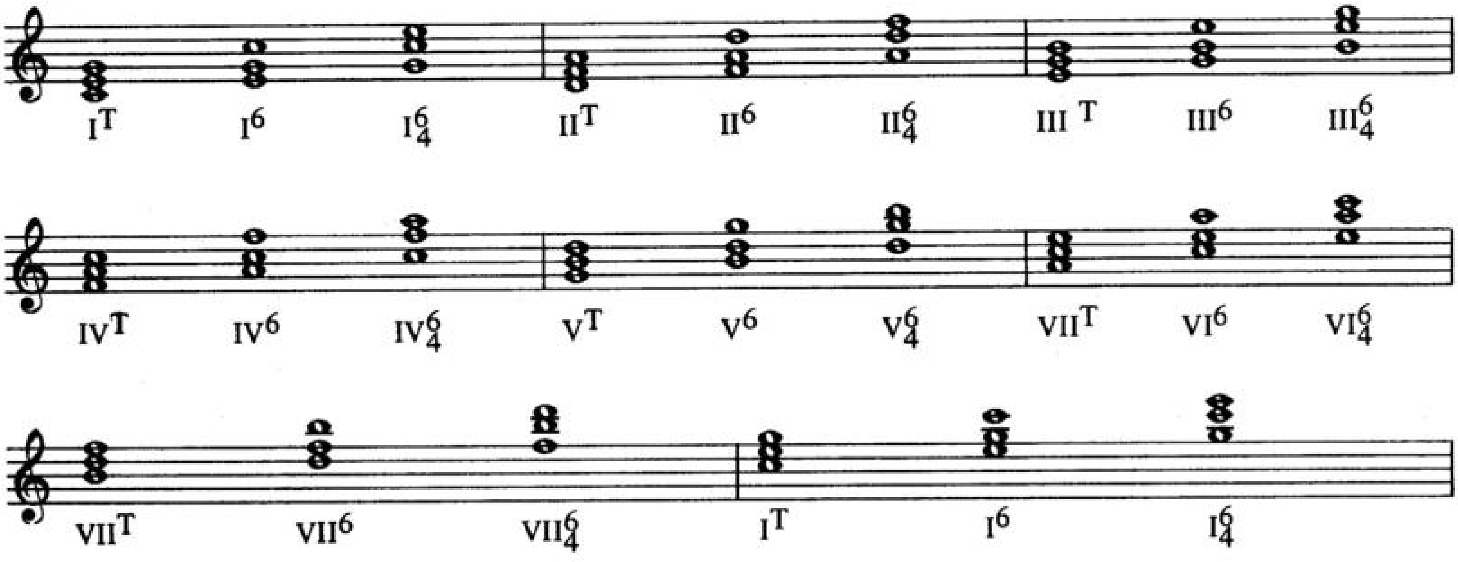
Inversions (Triads)

An inversion results from re-arranging the tones of a chord in such a way that the root of the chord is no longer in the bass. (See Fig. 1)

Fig. 1 Key of C

Root position 1st inversion 2nd inversion

The traditional symbols for triad inversions are formed by counting the number of scale tones from the bass note to each of the remaining tones in the chord.Thus, in Fig. 1 the distance from E to C in the first inversion is a 6th; the distance from E to G is a 3rd. Thus, the symbol for first inversion is $^{6}_{3}$ or, more usually, 6. In the second inversion the distance from G to E is a 6th; the distance from G to C is a 4th. Thus the symbol for second inversion is $^{6}_{4}$ and that is never modified. Fig. 2 illustrates the triads of C with their inversions.

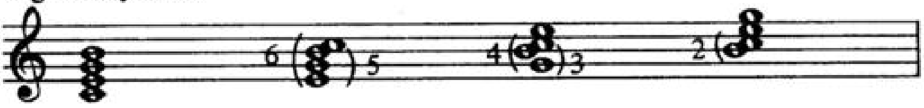
Fig. 2 Scale-tone triads of C and their inversions.



Lesson: Practice the scale-tone triads and their inversions in twelve keys - both hands.

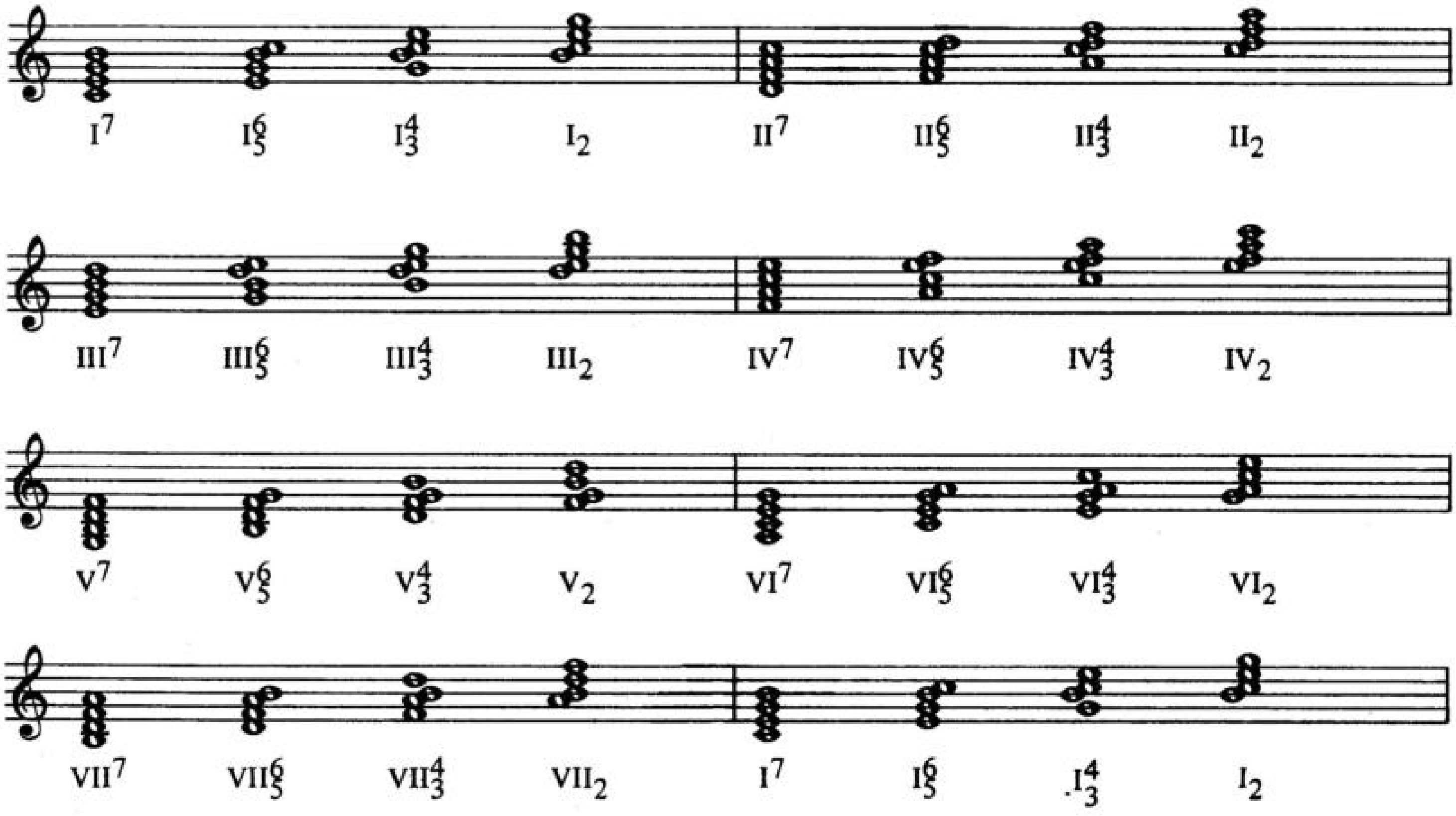
Inversions (Seventh Chords)

Fig. 3 Key of C



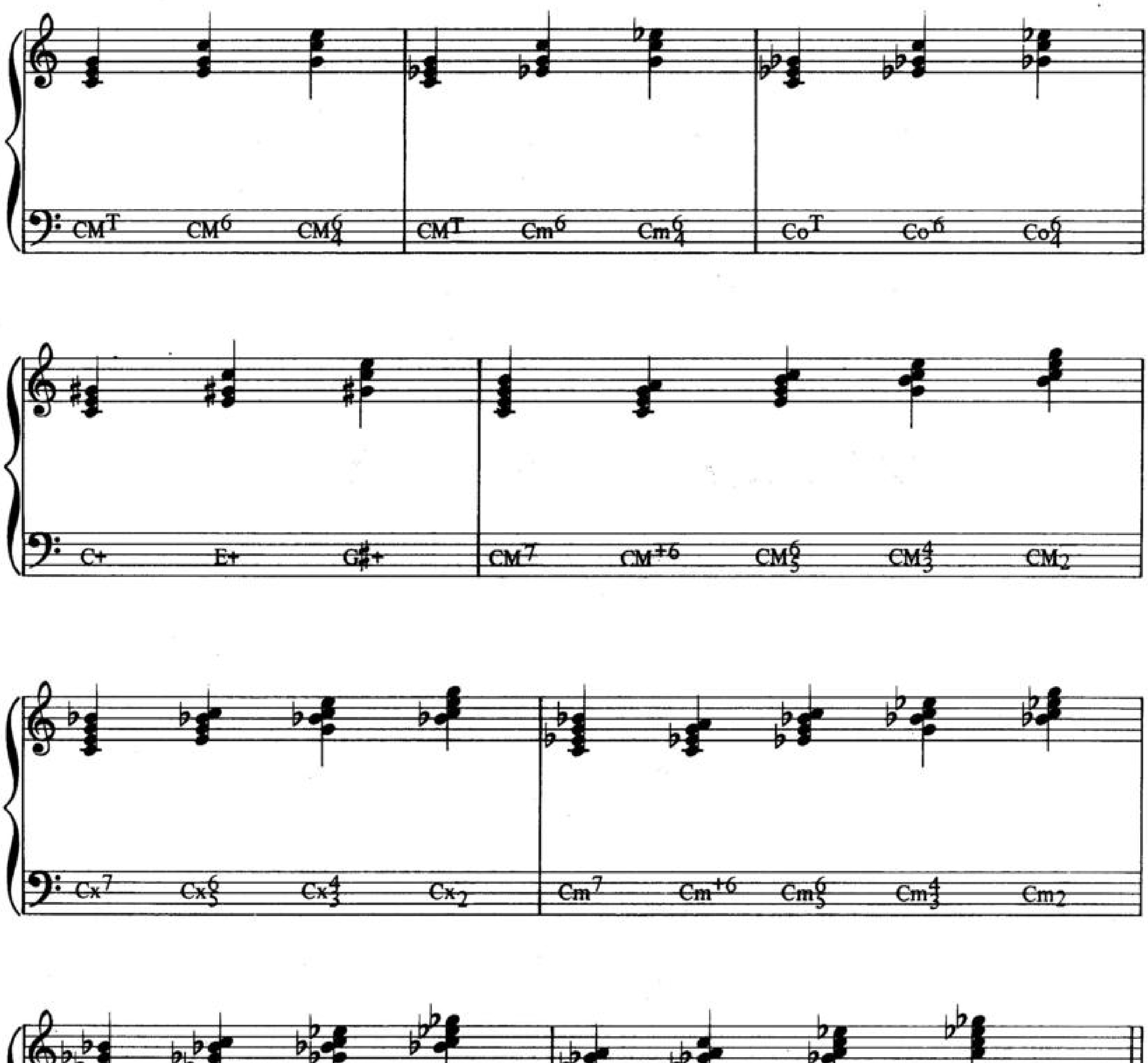
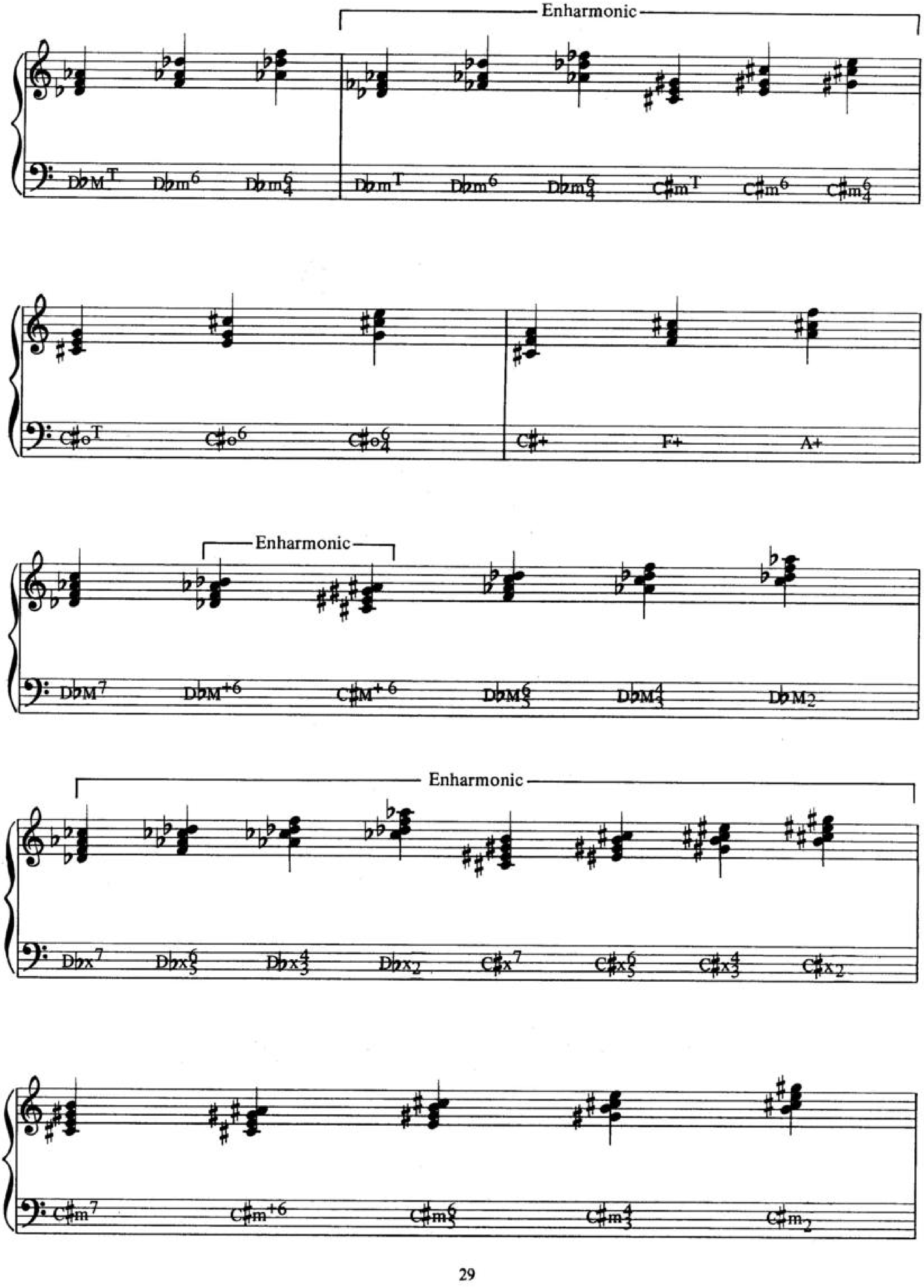
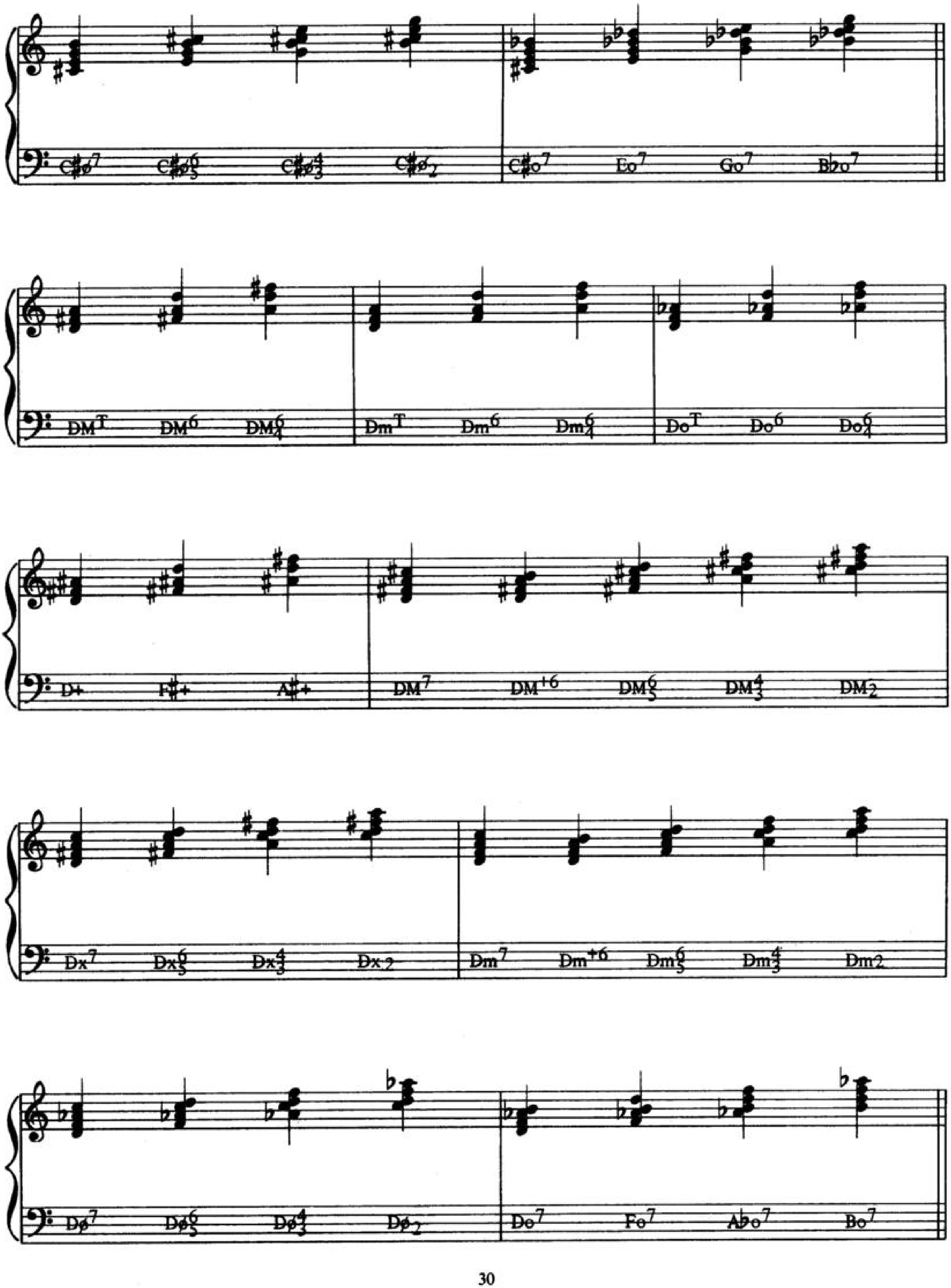
Root position 1st inversion 2nd inversion 3rd inversion

Each inversion of a seventh chord contains an interval of a second (B - C in Fig.3).The symbol for the inversion is formed by counting the scale - tones from the bass note to each of the notes of the second. Thus, in Fig. 3, in the first inversion, E to C is a 6th; E to B is a 5th. Thus, the symbol is $^6_5$. In the second inversion, G to C is a 4th; G to B is a 3rd. Thus, the symbol is $^4_3$. In the third inversion B to C is a 2nd. Thus, the symbol is 2.
Fig. 4 illustrates the seventh chords of C with their inversions.

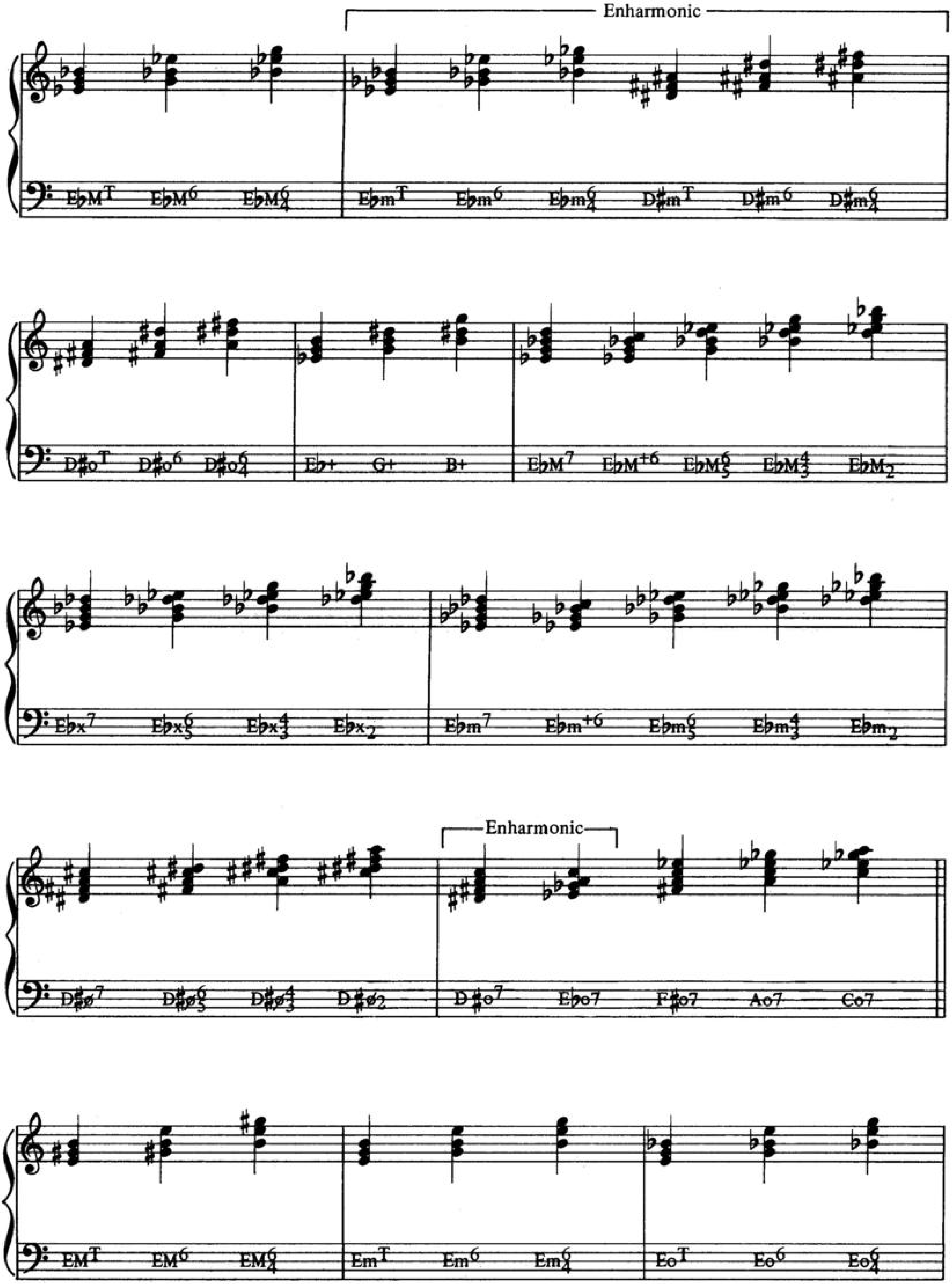
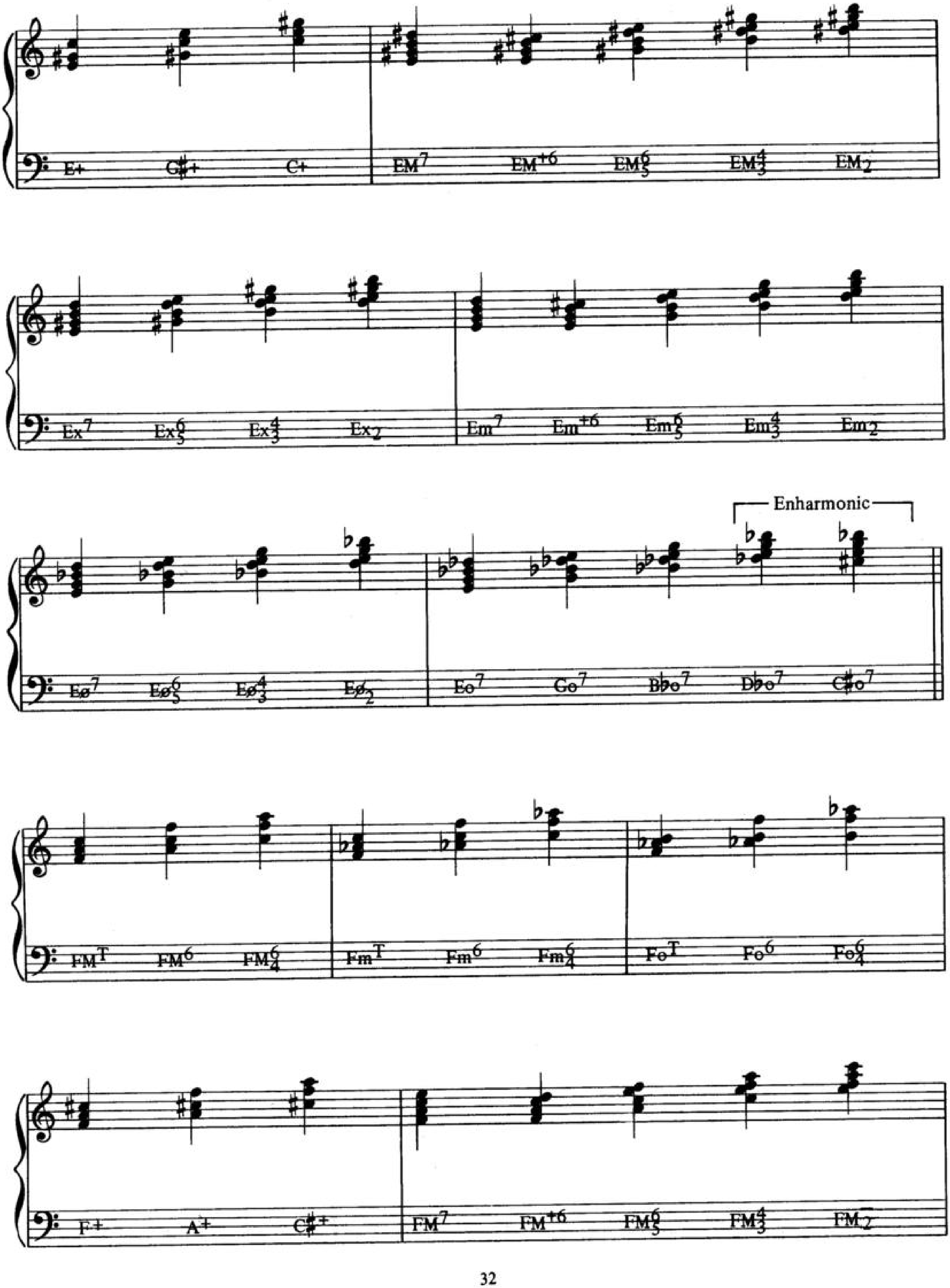
Fig. 4 Scale - tone seventh chords of C with their inversions.

Lesson: Practice the scale-tone seventh chords and their inversions in twelve keys - both hands.

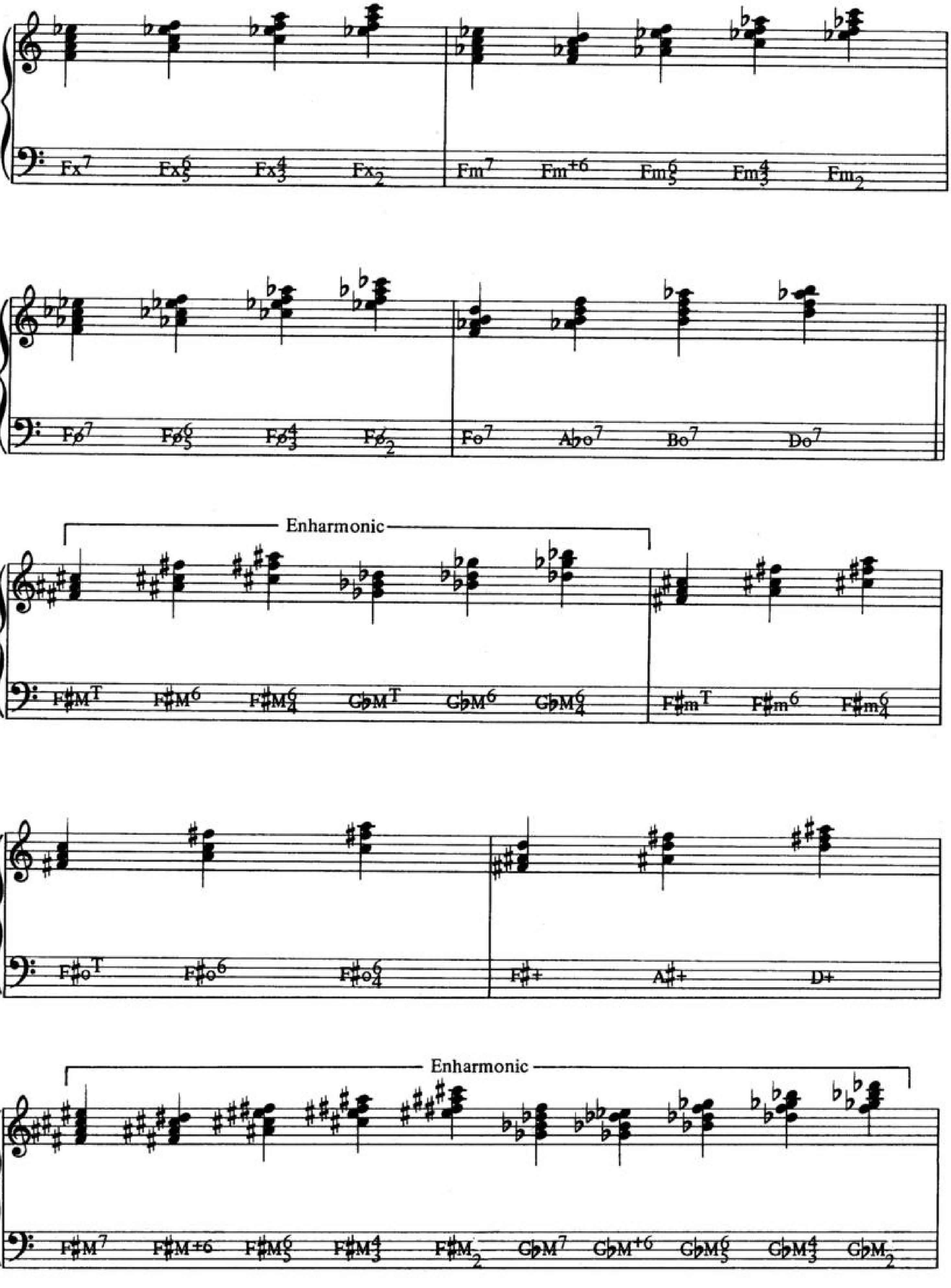
Note: The student will note in Chapter 8 that the diminished seventh chord cannot be inverted since the tones are evenly spaced by minor thirds and no tone is adjacent to another. Of all the chords we have studied only the diminished seventh never loses its original intervals.

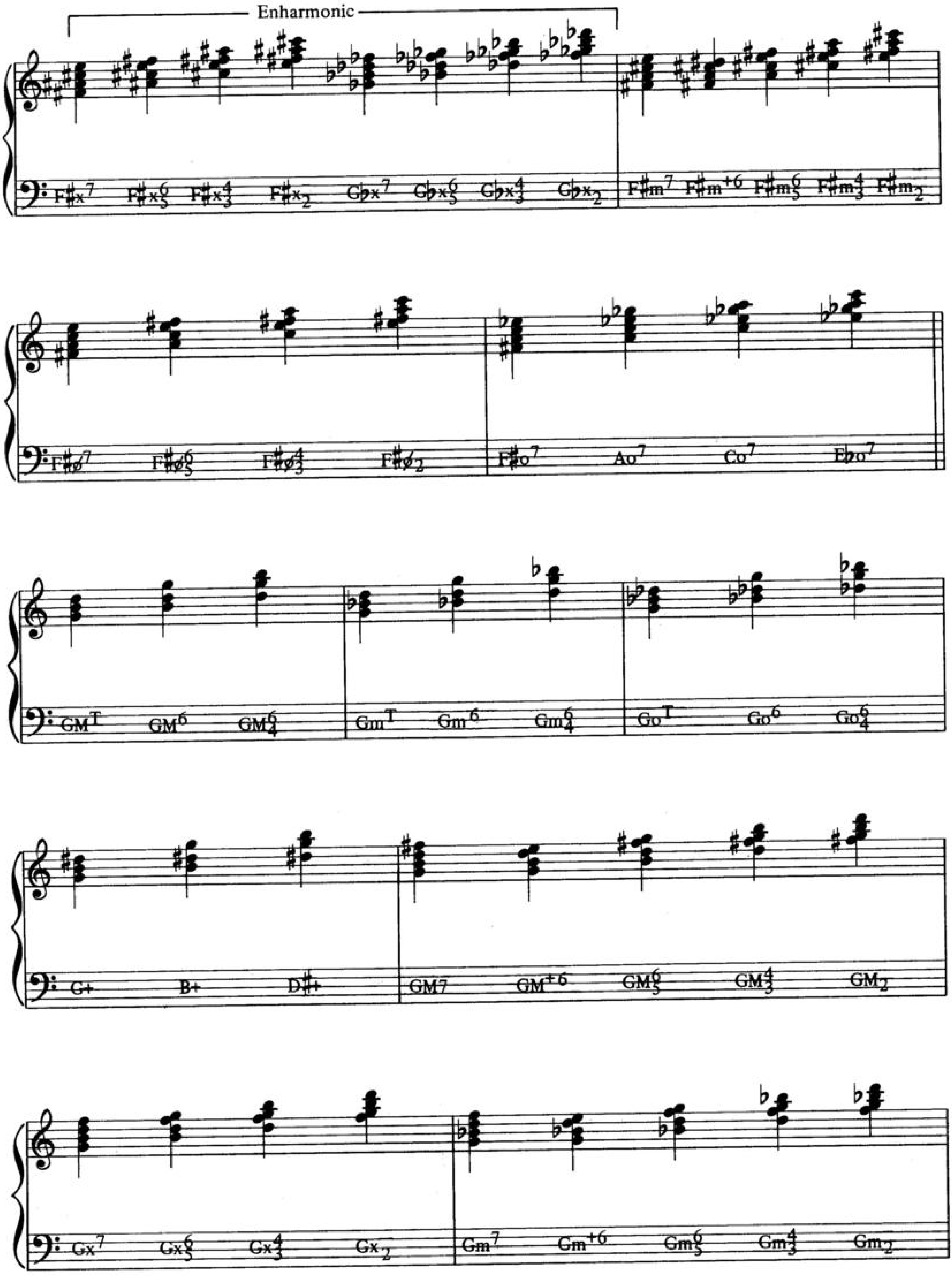
Chapter 8

The Harmonic Vocabulary


Enharmonic
D♭MT D♭m6 D♭m64 D♭mT D♭m6 D♭m64 C♯mT C♯m6 C♯m64
C♯oT C♯o6 C♯o64 C♯+ F+ A+
Enharmonic
D♭M7 D♭M+6 C♯M+6 D♭M65 D♭M43 D♭M2
Enharmonic
D♭x7 D♭x65 D♭x43 D♭x2 C♯x7 C♯x65 C♯x43 C♯x2
C♯m7 C♯m+6 C♯m65 C♯m43 C♯m2


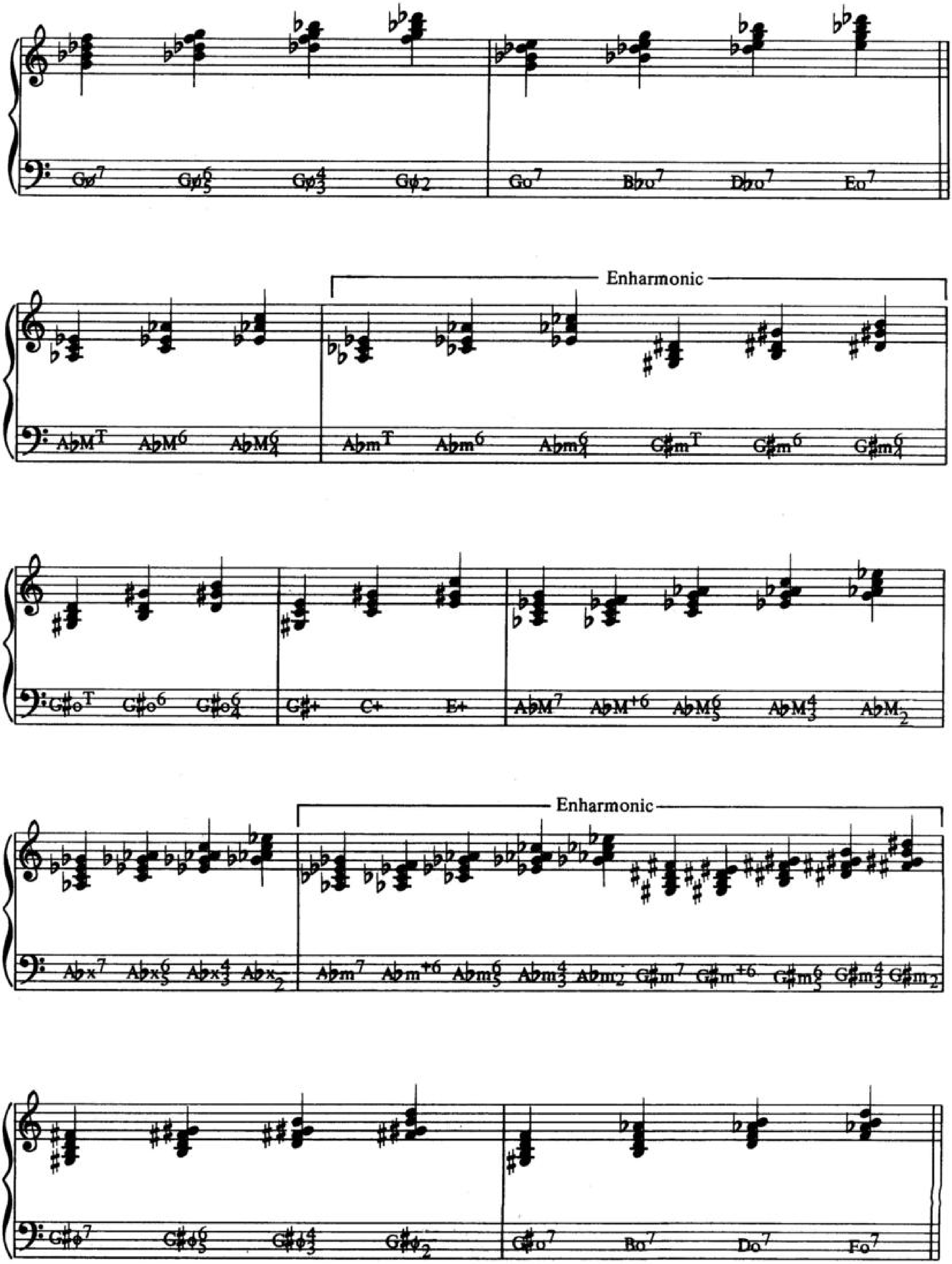
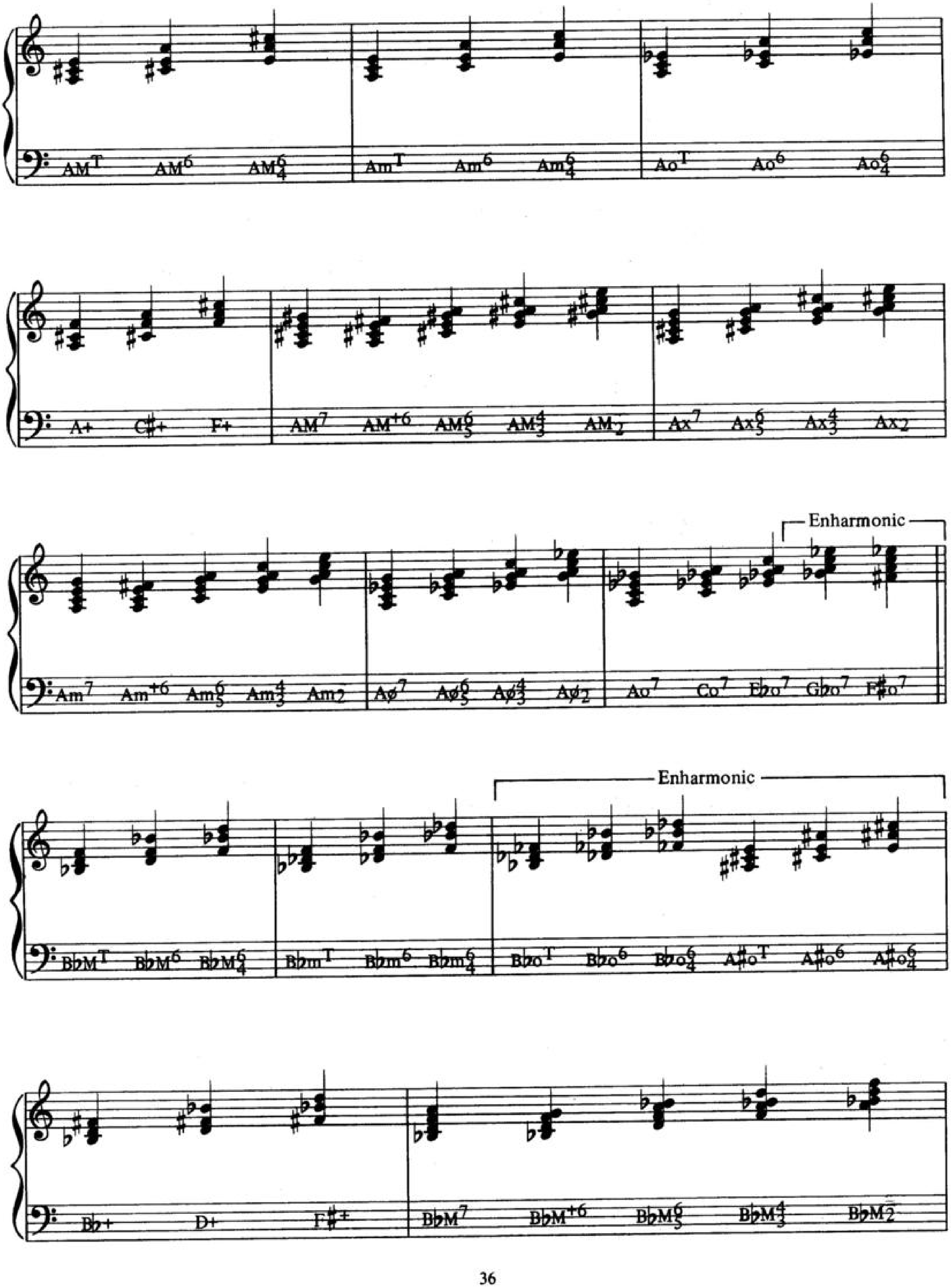
C♯ø7 C♯ø6/5 C♯ø4/3 C♯ø2
C♯o7 Eo7 Go7 B♭o7
DMT DM6 DM6/4
DmT Dm6 Dm6/4
DoT Do6 Do6/4
D+ F♯+ A♯+
DM7 DM+6 DM6/5 DM4/3 DM2
Dx7 Dx6/5 Dx4/3 Dx2
Dm7 Dm+6 Dm6/5 Dm4/3 Dm2
Dø7 Dø6/5 Dø4/3 Dø2
Do7 Fo7 A♭o7 Bo7

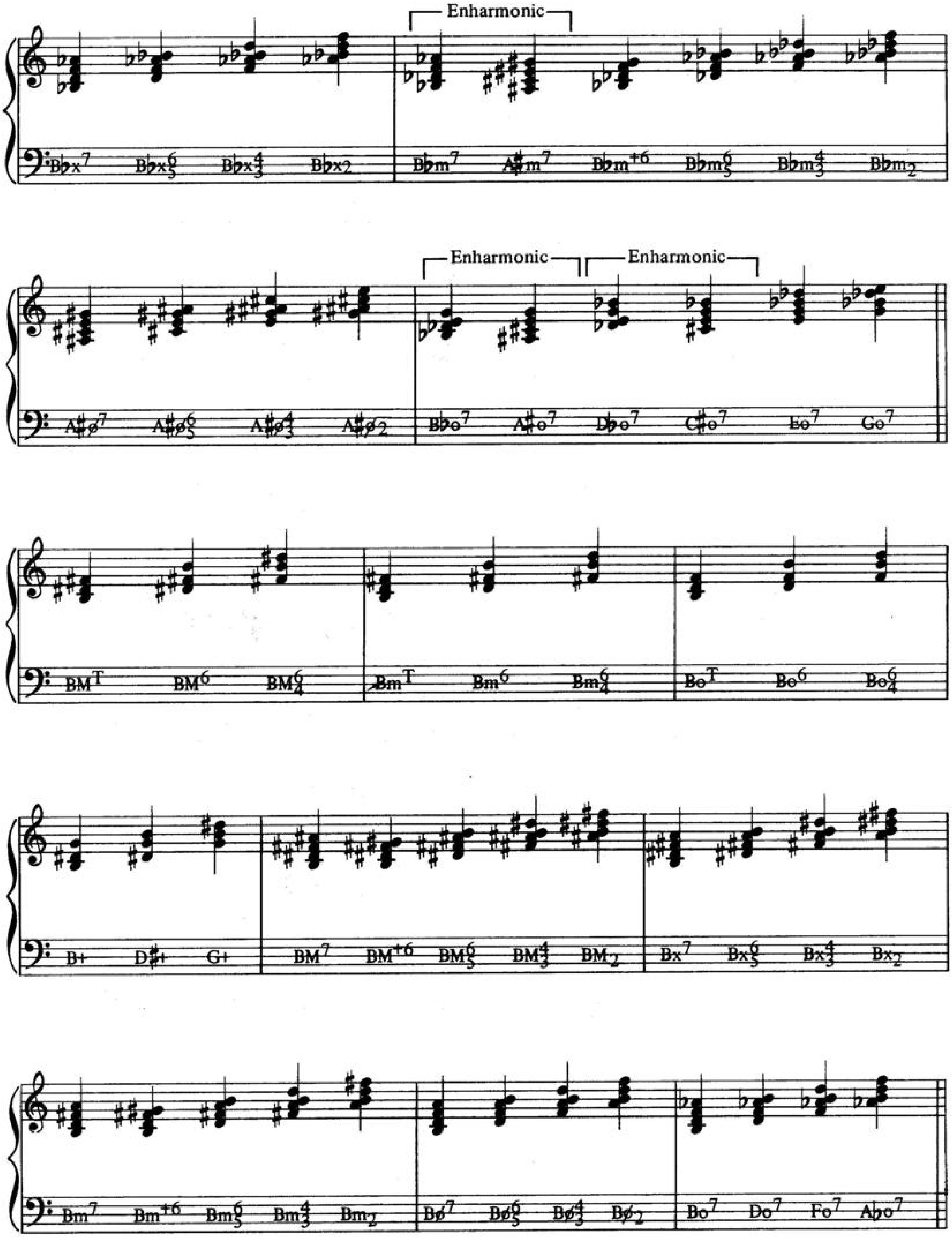

Enharmonic
E♭MT E♭M6 E♭M6/4 E♭mT E♭m6 E♭m6/4 D♯mT D♯m6 D♯m6/4
D♯oT D♯o6 D♯o6/4 E♭+ G+ B+ E♭M7 E♭M+6 E♭M6/5 E♭M4/3 E♭M2
E♭x7 E♭x6/5 E♭x4/3 E♭x2 E♭m7 E♭m+6 E♭m6/5 E♭m4/3 E♭m2
Enharmonic
D♯ø7 D♯ø6/5 D♯ø4/3 D♯ø2 D♯o7 E♭o7 F♯o7 Ao7 Co7
EMT EM6 EM6/4 EmT Em6 Em6/4 EoT Eo6 Eo6/4


E+ G♯+ C+
EM7 EM+6 EM6/5 EM4/3 EM2
Ex7 Ex6/5 Ex4/3 Ex2
Em7 Em+6 Em6/5 Em4/3 Em2
Enharmonic
Eø7 Eø6/5 Eø4/3 Eø2
Eo7 Go7 B♭♭o7 D♭♭o7 C♯o7
FMT FM6 FM6/4
FmT Fm6 Fm6/4
FoT Fo6 Fo6/4
F+ A+ C♯+
FM7 FM+6 FM6/5 FM4/3 FM2


Fx7 Fx6 5 Fx4 3 Fx2
Fm7 Fm+6 Fm6 5 Fm4 3 Fm2
Fø7 Fø6 5 Fø4 3 Fø2
Fo7 A♭o7 Bo7 Do7
Enharmonic
F♯MT F♯M6 F♯M6 4 G♭MT G♭M6 G♭M6 4
F♯mT F♯m6 F♯m6 4
F♯oT F♯o6 F♯o6 4
F♯+ A♯+ D+
Enharmonic
F♯M7 F♯M+6 F♯M6 5 F♯M4 3 F♯M2 G♭M7 G♭M+6 G♭M6 5 G♭M4 3 G♭M2


Enharmonic
F♯x7 F♯x6/5 F♯x4/3 F♯x2 G♭x7 G♭x6/5 G♭x4/3 G♭x2
F♯m7 F♯m+6 F♯m6/5 F♯m4/3 F♯m2
F♯ø7 F♯ø6/5 F♯ø4/3 F♯ø2
F♯o7 Ao7 Co7 E♭o7
GMT GM6 GM6/4
GmT Gm6 Gm6/4
GoT Go6 Go6/4
G+ B+ D♯+
GM7 GM+6 GM6/5 GM4/3 GM2
Gx7 Gx6/5 Gx4/3 Gx2
Gm7 Gm+6 Gm6/5 Gm4/3 Gm2


Gø7 Gø6/5 Gø4/3 Gø2 Go7 B♭o7 D♭o7 Eo7
Enharmonic
A♭MT A♭M6 A♭M6/4 A♭mT A♭m6 A♭m6/4 G♯mT G♯m6 G♯m6/4
G♯oT G♯o6 G♯o6/4 G♯+ C+ E+ A♭M7 A♭M+6 A♭M6/5 A♭M4/3 A♭M2
Enharmonic
A♭x7 A♭x6/5 A♭x4/3 A♭x2 A♭m7 A♭m+6 A♭m6/5 A♭m4/3 A♭m2 G♯m7 G♯m+6 G♯m6/5 G♯m4/3 G♯m2
G♯ø7 G♯ø6/5 G♯ø4/3 G♯ø2 G♯o7 Bo7 Do7 Fo7


AMT AM6 AM64 Am T Am6 Am64 AoT Ao6 Ao64
A+ C#+ F+ AM7 AM+6 AM65 AM43 AM2 Ax7 Ax65 Ax43 Ax2
Enharmonic
Am7 Am+6 Am65 Am43 Am2 Aø7 Aø65 Aø43 Aø2 Ao7 Co7 Ebo7 Gbo7 F#o7
Enharmonic
BbMT BbM6 BbM64 BbmT Bbm6 Bbm64 BboT Bbo6 Bbo64 A#oT A#o6 A#o64
Bb+ D+ F#+ BbM7 BbM+6 BbM65 BbM43 BbM2

Note: From this point onward the use of the Arabic numeral 7 will no longer be necessary. All chords are seventh chords unless indicated otherwise.

Chapter 9

Jazz Rhythm

Improvisation in both Western and Eastern music has flourished for centuries; only since 1900 has improvisation in Western classical music declined, coinciding with the rise of jazz improvisation - a unique fusion of African rhythm and European harmony.

These unique qualities of jazz improvisation lie in the following:

1. The African device of accenting unstressed portions of the bar.
2. The specific rhythmic assignments usually employed as follows:

Rhythmic unit = Quarter note (♩)
Harmonic unit = Quarter note (♩)
Half note (𝅗𝅥)
Whole note (𝅝)

Melodic unit = Eighth notes (♫)
Eighth note triplets (♪♪♪)
Sixteenth notes (♬♬),
Sixteenth note triplets (𝅘𝅥𝅯𝅘𝅥𝅯𝅘𝅥𝅯 𝅘𝅥𝅯𝅘𝅥𝅯𝅘𝅥𝅯)

The following historical treatments of the twelve - bar blues will illustrate how each style has employed these three units.

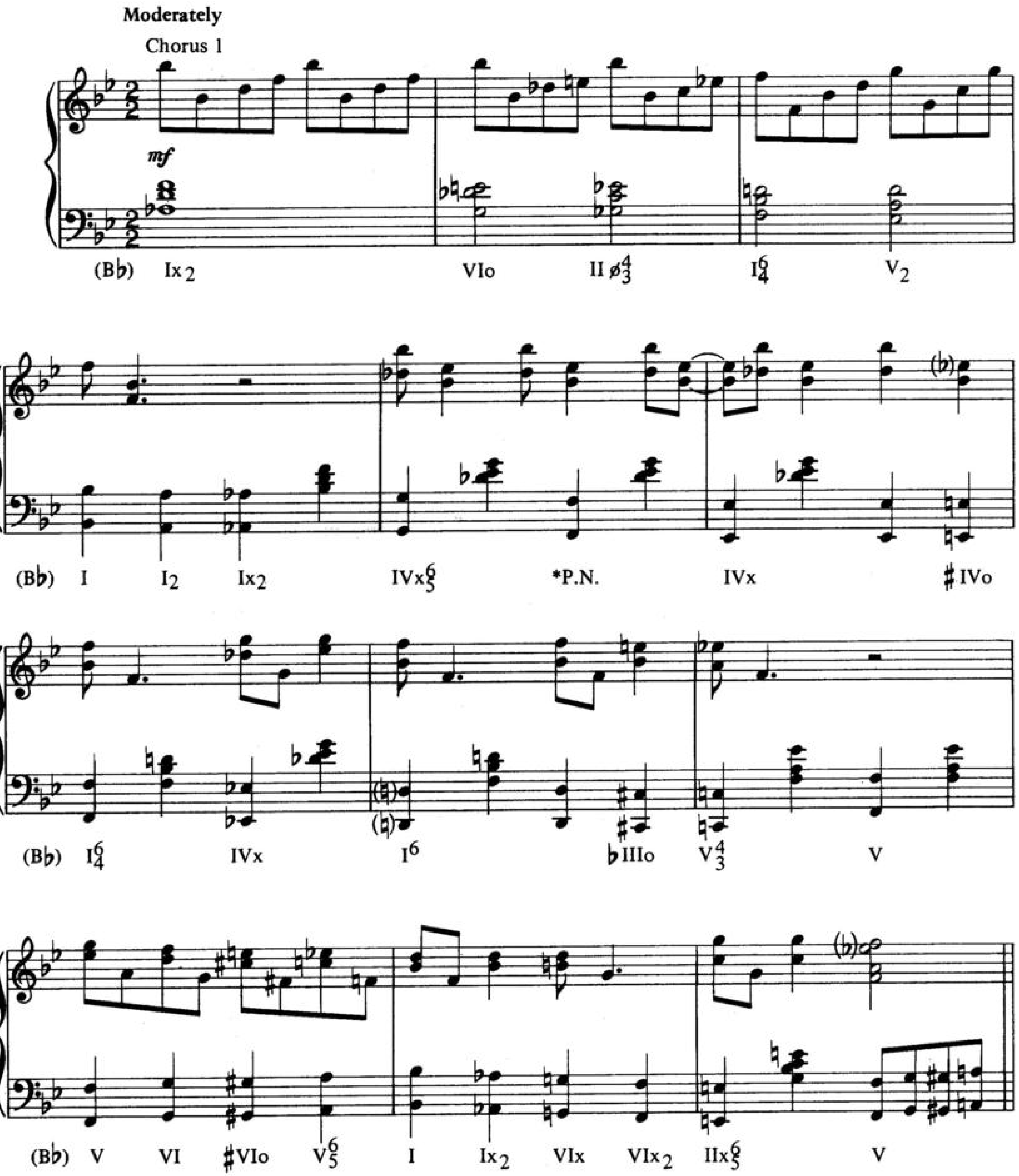
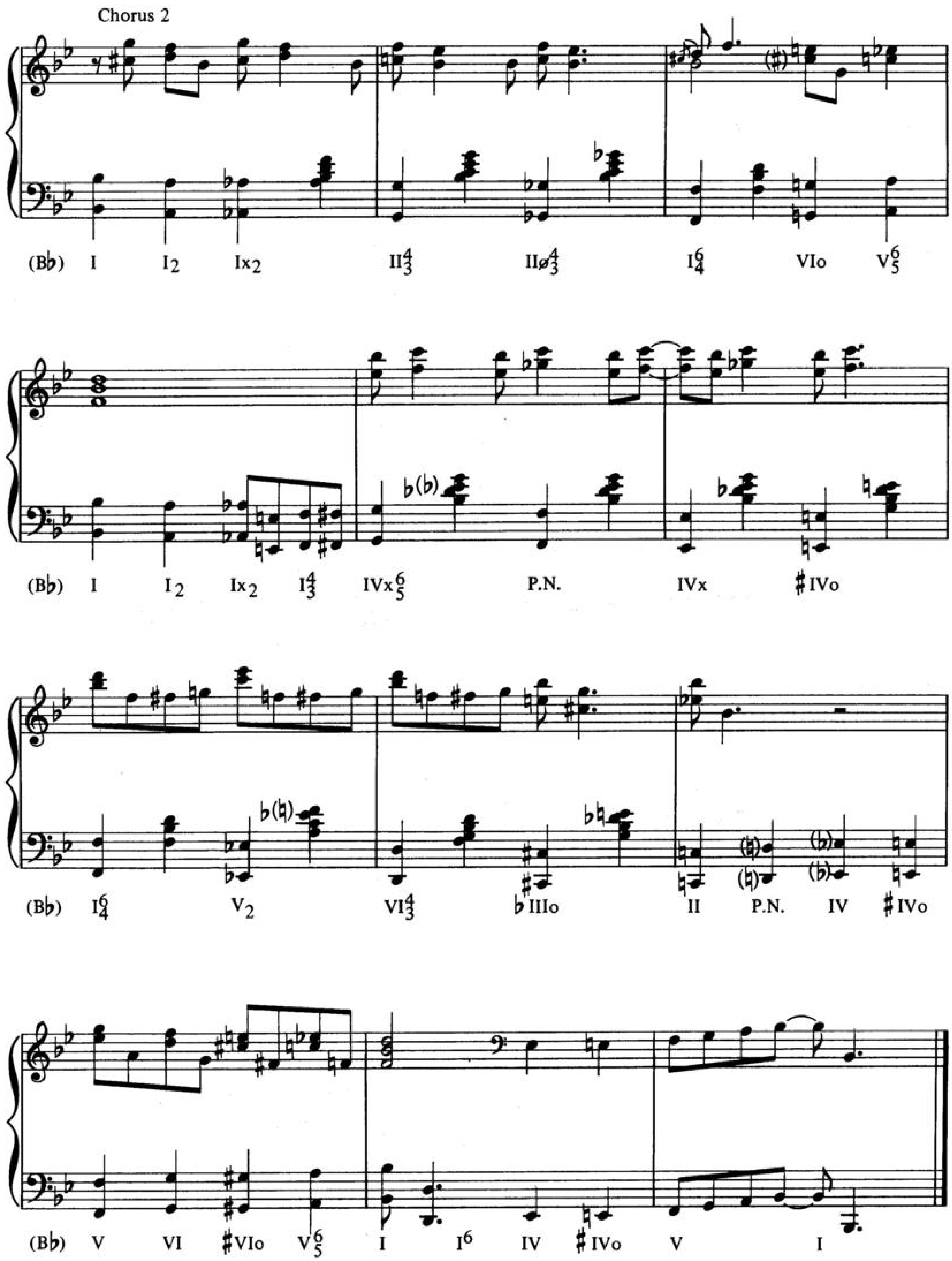
Chapter 10

Ragtime/Stride Piano
1900 - 1920

Rhythmic unit = ♩ (swing bass octaves)
Harmonic unit = ♩ and 𝅗𝅥 (combination of 𝅗𝅥 swing bass and ♩ "walk" bars)
Melodic unit = ♩ and ♫

The student is encouraged to seek out recordings of the following practitioners of this style:

"Jelly Roll" Morton
James P. Johnson
Willie "The Lion" Smith
"Fats" Waller (early)
Tom Turpin
James Scott
Scott Joplin

Fig. I. Key of B♭

* P.N. = passing note


Chorus 2
(B♭) I I2 Ix2 II4/3 IIø4/3 I6/4 VIo V6/5
(B♭) I I2 Ix2 I4/3 IVx6/5 P.N. IVx ♯IVo
(B♭) I6/4 V2 VI4/3 ♭IIIo II P.N. IV ♯IVo
(B♭) V VI ♯VIo V6/5 I I6 IV ♯IVo V I

Swing Piano
1920 - 1940

Rhythmic unit = ♩(swing bass tenths)

Harmonic unit = ♩and 𝅗𝅥 (combination of 𝅗𝅥 swing bass and ♩ "walk" bars

Melodic unit =  and

The student is encouraged to seek out recordings of the following stylists of this period:

"Fats" Waller (middle, late periods)
Earl Hines
Art Tatum
Teddy Wilson

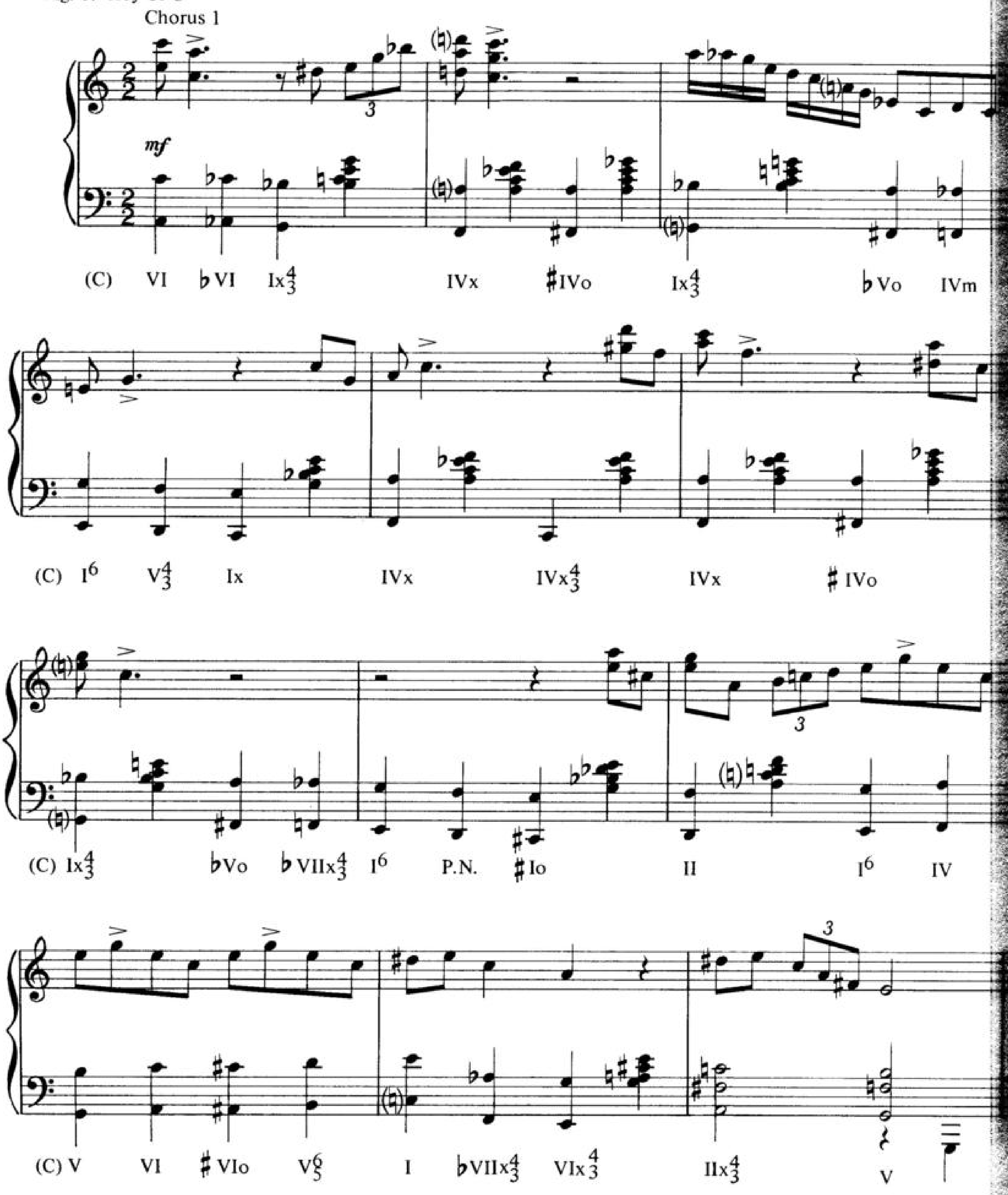
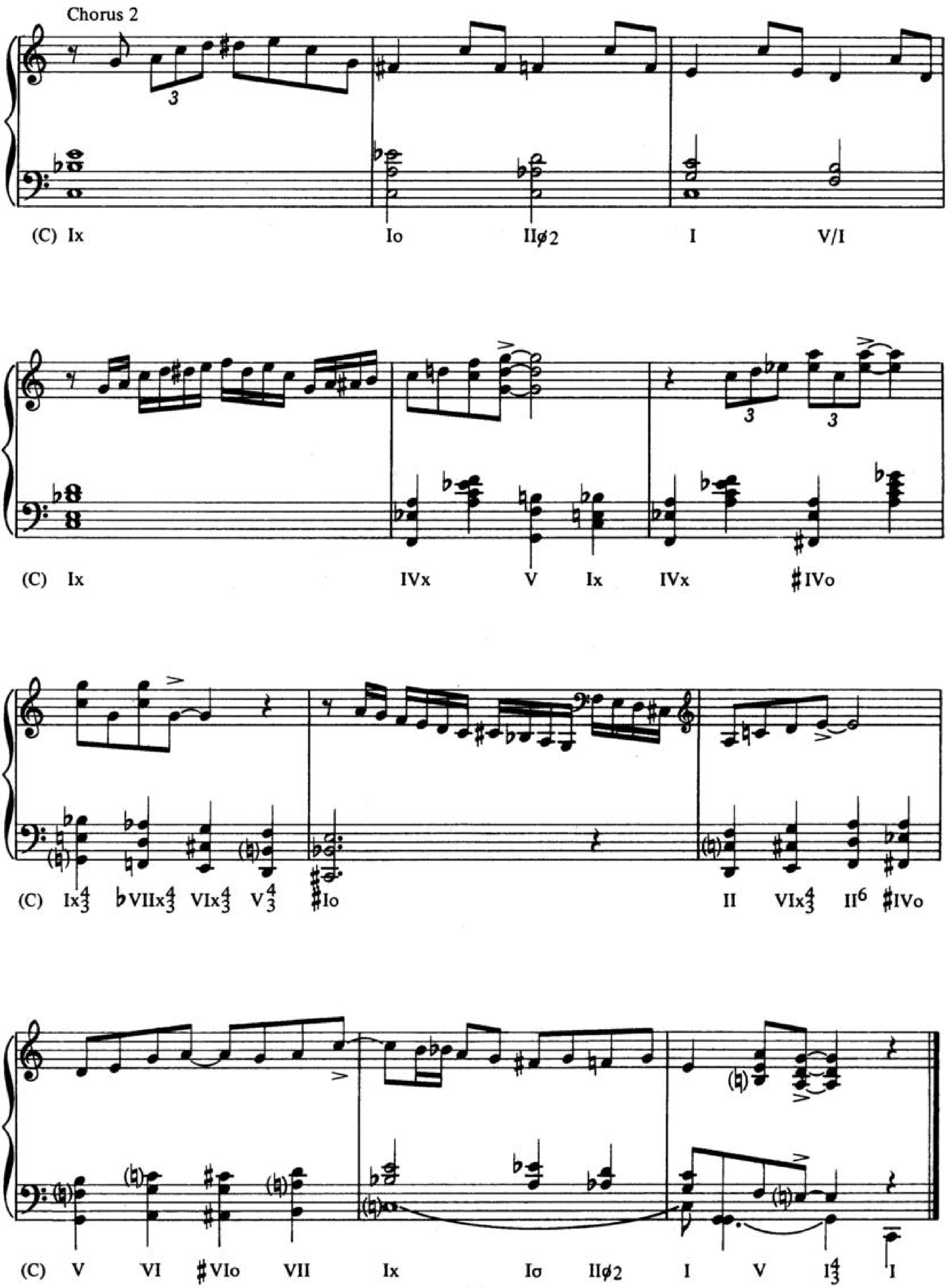
Tenths

Tenths break down into three spans:

Span 1	Span 2	Span 3
C - E♭	C - E	D♭ - F
C♯ - E	D - F	D - F♯
F - A♭	D♯ - F♯	E♭ - G
F♯ - A	E - G	E - G♯
G - B♭	F - A	F♯ - A♯
G♯ - B	G - B	A♭ - C
	A - C	A - C♯
	B♭ - D♭	B♭ - D
	B - D	B - D♯

Spans 1 and 2 are within the normal hand span of the average pianist; span 3 is not and will be avoided in this text.

Fig. 1 illustrates swing piano: the first chorus is in the general style of Teddy Wilson, the second is more reminiscent of Art Tatum.

Fig. 1. Key of C


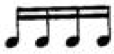
Chorus 2
3
(C) Ix Io IIø2 I V/I
3 3
(C) Ix IVx V Ix IVx ♯IVo
(C) Ix4/3 ♭VIIx4/3 VIx4/3 V4/3 ♯Io II VIx4/3 II6 ♯IVo
(C) V VI ♯VIo VII Ix Iσ IIø2 I V I4/3 I

Chapter 12

Bop Piano
1940 - 1955

Rhythmic unit = ♩ (foot beat)

Harmonic unit = 𝅗𝅥 and 𝅝 (left hand "shells")

Melodic unit =  and 

The important pianists of the early revolutionary period of bop were:

Earl "Bud" Powell
Thelonious Monk

Powell in particular forged a style which would accommodate the new demands of bop:

avoidance of swing bass
left hand shells (chord fragments)
right hand "horn line"

In the later period of bop the major influential pianists were:

Horace Silver
Hampton Hawes

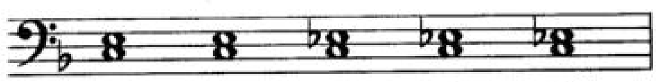
Shells

The use of shells are illustrated in Fig 1; they usually employ the root and the 7th or the root and the 3rd.

The fingerings usually employed are as follows:

Root and 7th = 5th finger and thumb.
Root and 3rd = 2nd finger and thumb.

Fig. 1 Key of F

* 7 FM, 7 Fx, 7 Fm, 7 Fø, 7 Fo

3 CM, 3 Cx, 3 Cm, 3 Cø, 3 Co

*Note: The numerals above the chord names indicate the interval point of the left hand shell.

Since a shell can only imply the quality of a chord, the following table will be helpful in determining the function of each shell in Fig. 1.

Shell		Implied Quality
M 7th	=	M 7 chord
m 7th	=	x 7 chord m 7 chord ø 7 chord
o 7th	=	o 7 chord
M 3rd	=	M 7 chord x 7 chord
m 3rd	=	m 7 chord ø 7 chord o 7 chord

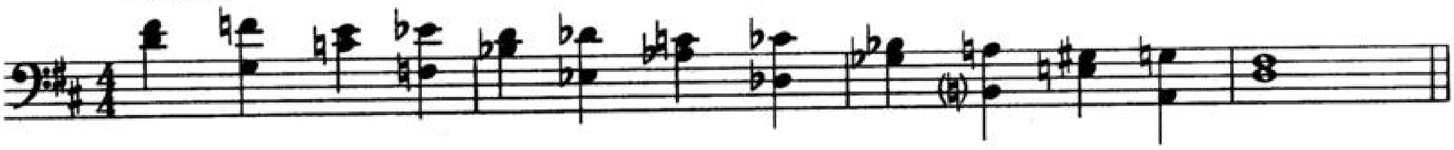
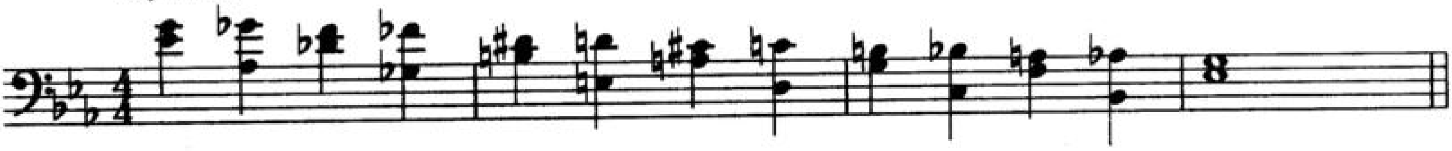
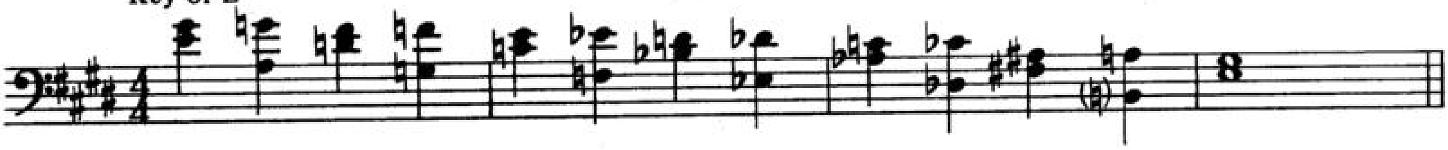
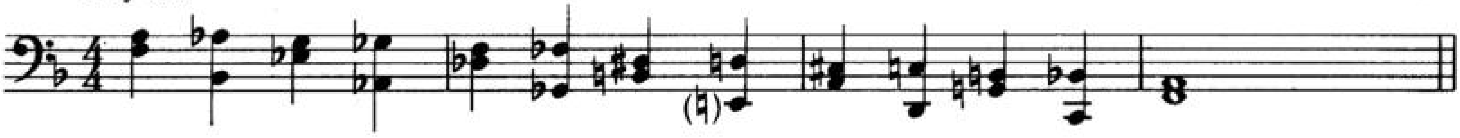
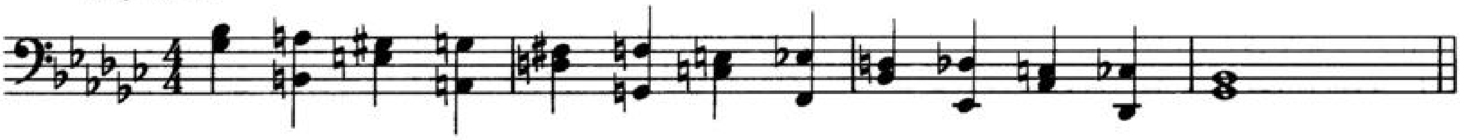
Fig. 2 illustrates a drill which should be practiced around the circle of fifths from the twelve major thirds. The fingering is always 2 - 1 for 3rds and 5 - 1 for 7ths.

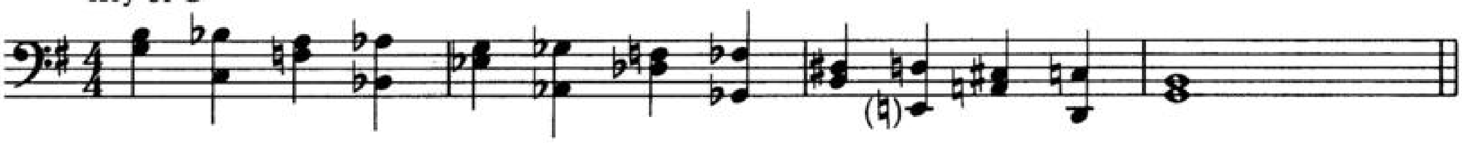
Fig. 2

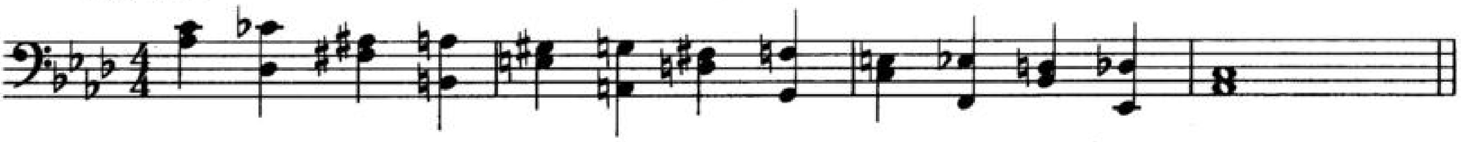
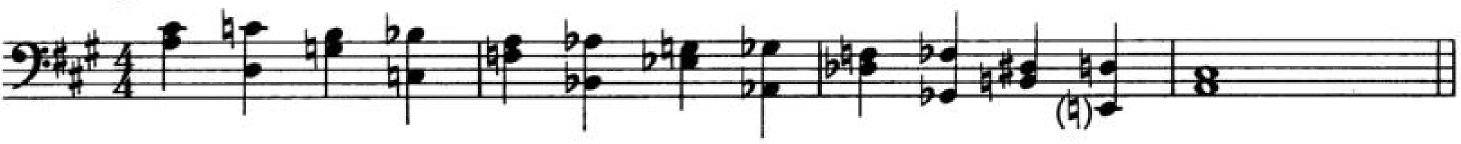
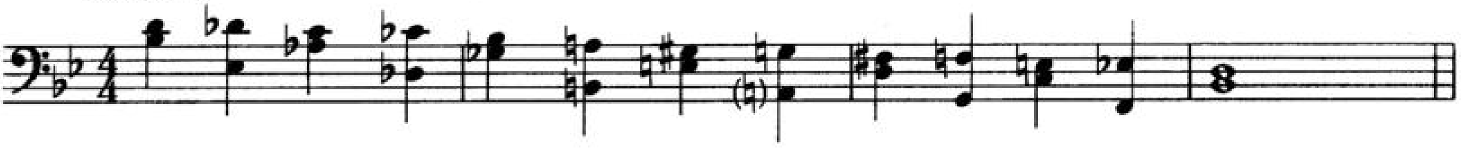
Key of C

Left Hand Drill

Key of D♭

Key of D

Key of E♭

Key of E

Key of F

Key of G♭

Key of G



Key of A♭

Key of A

Key of B♭

Key of B

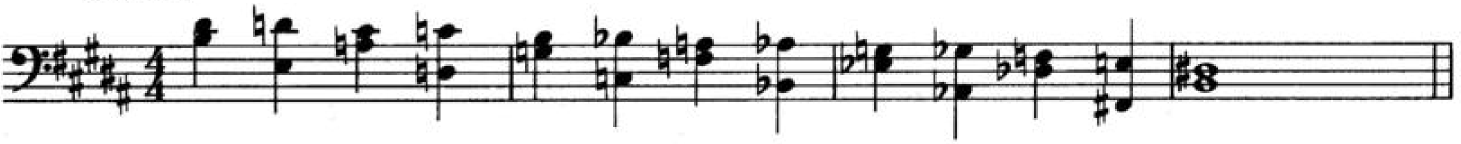
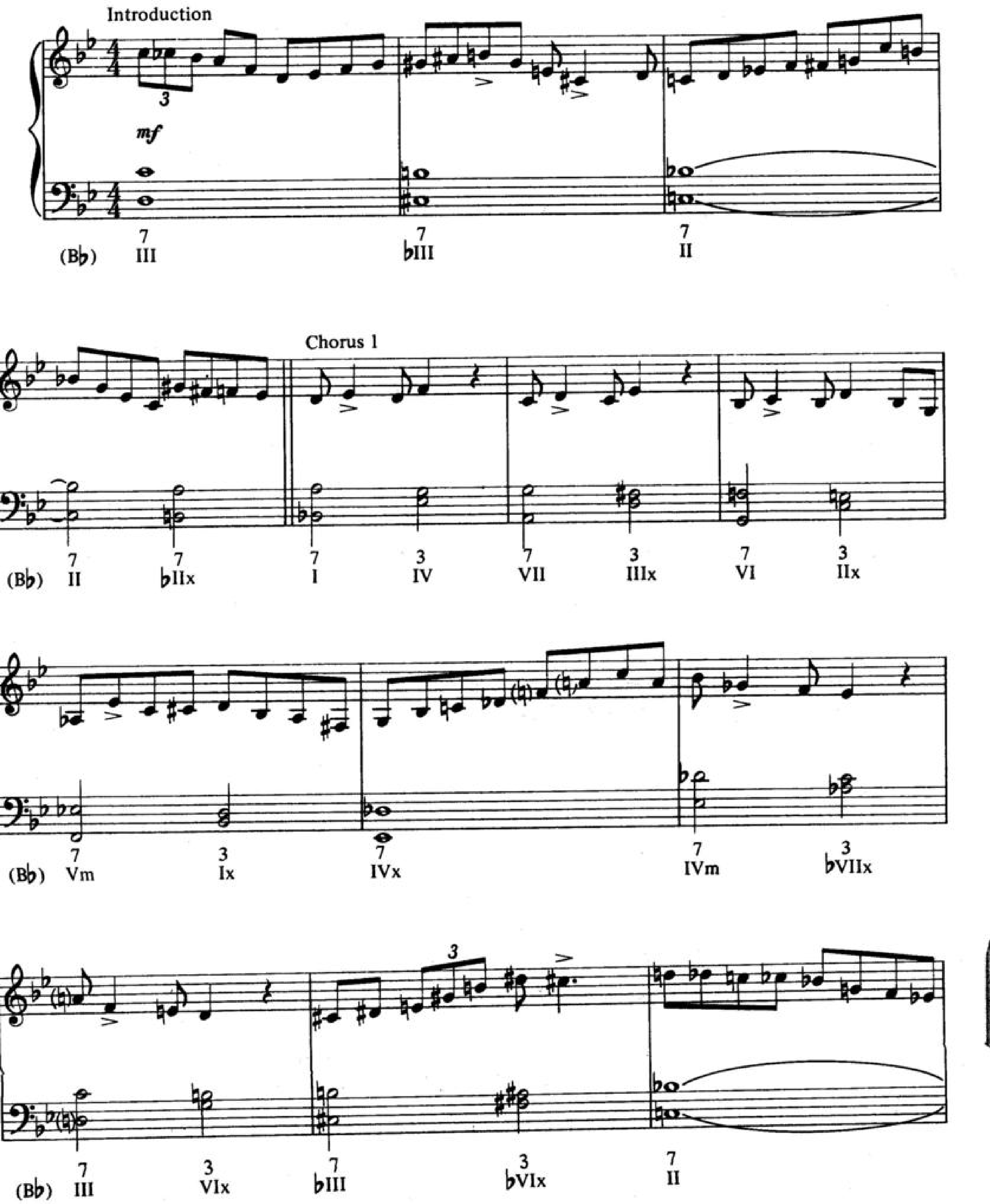
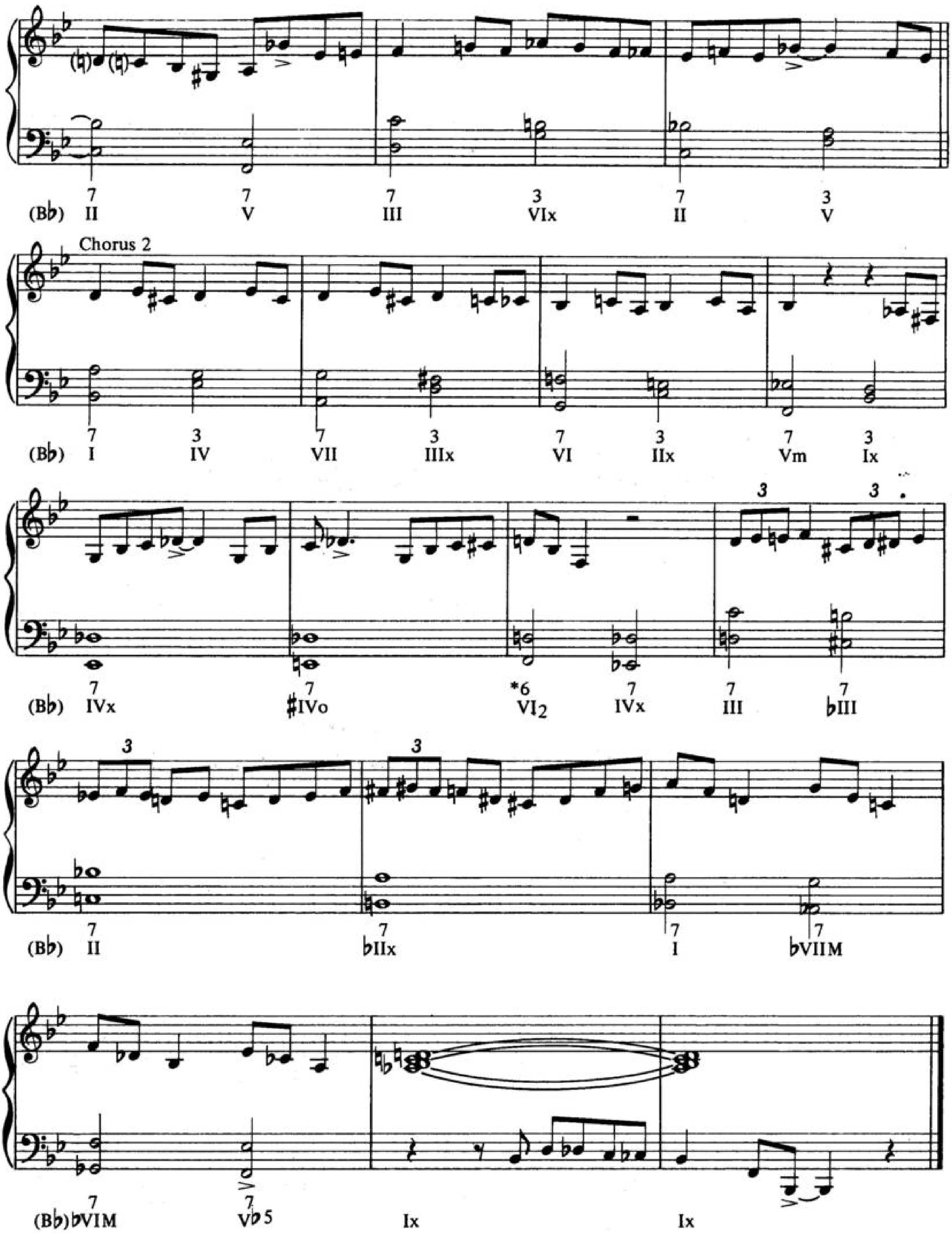



Fig. 3 is a treatment of the twelve - bar blues in the characteristic style of bop piano.

Fig. 3 Key of B♭

Lively

* All inversion shells employ the outside voices of the particular inversion forming a point of six.

Chapter 13

Early Contemporary Jazz Piano
1955 - 1965

Rhythmic unit = ♩ (foot beat)

Harmonic unit = 𝅗𝅥 and 𝅝 (left hand voicings)

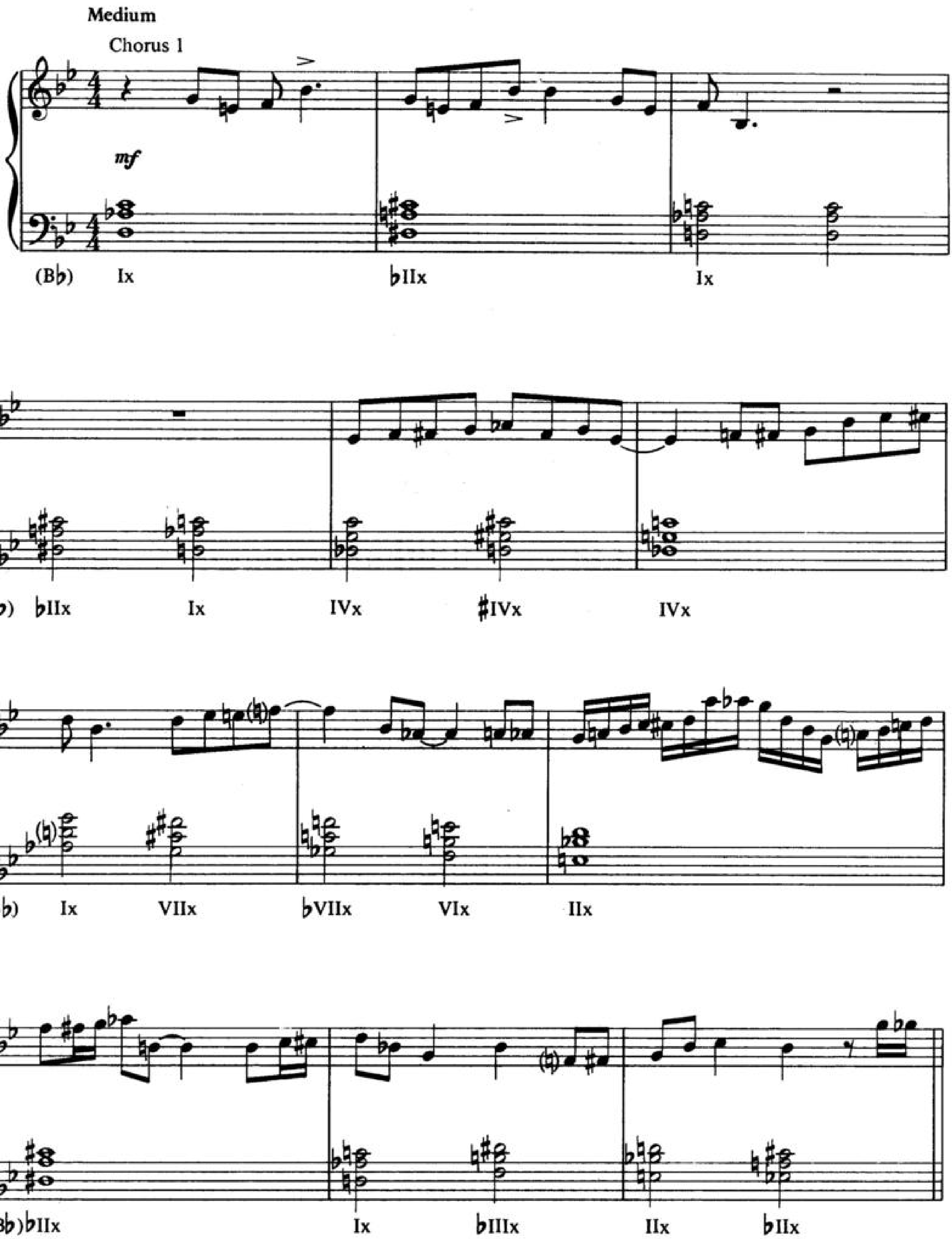
Melodic unit = 

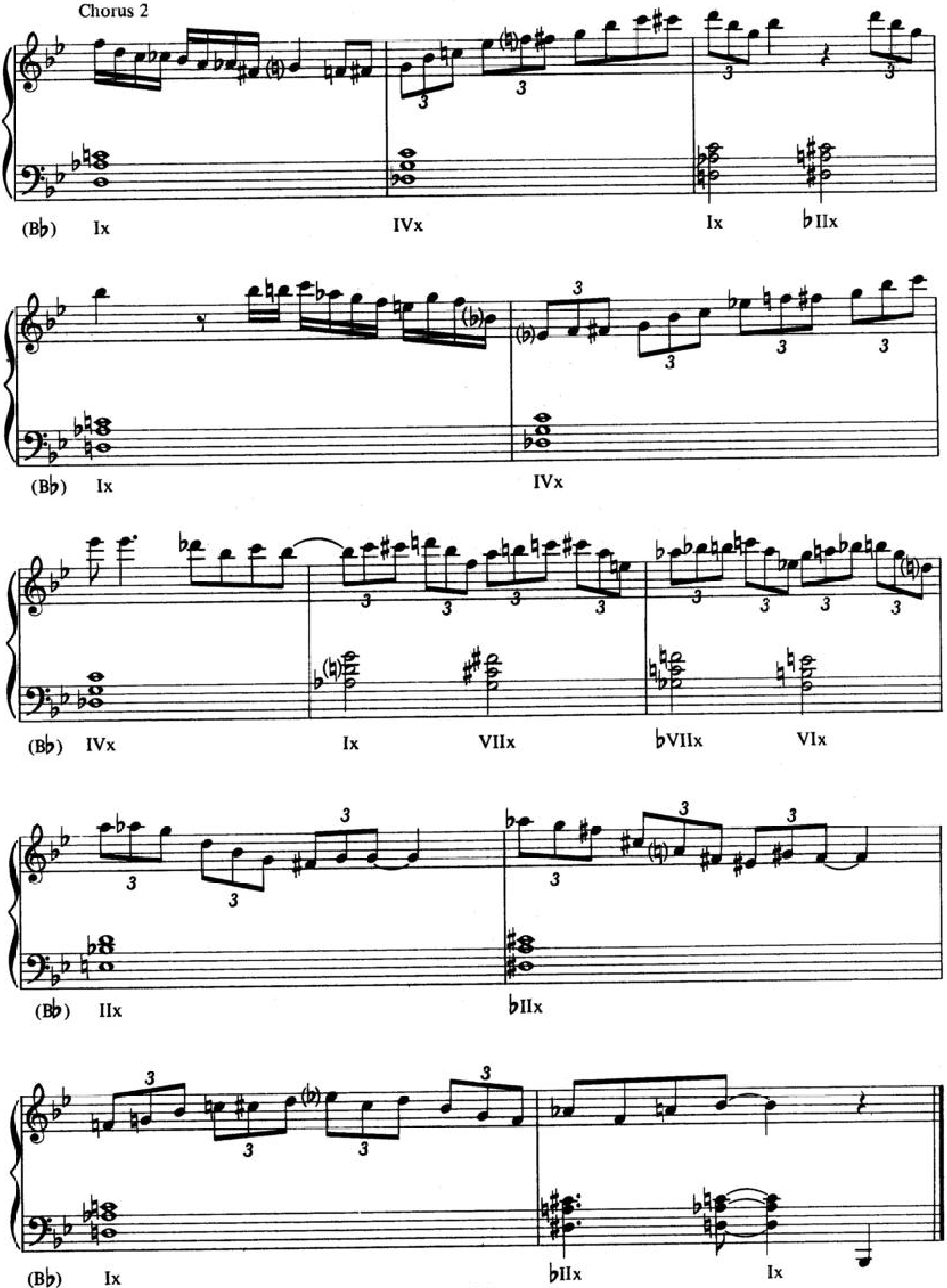
In the middle fifties stylistic changes in jazz piano began to be heard, particularly in the Miles Davis rhythm sections of the period. The important pianists in this early movement were:

"Red" Garland
Wynton Kelly

The basic problem of early contemporary jazz piano was to escape from the severe three voice style of bop piano into a more harmonic approach. This was achieved through the use of left hand voicings which will be thoroughly studied further on in this book.

Fig. 1 illustrates this style applied to the twelve - bar blues.

Fig. 1 Key of B♭


Medium
Chorus 1
mf
(B♭) Ix
♭IIx
Ix
(B♭) ♭IIx
Ix
IVx
♯IVx
IVx
(B♭) Ix
VIIx
♭VIIx
VIx
IIx
(B♭)♭IIx
Ix
♭IIIx
IIx
♭IIx


Chorus 2
(B♭) Ix
IVx
Ix
♭IIx
(B♭) Ix
IVx
(B♭) IVx
Ix
VIIx
♭VIIx
VIx
(B♭) IIx
♭IIx
(B♭) Ix
♭IIx
Ix

Contemporary Jazz Piano
1965 - Present

Rhythmic unit = ♩ (foot beat)

Harmonic unit = 𝅗𝅥 and 𝅝 (left hand voicings / modal fourth fragments)

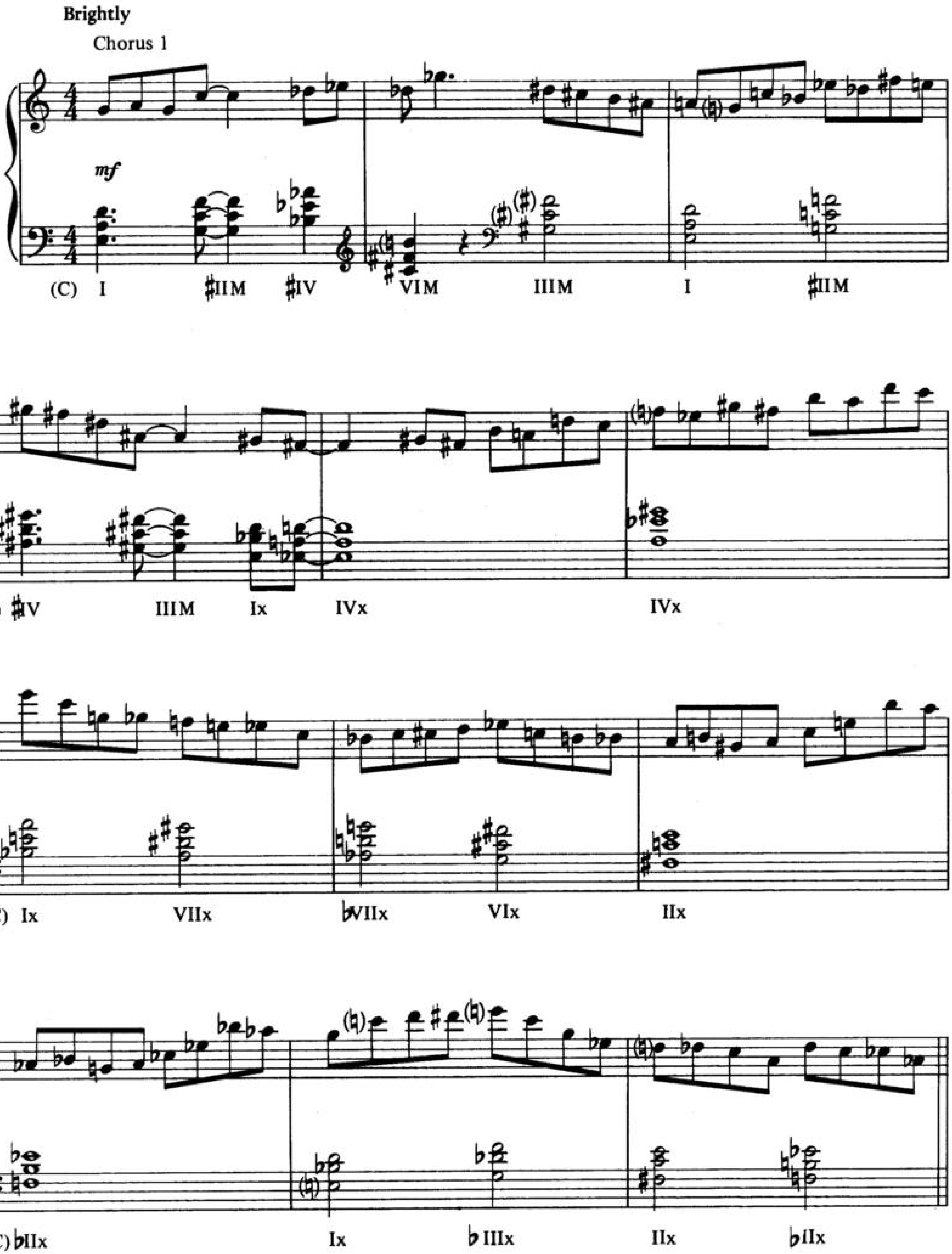
Melodic unit =  and 

Many of the further developments of contemporary jazz piano continued to occur in the Miles Davis rhythm sections with the appearance of Bill Evans, Herbie Hancock and Chick Corea. An exception was McCoy Tyner who achieved his innovations with John Coltrane.

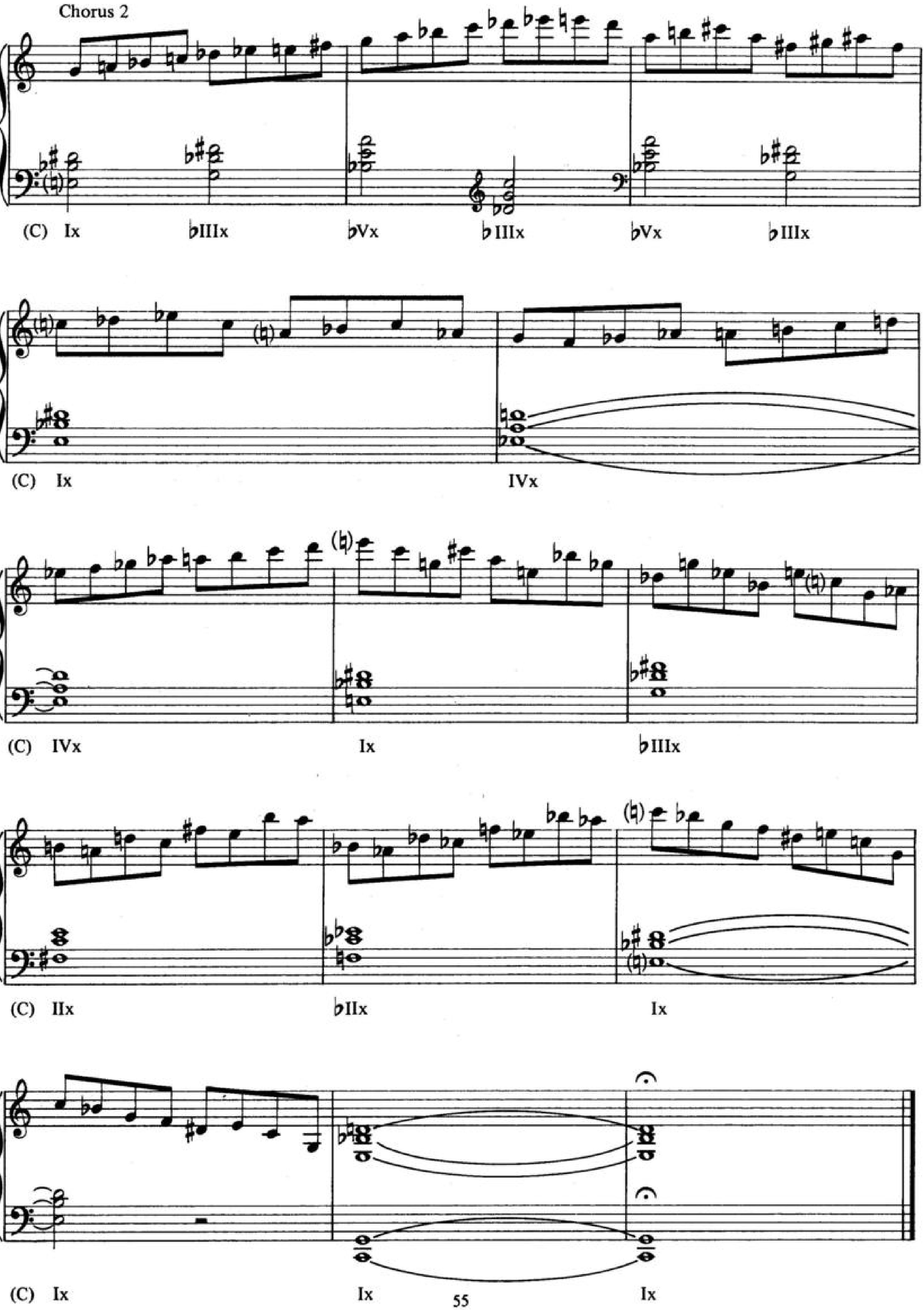
The student should study carefully the recordings of:

Bill Evans
Herbie Hancock
Chick Corea
McCoy Tyner

Fig. 1 illustrates some of the basic devices employed by contemporary pianists as they would appear in the twelve - bar blues.

Fig. 1 Key of C


Brightly
Chorus 1
mf
(C) I ♯IIM ♯IV VIM IIIM I ♯IIM
(C) ♯IV IIIM Ix IVx IVx
(C) Ix VIIx ♭VIIx VIx IIx
(C) ♭IIx Ix ♭IIIx IIx ♭IIx


Chorus 2
(C) Ix
♭IIIx
♭Vx
♭IIIx
♭Vx
♭IIIx
(C) Ix
IVx
(C) IVx
Ix
♭IIIx
(C) IIx
♭IIx
Ix
(C) Ix
Ix
Ix

The student may notice the absence of several important pianists in the preceding summary, in particular Oscar Peterson and George Shearing. These omissions demand an explanation.

Oscar Peterson has established a level of virtuosity in jazz piano reminiscent of the great Art Tatum. Peterson's influences,however, are more modern - namely Bud Powell, Charlie Parker, George Shearing and Nat Cole. There are no major innovations in Peterson's playing as regards devices; his contribution lies in his brilliant consolidation of elements of the art from the time he first appeared on the jazz horizon in 1950.

George Shearing is a different matter. He is basically a Powell influenced pianist but is credited with developing and popularizing the block chord system previously associated with pianist Milt Buckner of the Lionel Hampton Band. This block chord system has become part of the jazz vernacular and is employed by many contemporary pianists in varying ways.

Two other pianists who left no heritage of devices employed by professional musicians but who brought jazz piano to the forefront of the American music public are Dave Brubeck and Erroll Garner. Both of these men were able to open new markets which had previously been largely inaccessible to jazz musicians. Brubeck, in colleges throughout the world; and Garner,through television and extensive recordings,brought a valuable exposure to jazz.

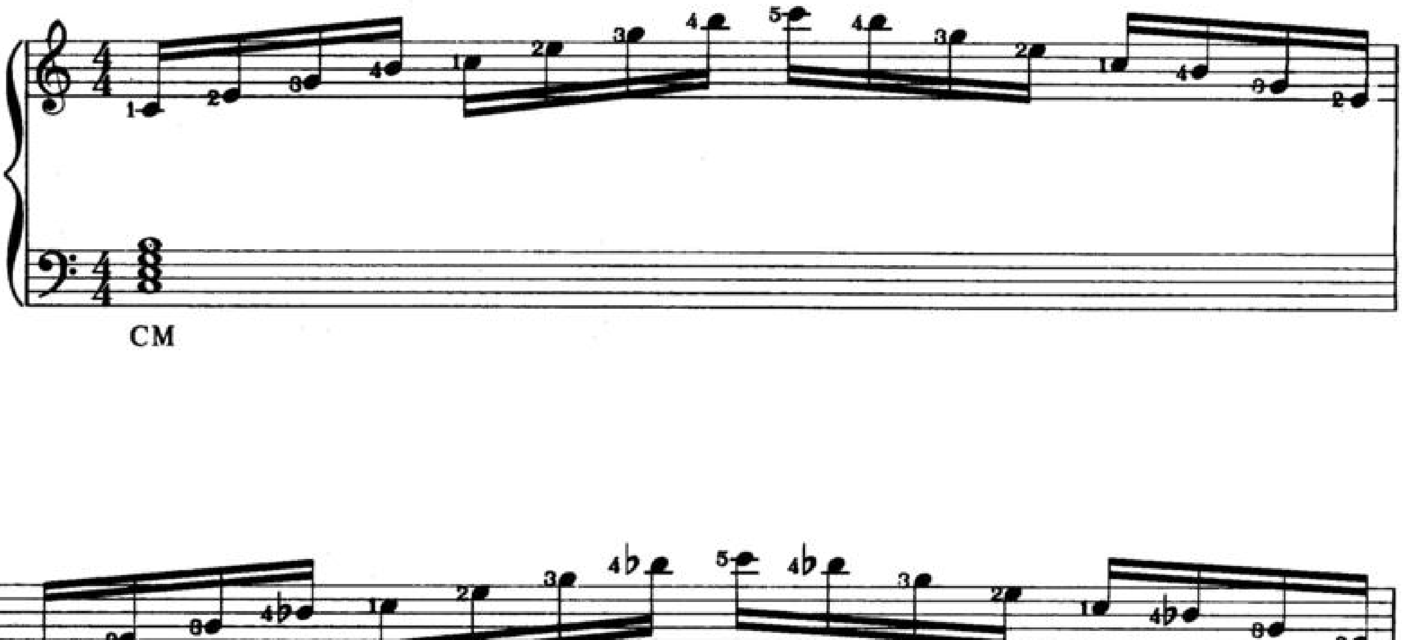
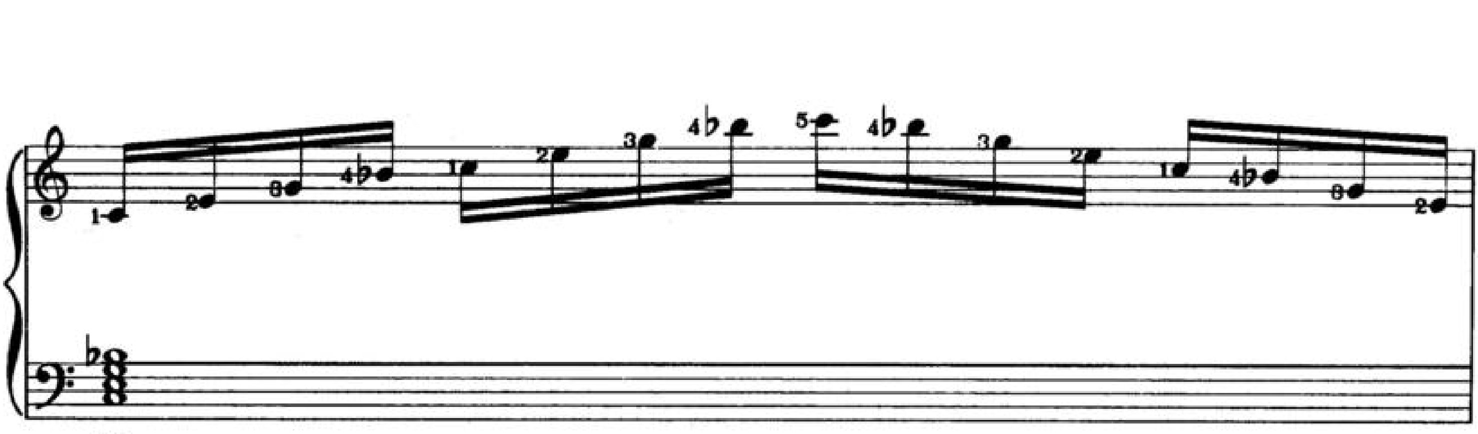
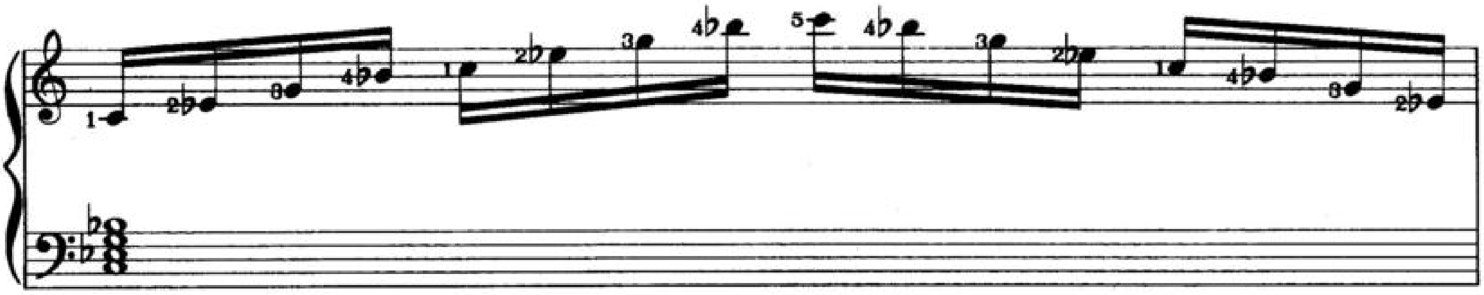
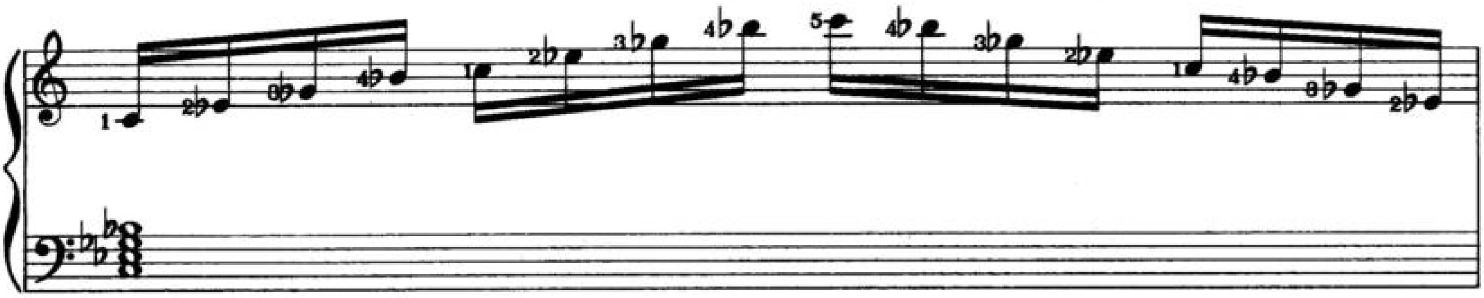
The Improvised Line

Jazz improvisation involves abandoning the melody and creating an improvised line based on the resources of the chords.

These resources consist of the following:

1. Arpeggios (broken chords)
2. Modes
3. Non - modal tones (blue notes)

Arpeggios

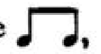
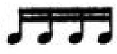
Fig. 1 Key of C

Cm

Cø

Co

The following table illustrates the right hand arpeggio fingerings for the Sixty chords. (See Chapter Three)
Inversion fingerings are generally derived from root position fingerings.
Some fingerings employ only one fingering combination for all five qualities (M, x, m, ø, o); others require various fingerings as the intervals change.
The traditional rule concerning all fingering has been to avoid the thumb and, to some extent, the fifth finger on black notes in order not to disturb the classic piano hand position.

C	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
D	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
E	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
F	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
G	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
A	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
B	M, x, m, ø, o	123412345 - reverse
D♭	M, x, m, ø, o	212341234 - reverse
A♭	M, x, m, ø, o	212341234 - reverse
B♭ (A♯)	M, x,	212341234 - reverse
B♭ (A♯)	m. ø, o	231234123 - reverse
G♭ (F♯)	M, x,	234123412 - reverse
G♭ (F♯)	m, ø, o	212341234 - reverse
E♭	M, x,	212341234 - reverse
E♭	m,	123412345 - reverse
E♭ (D♯)	ø, o	231234123 - reverse

Fig. 2 is an arpeggiated improvised line on "Here's That Rainy Day". Note the key changes.

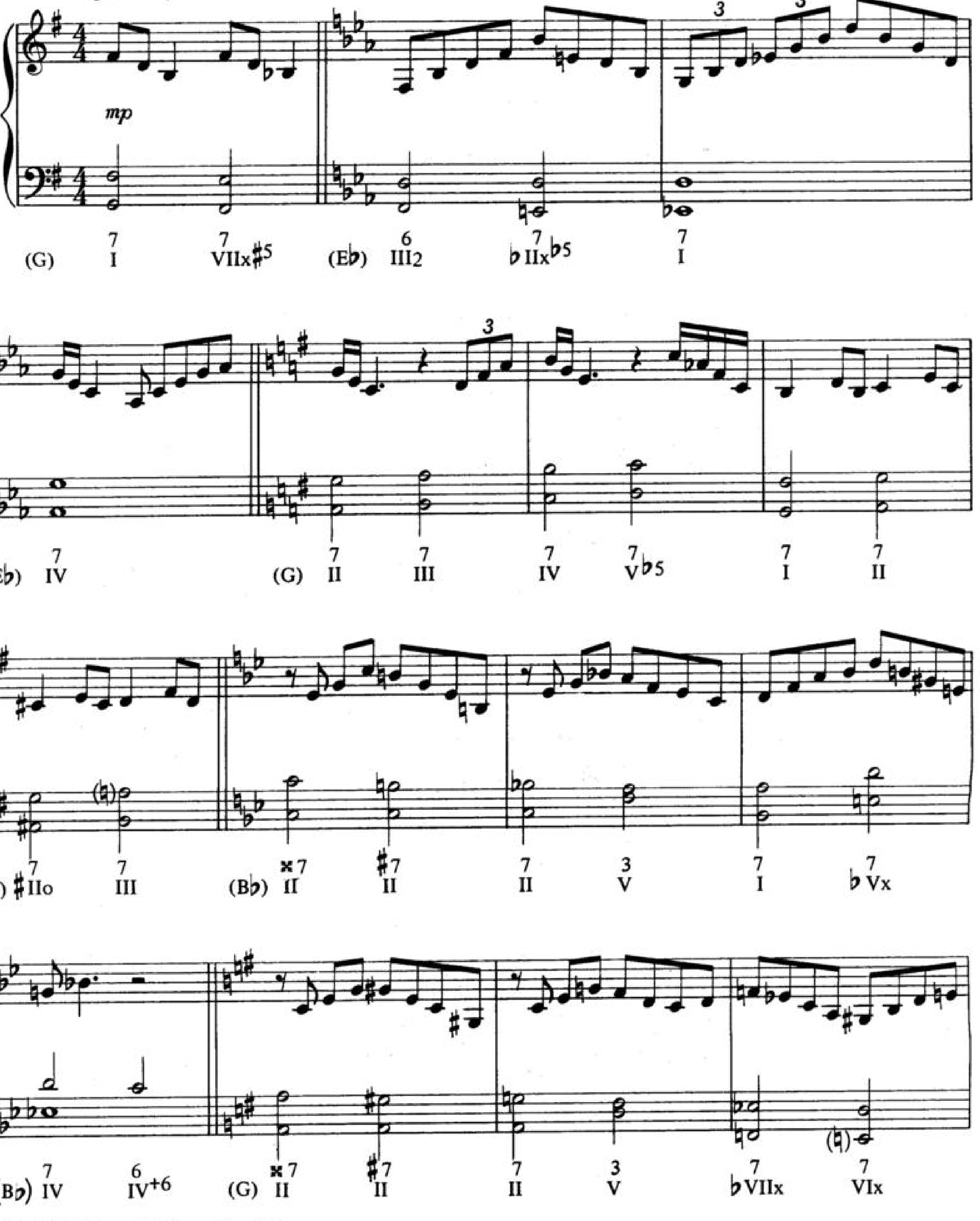
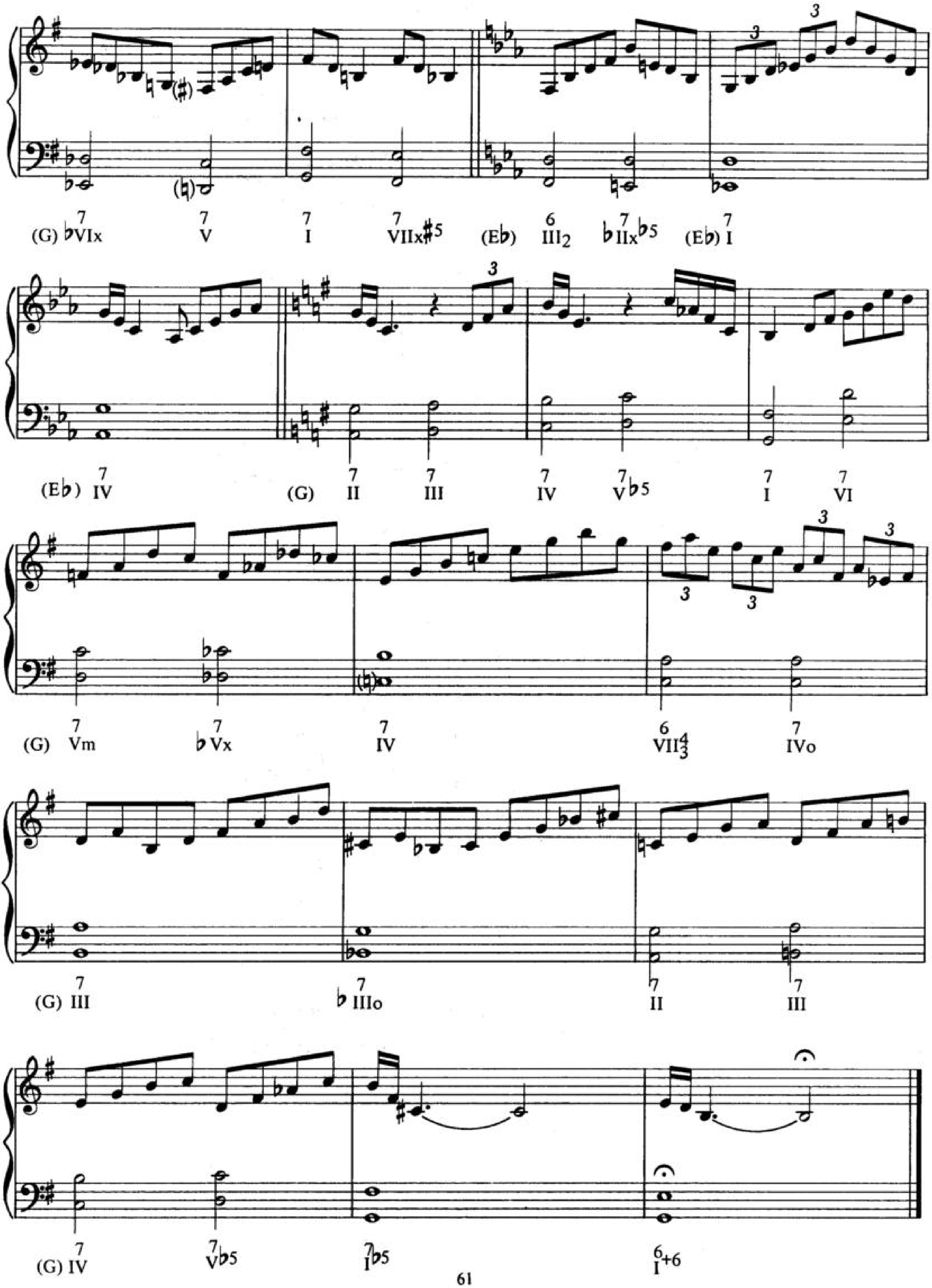
The improvised line employs the ,  and  melodic units.

The left hand shells create a basic bop treatment in order to lend a sense of style to the study.

The student is advised to seriously study the arpeggio table appearing above for automatic facility.

Here's That Rainy Day

words and music by
Johnny Burke and James Van Heusen

Fig. 2 Key of G


(G) ♭VIx7
V7
I7
VIIx7♯5
(E♭) III6 2
♭IIx7♭5
(E♭) I7
(E♭) IV7
(G) II7
III7
IV7
V7♭5
I7
VI7
(G) Vm7
♭Vx7
IV7
VII6 4 3
IVo7
(G) III7
♭IIIo7
II7
III7
(G) IV7
V7♭5
I7♭5
I6+6

Chapter 16

Modes

A mode is a displaced scale starting on any tone in the row.

Thus, the scale of C can be played from:

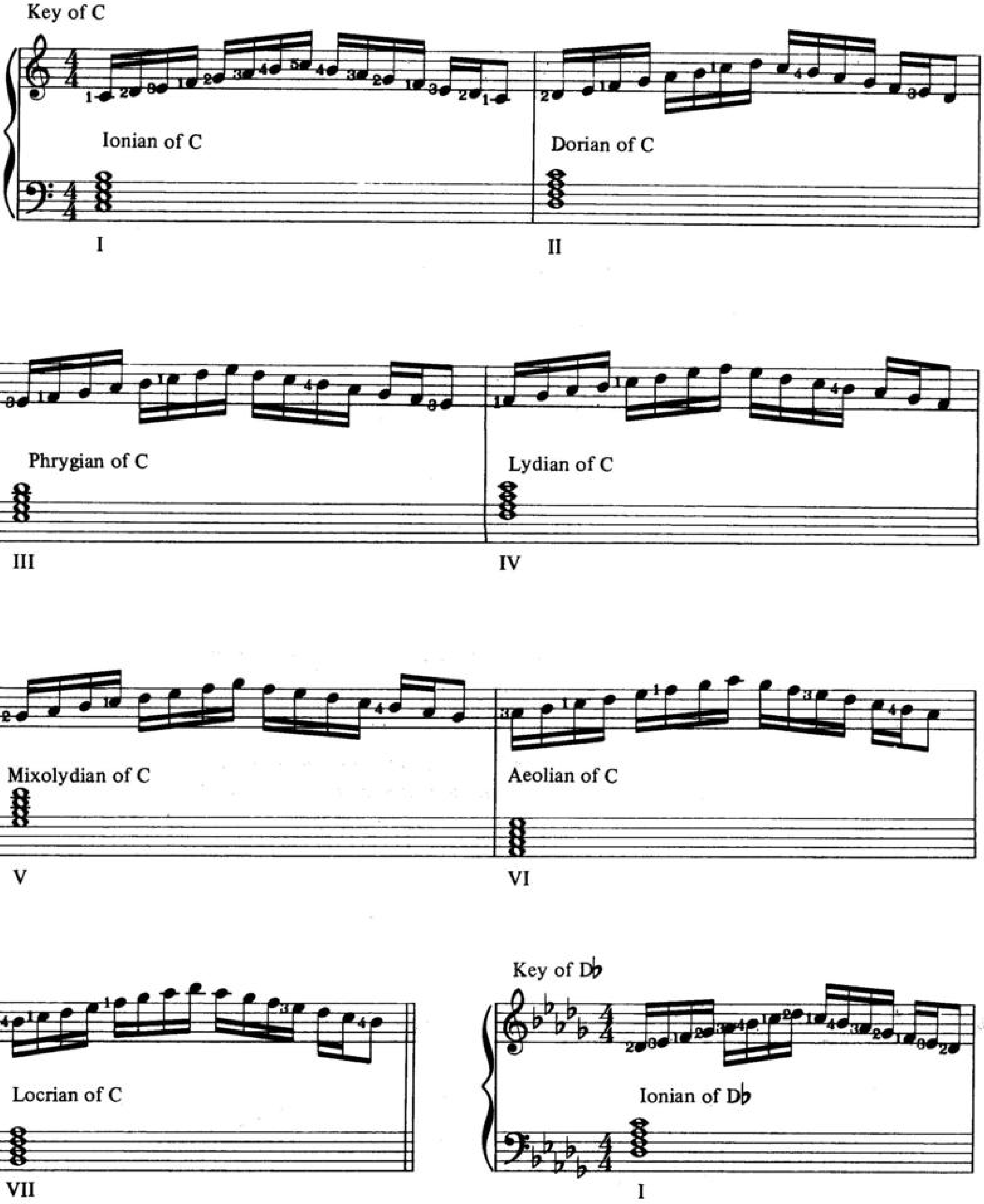
I	C to C	-	Ionian Mode
II	D to D	-	Dorian Mode
III	E to E	-	Phrygian Mode
IV	F to F	-	Lydian Mode
V	G to G	-	Mixolydian Mode
VI	A to A	-	Aeolian Mode
VII	B to B	-	Locrian Mode

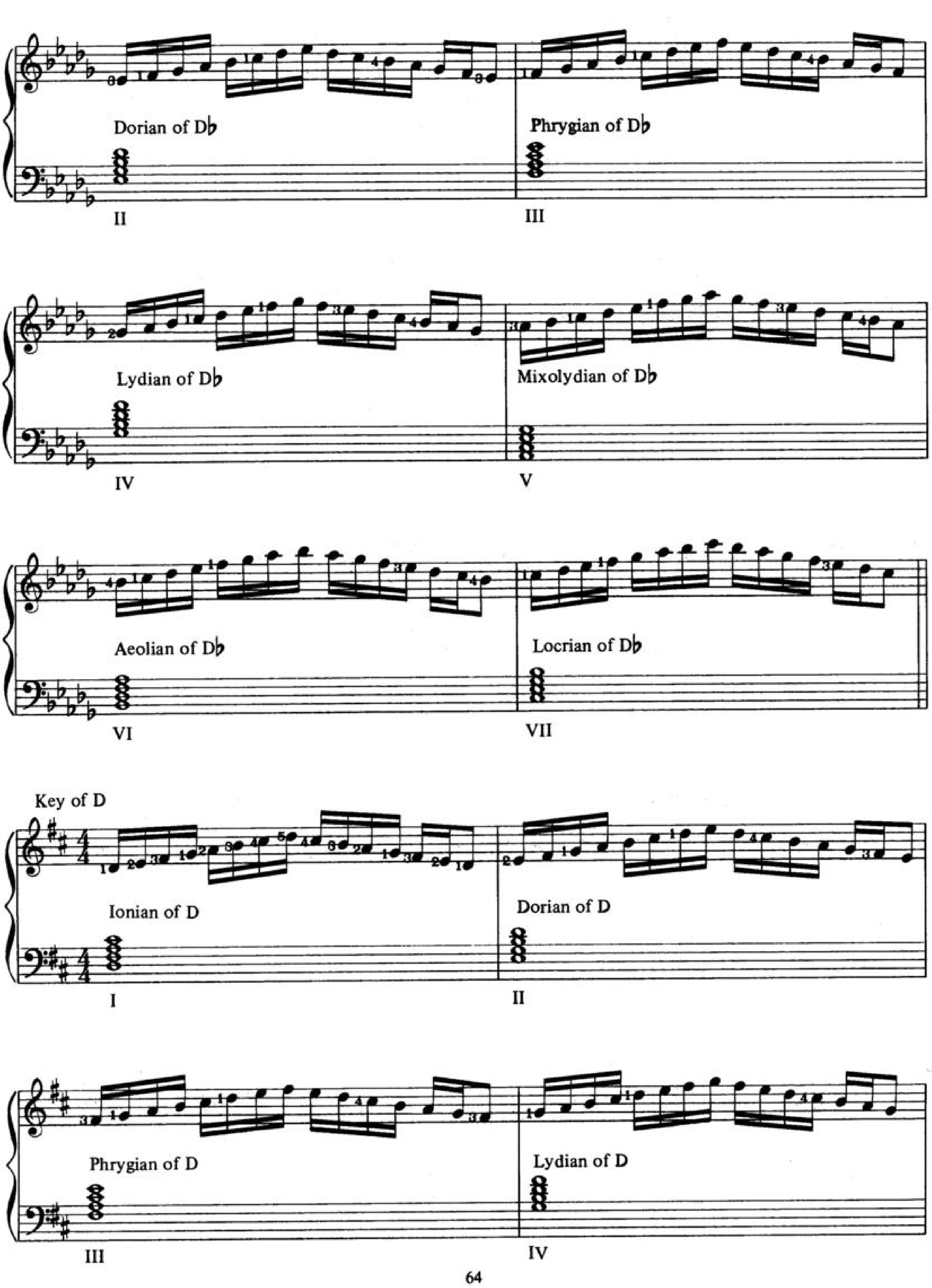
The terms appearing in the above table are the traditional Greek names applied to the modal displacements.

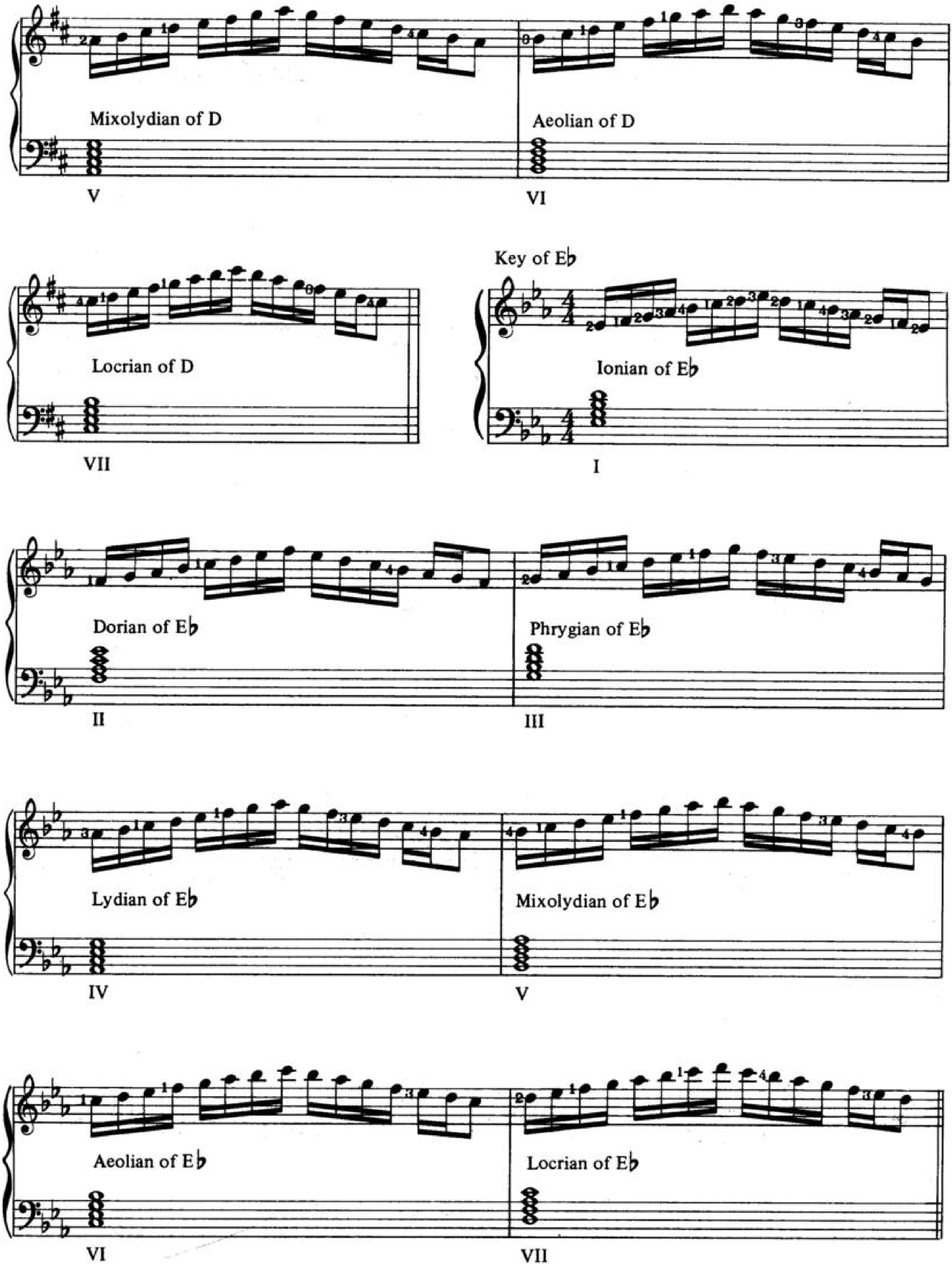
The basic problem here is to connect the eighty - four modes, (twelve scales, seven displacements) to the Sixty chord system in order to employ the most important device in contemporary jazz improvisation.

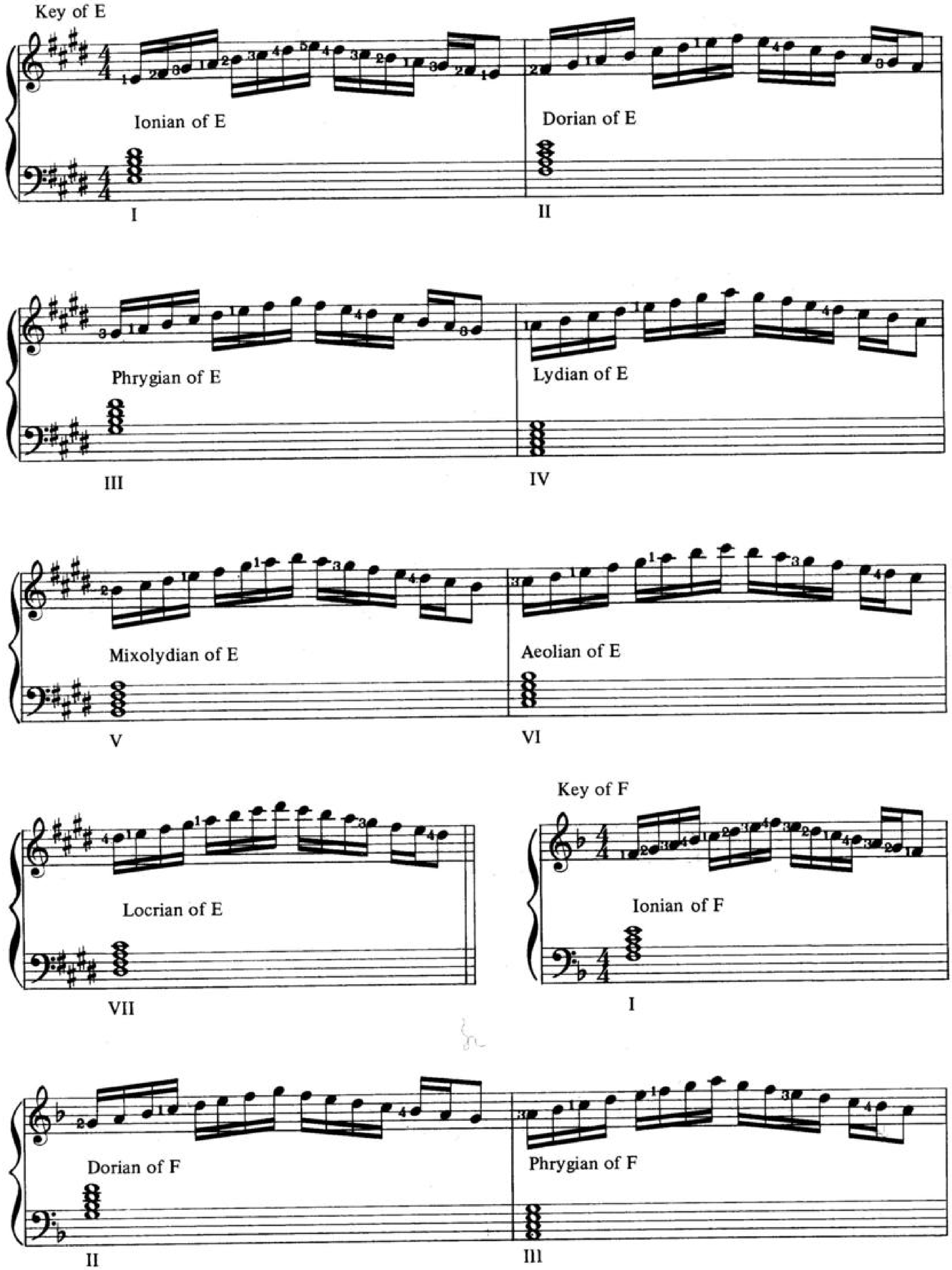
The Eighty-four Modes

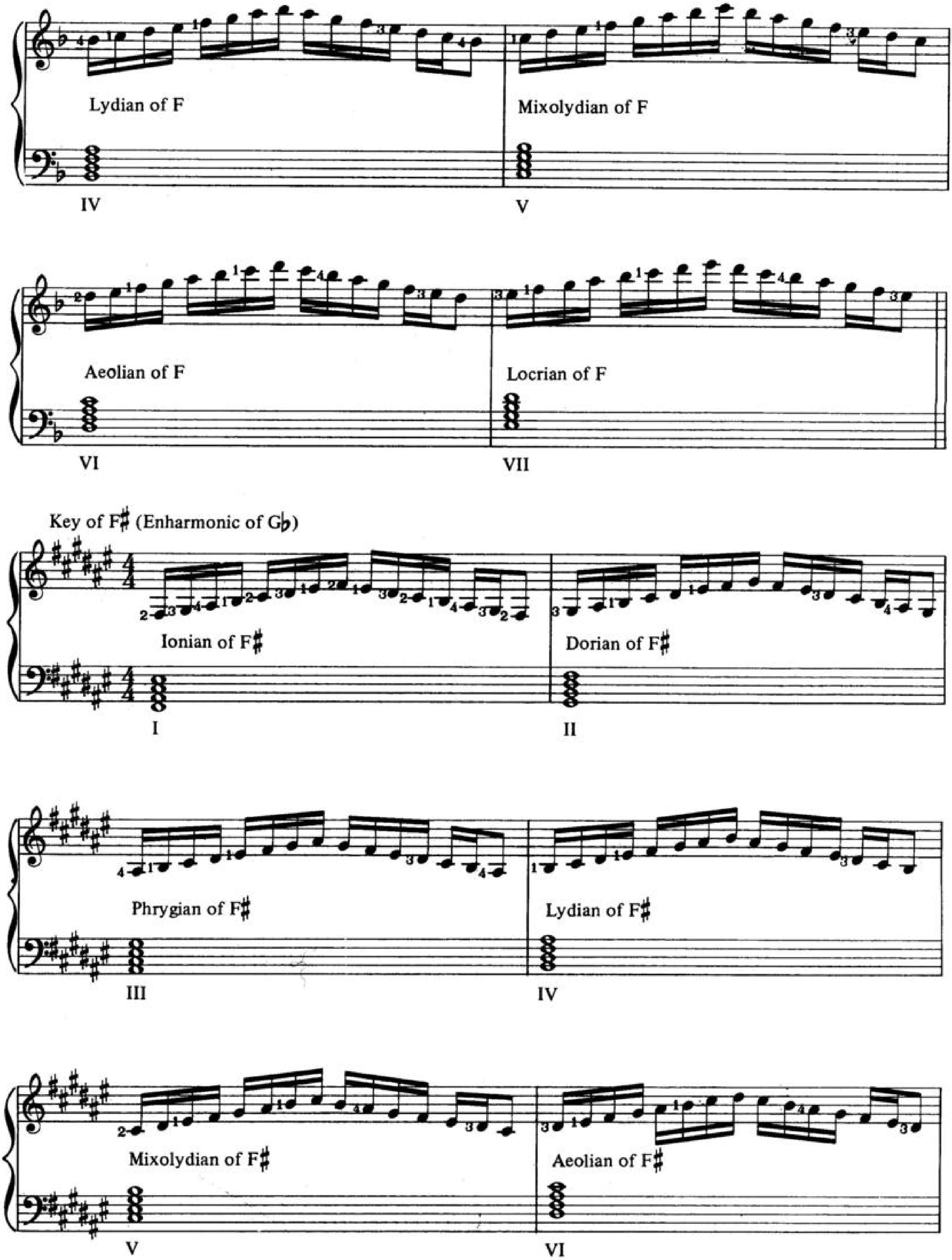
(All fingerings follow the original Ionian fingering system)

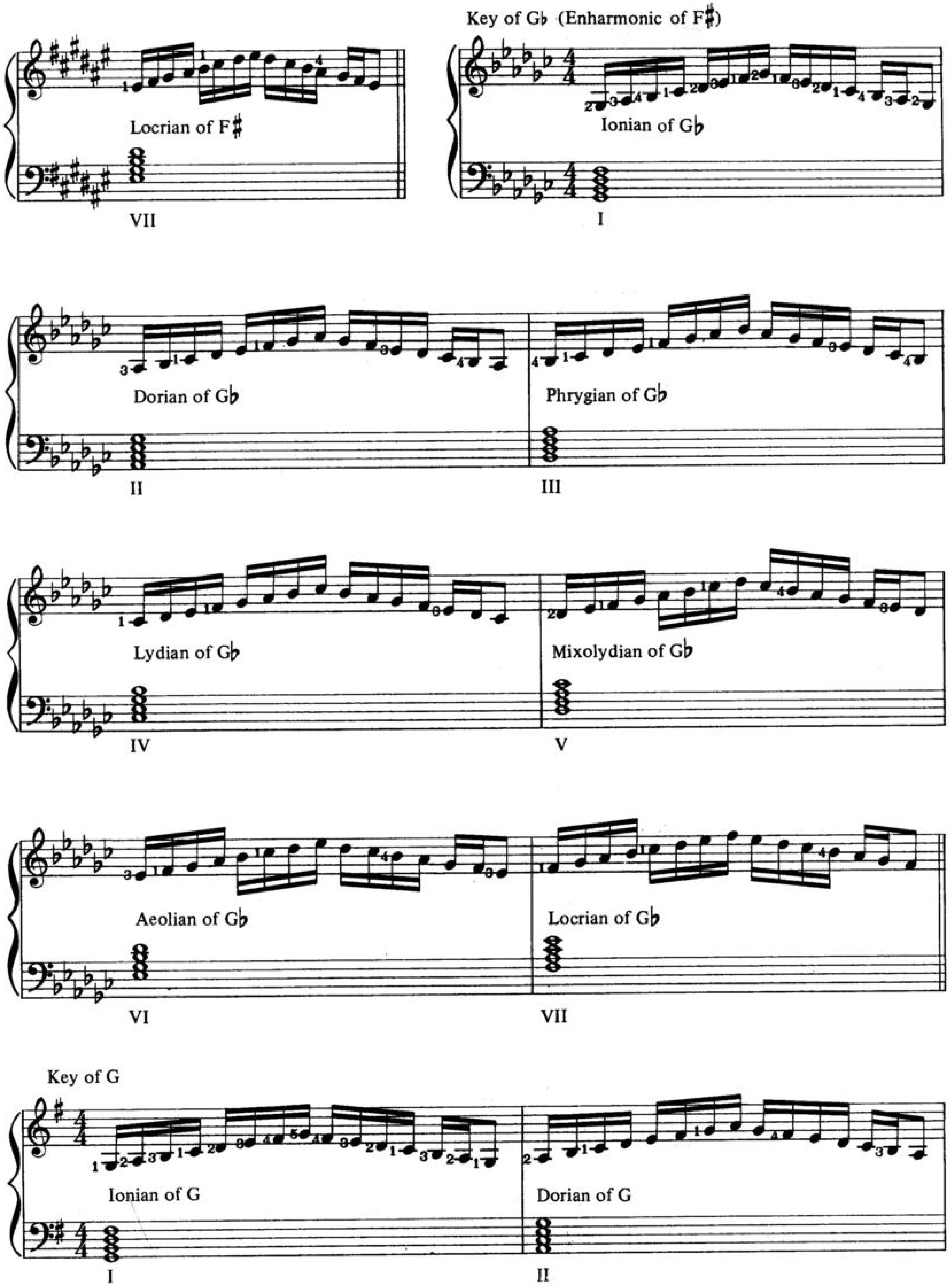


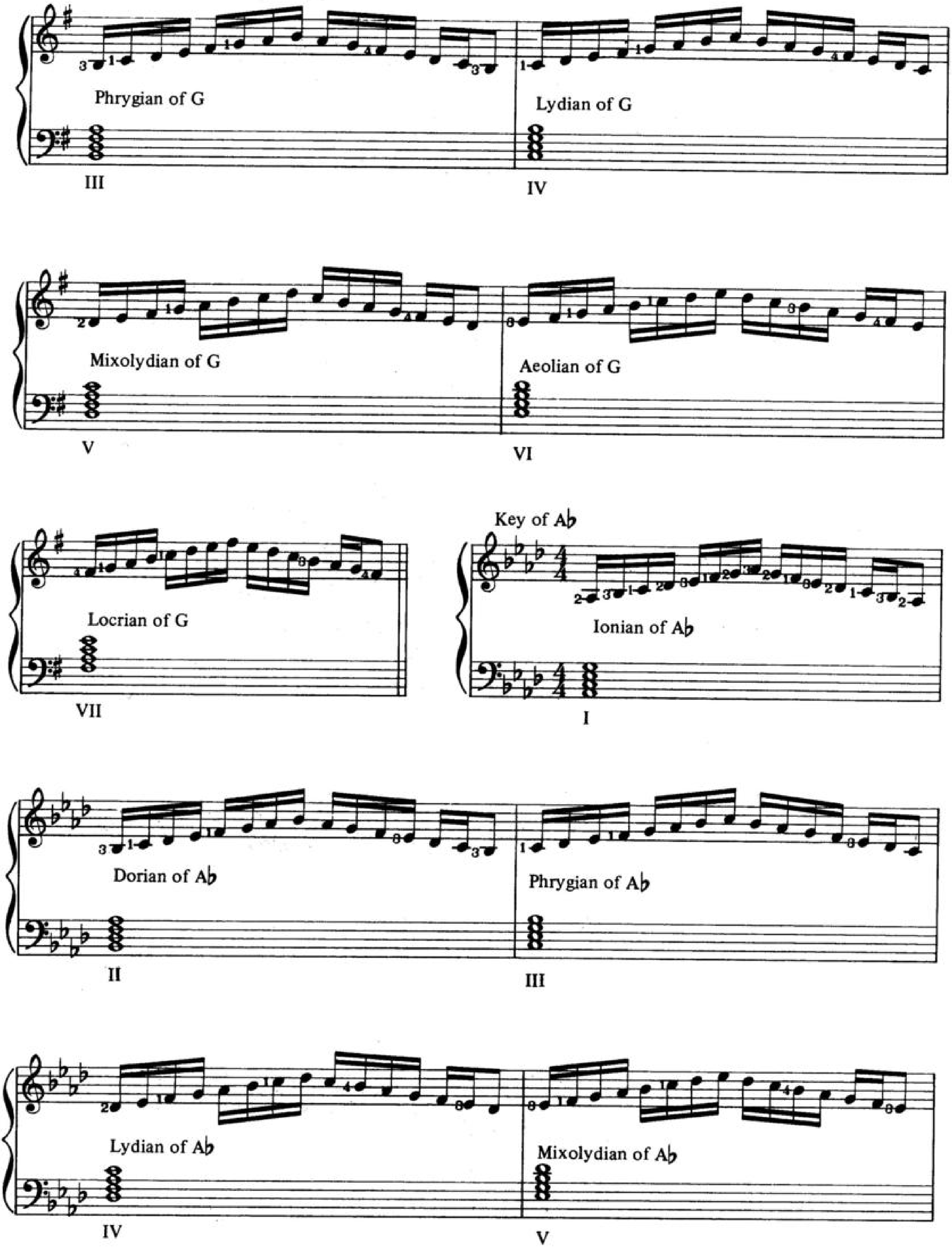
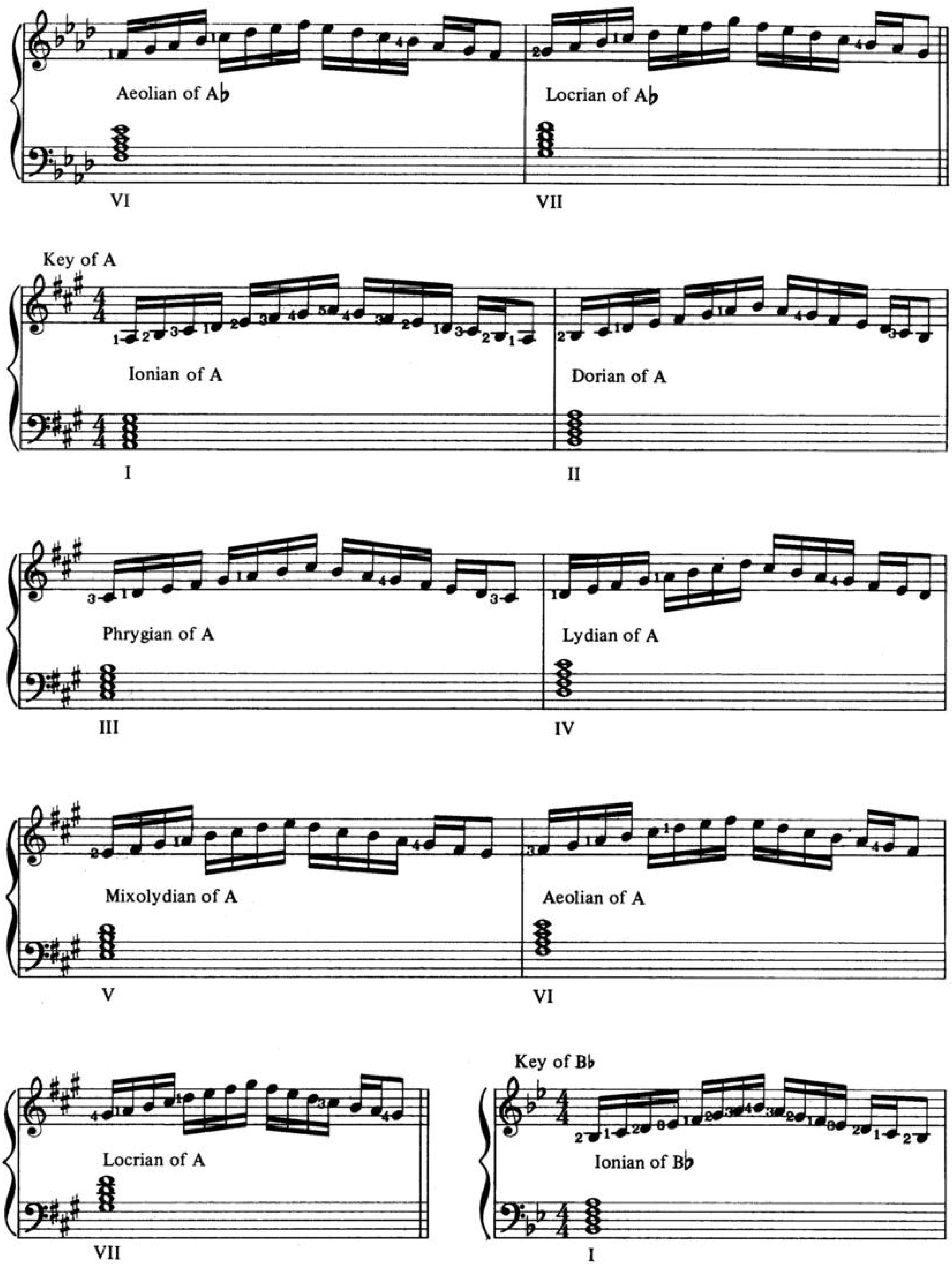

Dorian of D♭
II
Phrygian of D♭
III
Lydian of D♭
IV
Mixolydian of D♭
V
Aeolian of D♭
VI
Locrian of D♭
VII
Key of D
Ionian of D
I
Dorian of D
II
Phrygian of D
III
Lydian of D
IV

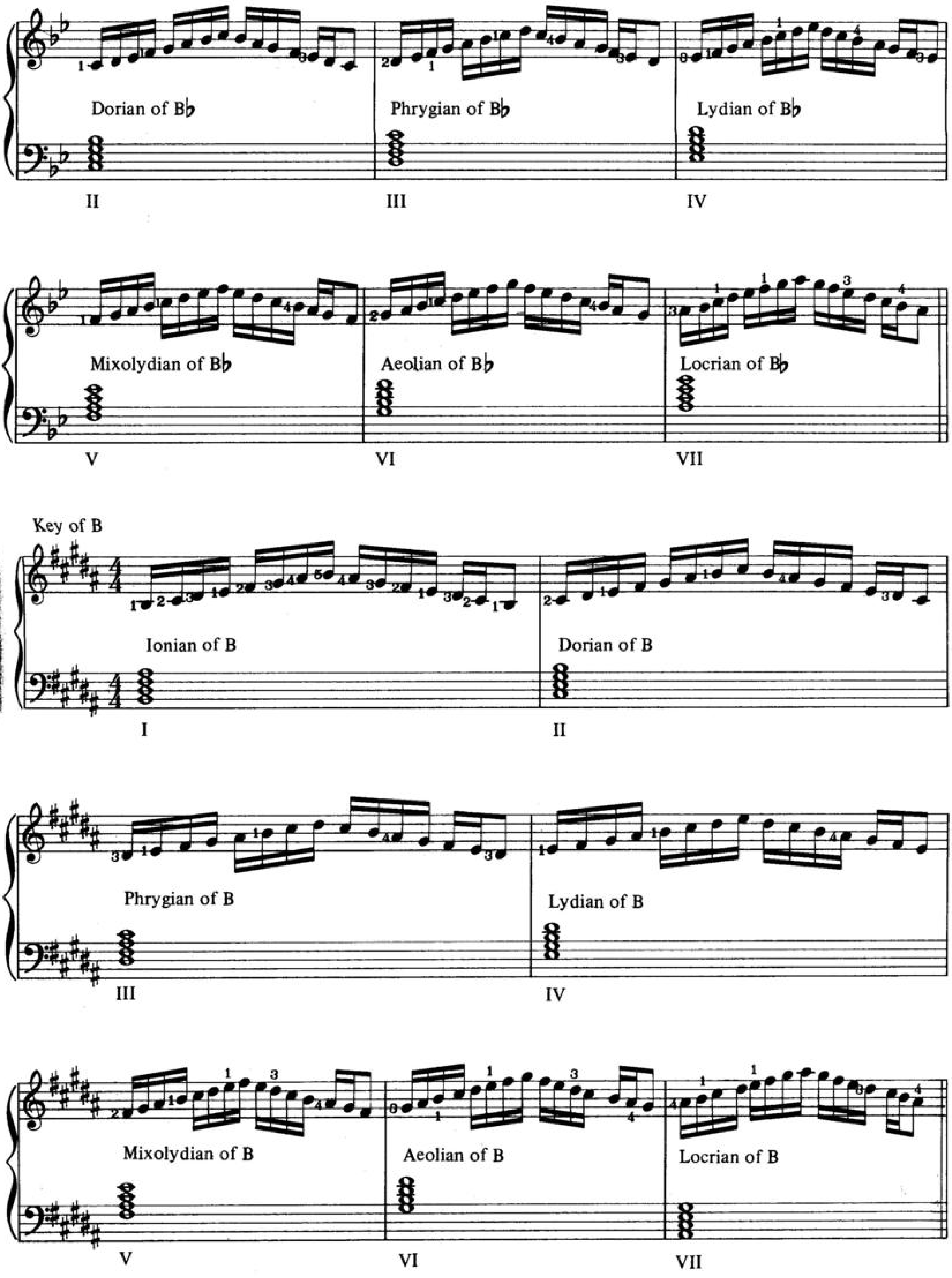

Mixolydian of D
V
Aeolian of D
VI
Locrian of D
VII
Key of E♭
Ionian of E♭
I
Dorian of E♭
II
Phrygian of E♭
III
Lydian of E♭
IV
Mixolydian of E♭
V
Aeolian of E♭
VI
Locrian of E♭
VII


Key of E
Ionian of E
I
Dorian of E
II
Phrygian of E
III
Lydian of E
IV
Mixolydian of E
V
Aeolian of E
VI
Locrian of E
VII
Key of F
Ionian of F
I
Dorian of F
II
Phrygian of F
III


Lydian of F
IV
Mixolydian of F
V
Aeolian of F
VI
Locrian of F
VII
Key of F♯ (Enharmonic of G♭)
Ionian of F♯
I
Dorian of F♯
II
Phrygian of F♯
III
Lydian of F♯
IV
Mixolydian of F♯
V
Aeolian of F♯
VI


Locrian of F♯
VII
Key of G♭ (Enharmonic of F♯)
Ionian of G♭
I
Dorian of G♭
II
Phrygian of G♭
III
Lydian of G♭
IV
Mixolydian of G♭
V
Aeolian of G♭
VI
Locrian of G♭
VII
Key of G
Ionian of G
I
Dorian of G
II


Phrygian of G
III
Lydian of G
IV
Mixolydian of G
V
Aeolian of G
VI
Locrian of G
VII
Key of A♭
Ionian of A♭
I
Dorian of A♭
II
Phrygian of A♭
III
Lydian of A♭
IV
Mixolydian of A♭
V


Aeolian of A♭
Locrian of A♭
VI
VII
Key of A
Ionian of A
Dorian of A
I
II
Phrygian of A
Lydian of A
III
IV
Mixolydian of A
Aeolian of A
V
VI
Locrian of A
VII
Key of B♭
Ionian of B♭
I


Dorian of B♭
Phrygian of B♭
Lydian of B♭
II
III
IV
Mixolydian of B♭
Aeolian of B♭
Locrian of B♭
V
VI
VII
Key of B
Ionian of B
Dorian of B
I
II
Phrygian of B
Lydian of B
III
IV
Mixolydian of B
Aeolian of B
Locrian of B
V
VI
VII

Chapter 17

Modal Improvisation (Part 1)

Until 1940 the basic element employed in jazz improvisation was the arpeggio (broken chord). This was evolved by Louis Armstrong, Coleman Hawkins and a host of other gifted performers. Beginning in the late Thirties with the appearance of Lester Young, Charlie Parker, Fats Navarro and Bud Powell the use of displaced scales (modes) began and has continued to dominate the improvised line to the present day.

Now we have to connect the modal system described in Chapter Sixteen to the seventh chord harmonic system described in Chapter Two.

Fig. 1 illustrates the seventh chord system and the possible modal relationships.

Fig. 1

Quality	Intervals	Positions	Modes
Major 7	M P M	I	Ionian
		IV	Lydian
Dominant 7th	M P m	V	Mixolydian
Minor 7th	m P m	II	Dorian
		III	Phrygian
		VI	Aeolian
Half diminished 7th	m o m	VII	Locrian
Diminished 7th	m o o	none	none

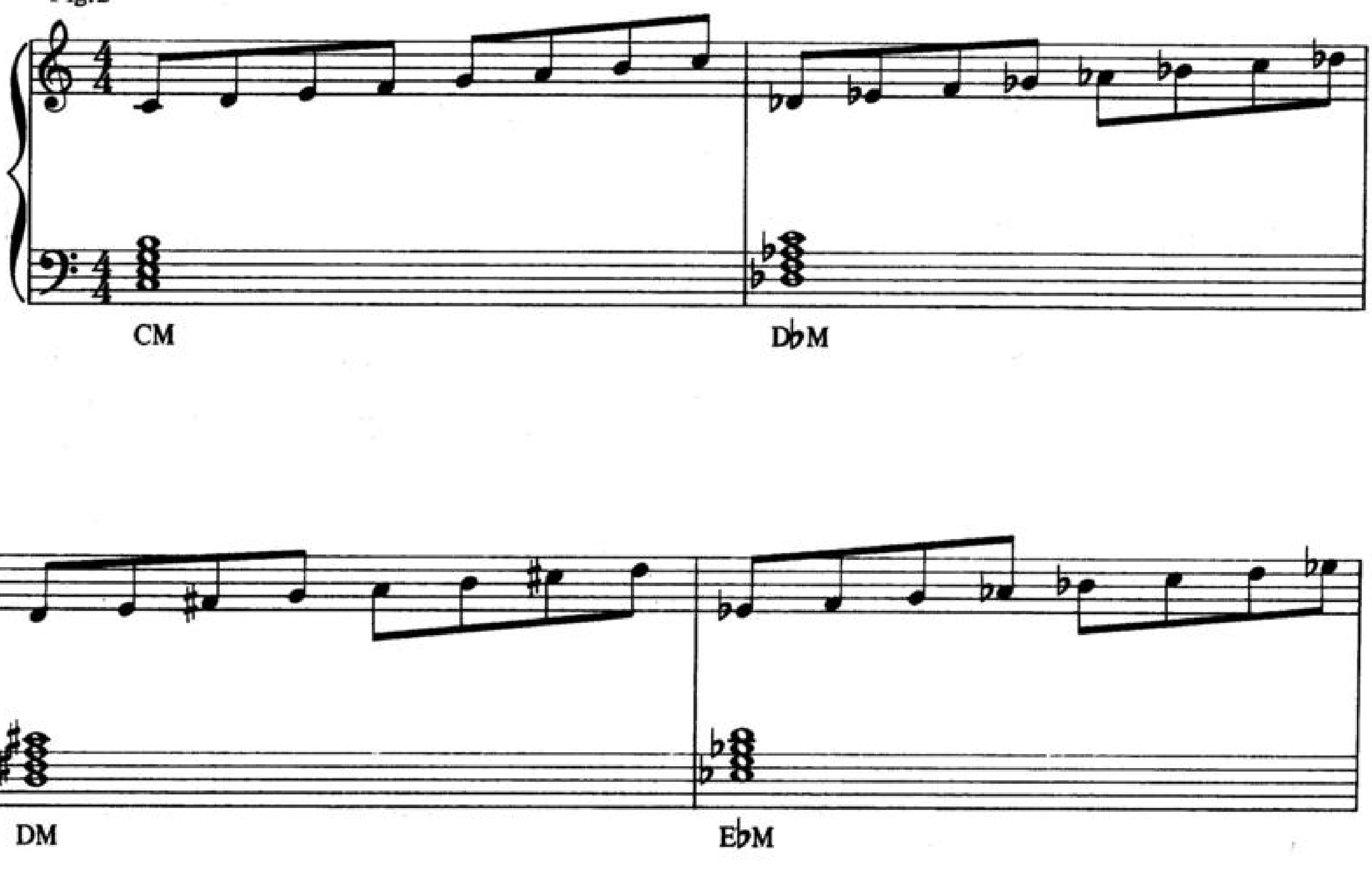
The Major 7th

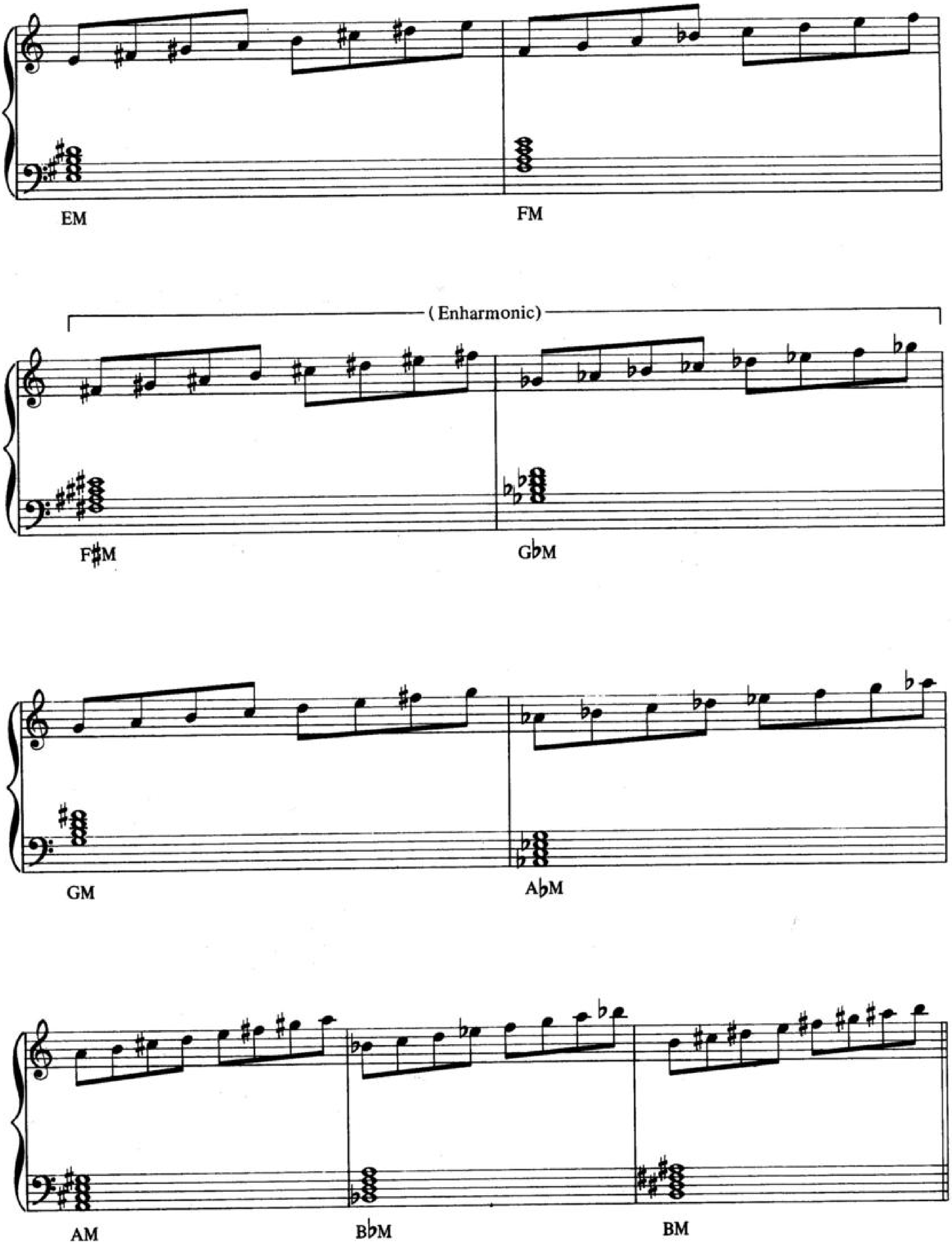
I - Ionian
IV - Lydian

The problem with the major chord lies in the fact that I is always I, but IV may be IV or I of a new key. Eventually, the decision as to which of the two modes to choose will be left to the student;but,for an initial drill all majors will be treated as I taking the Ionian mode.
Fig. 2 illustrates the twelve major chords with their accompanying Ionian modes. These modes should be practiced first one octave, then two, both ascending and descending for complete automatic facility.

The Major Scales

Fig.2

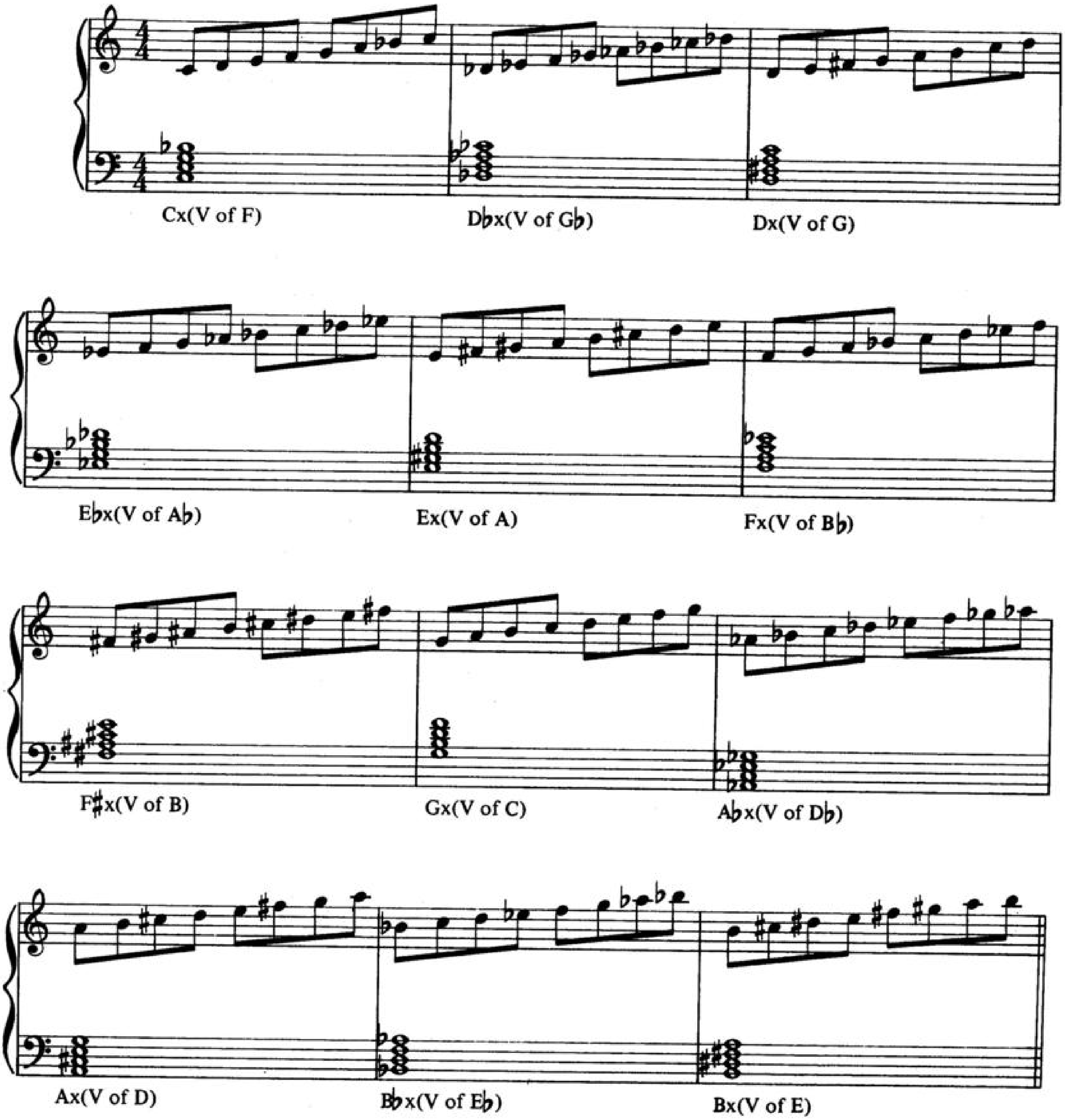



EM
FM
(Enharmonic)
F♯M
G♭M
GM
A♭M
AM
B♭M
BM

The Dominant seventh

There is never any question about the status of the dominant chord since it only appears in the position of V. Fig. 3 illustrates the twelve dominant chords with their accompanying Mixolydian modes. These modes should be practiced first one octave, then two, both ascending and descending for complete automatic facility.

The Dominant Scales

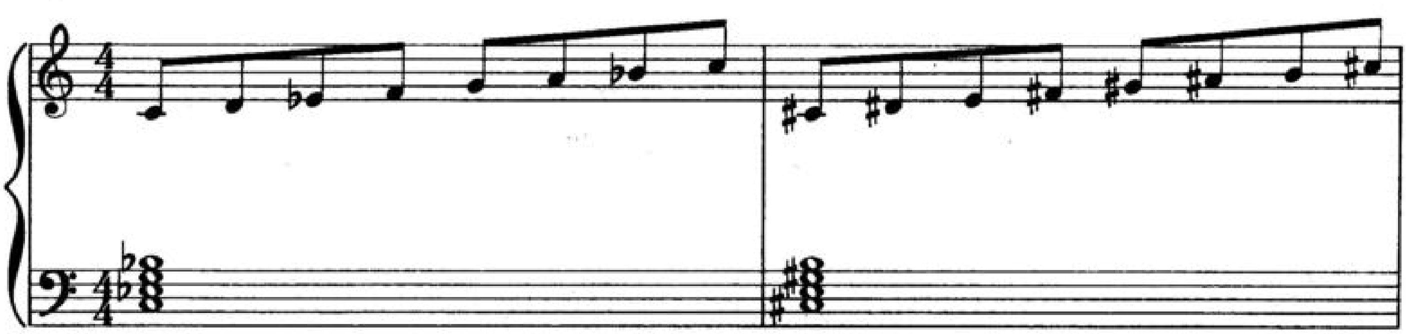
Fig. 3

The Minor 7th.

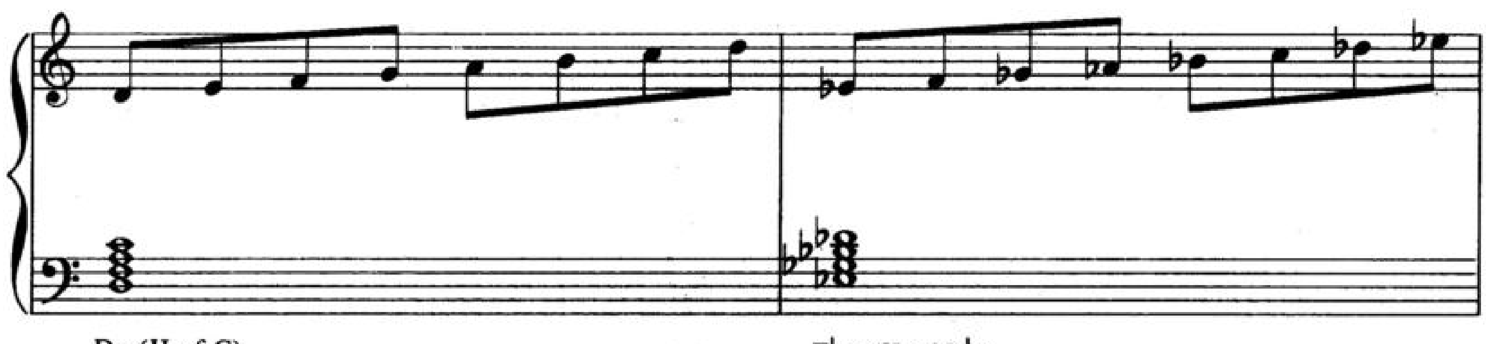
II - Dorian
III - Phrygian
VI - Aeolian

The minor chord is the most difficult to deal with since it appears in three positions (II - III - VI). For an initial drill the position of II (Dorian) will be used since the II position is the most commonly employed. Also the II chord forms an integral part of the basic cadence II - V - I (a basic anchor of all jazz improvisation). More advanced decisions should be left to the individual choice of the student.

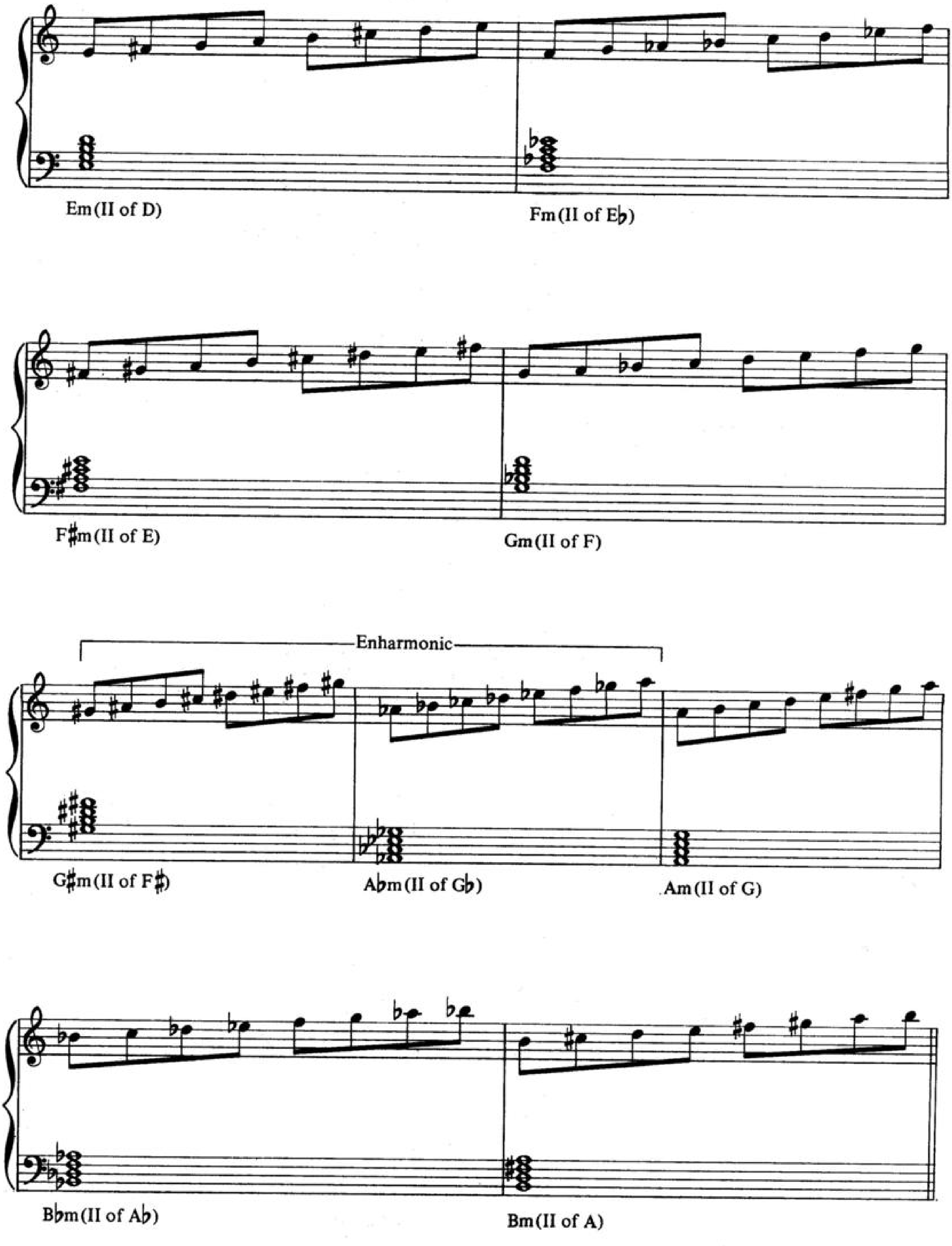
Fig. 4 illustrates the twelve minor chords with their accompanying Dorian modes. These modes should be practiced first one octave, then two, both ascending and descending for complete automatic facility.

The Minor Scales

Fig. 4

Cm(II of B♭) C♯m(II of B)



Dm(II of C) E♭m(II of D♭)

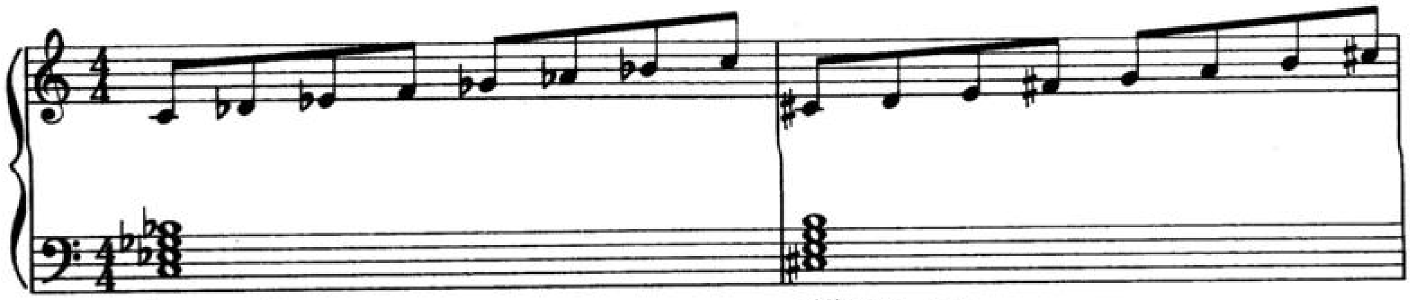
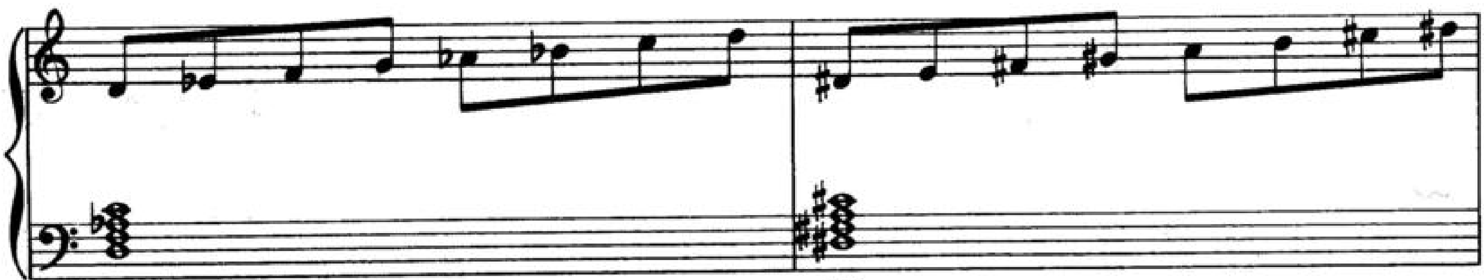
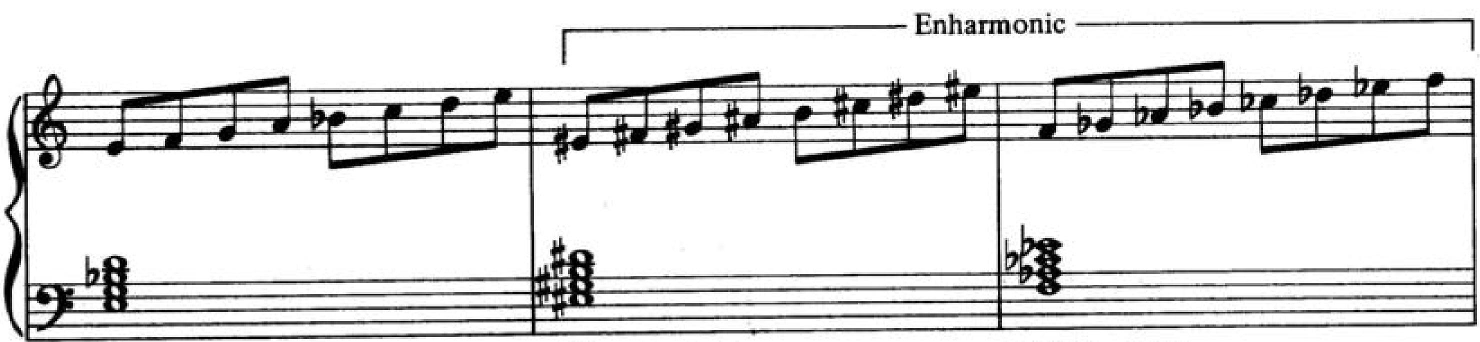
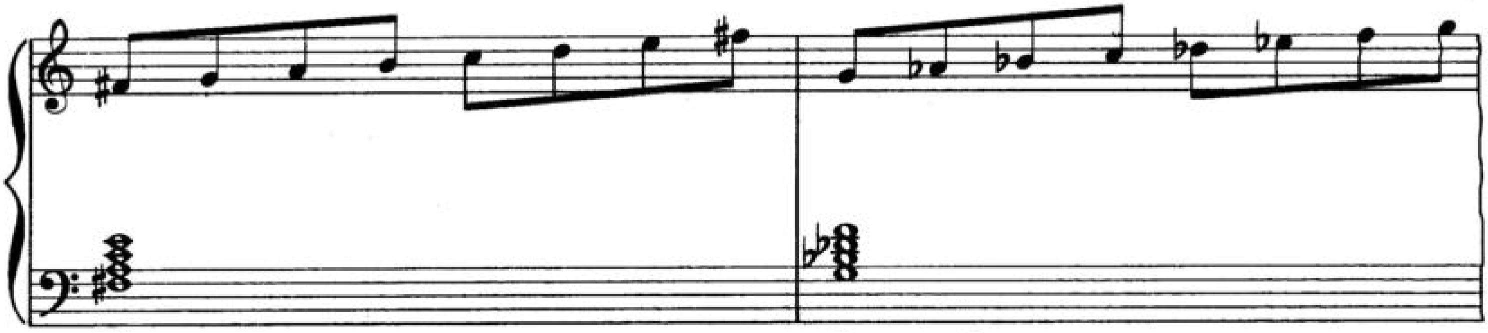
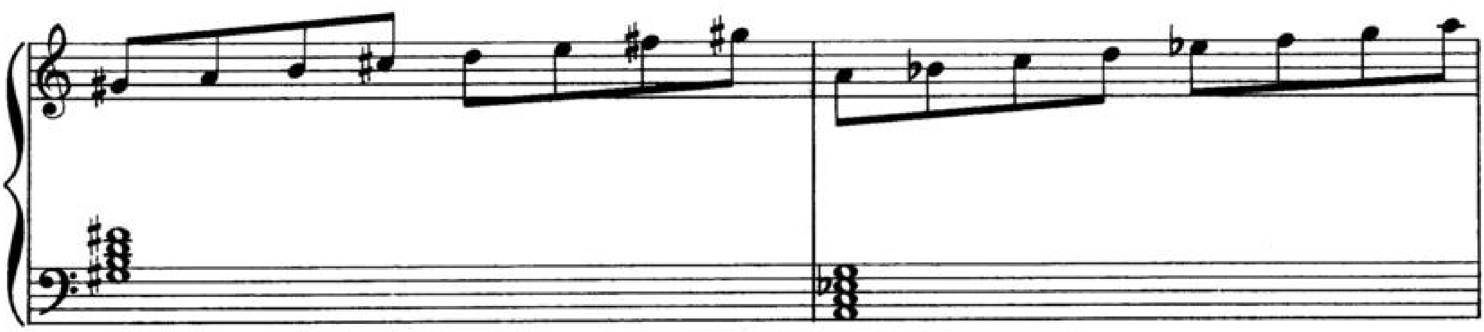
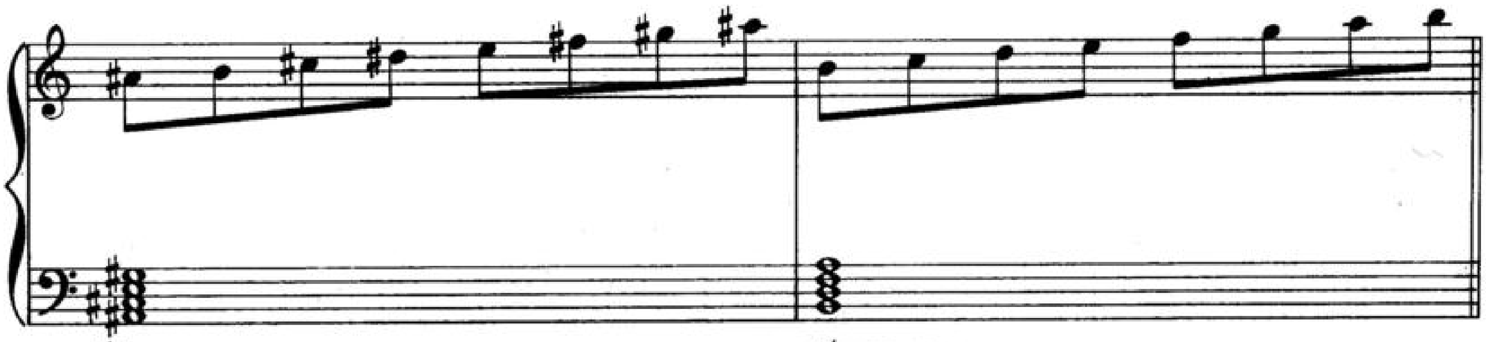

Em (II of D)
Fm (II of E♭)
F♯m (II of E)
Gm (II of F)
Enharmonic
G♯m (II of F♯)
A♭m (II of G♭)
Am (II of G)
B♭m (II of A♭)
Bm (II of A)

The Half Diminished Chord

Like the dominant chord, the half diminished chord appears in only one position (VII) and therefore always employs the Locrian mode.

Fig. 5 illustrates the twelve half diminished chords with their accompanying Locrian modes. These modes should be practiced first one octave, then two, both ascending and descending for complete automatic facility.

The Half Diminished Scales

Fig. 5

C⌀ (VII of D♭) C♯⌀ (VII of D)

D⌀ (VII of E♭) D♯⌀ (VII of E)

E⌀ (VII of F) E♯⌀ (VII of F♯) F⌀ (VII of G♭)

F♯ø (VII of G) Gø (VII of A♭)

G♯ø (VII of A) Aø (VII of B♭)

A♯ø (VII of B) Bø (VII of C)

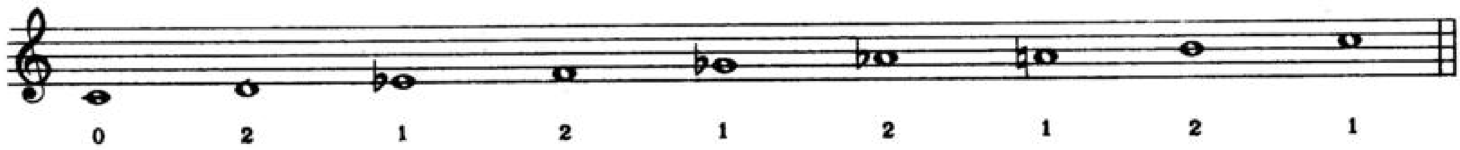
The Diminished Chord

The diminished chord presents a special problem since it does not appear naturally in the seventh chord system with which jazz is essentially concerned. To overcome this problem, jazz musicians have evolved two artificial scales which can be used interchangeably to accommodate the diminished chord. The two scales employ alternating major and minor seconds.

The Diminished Scales

Fig.6 and 7 illustrate the two alternating scales.

Fig. 6 Semitone combination: 021212121



2 indicates two half steps; 1 indicates one half step.

Fig. 7 Semitone combination: 012121212

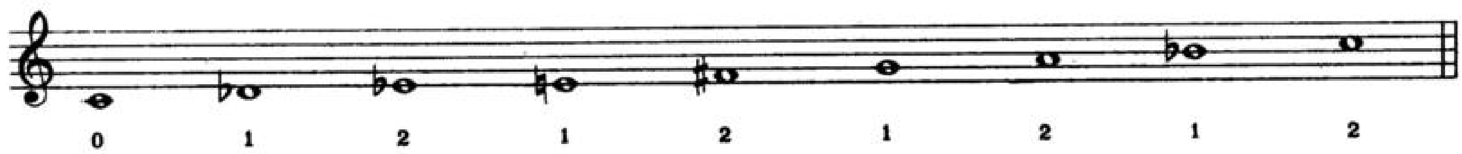


Fig. 8 illustrates the twelve 021212121 diminished scales. The numbers indicate suggested fingerings.

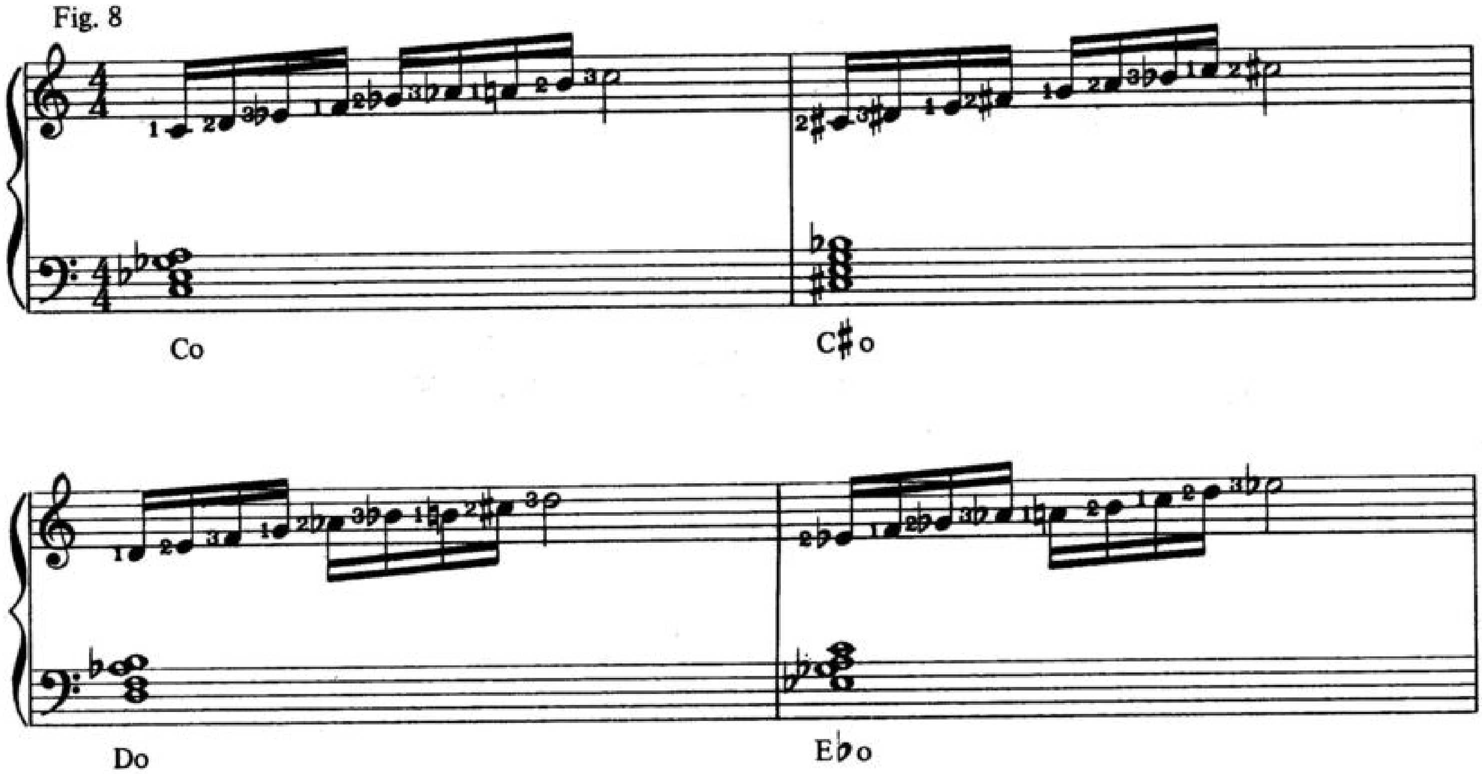
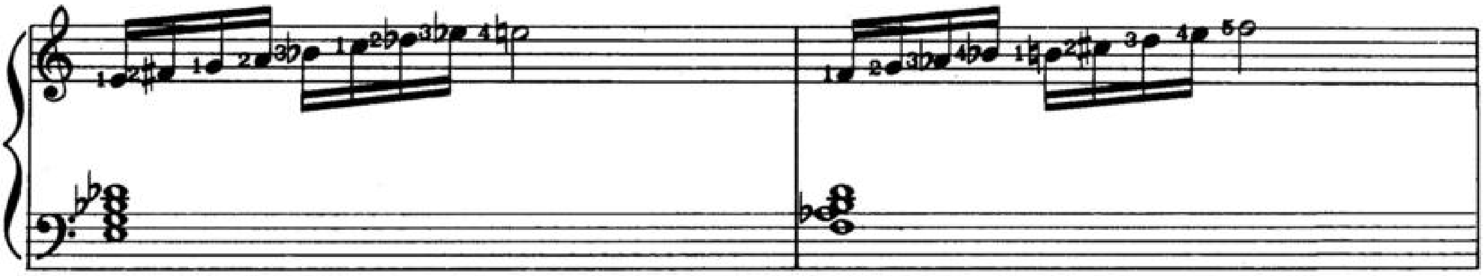
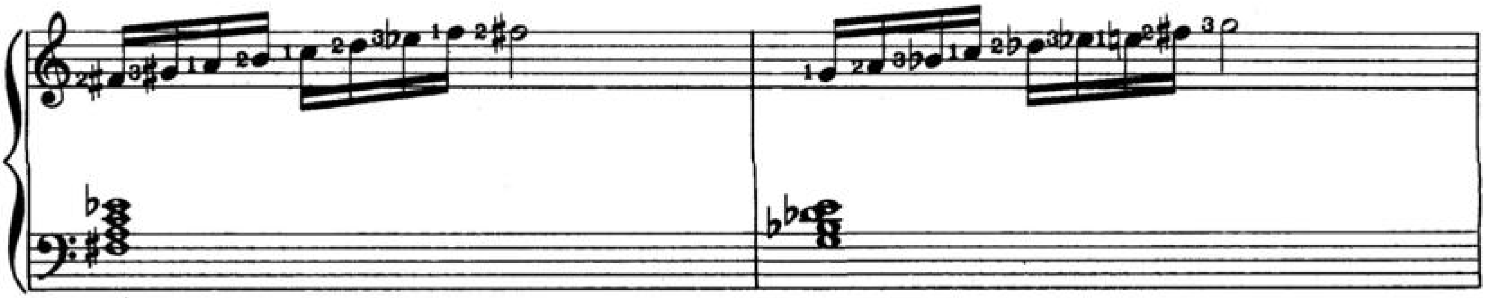
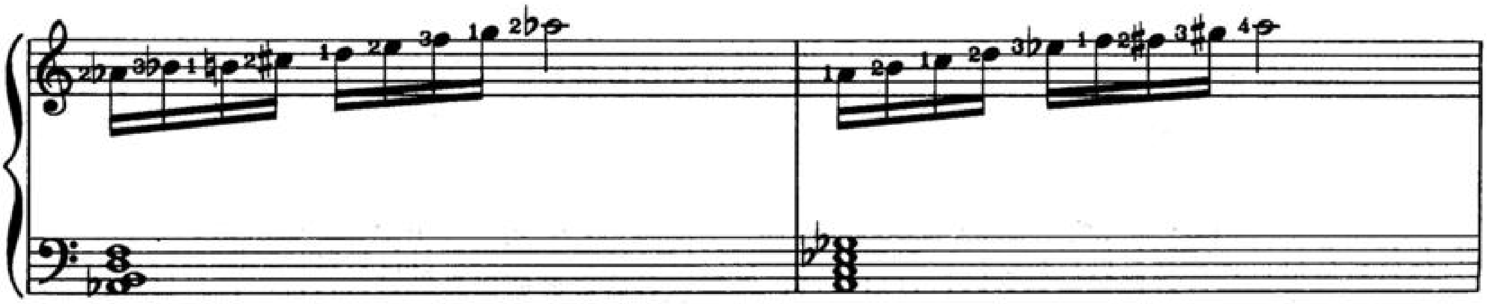
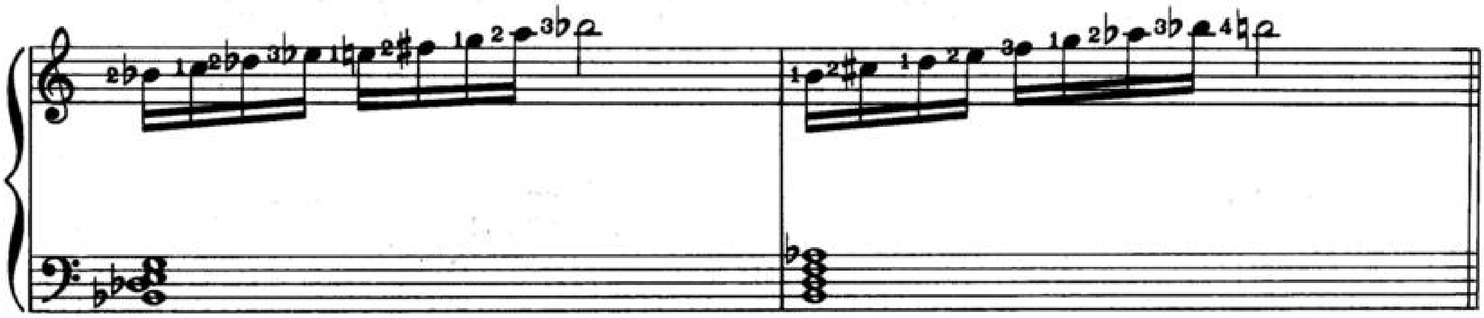
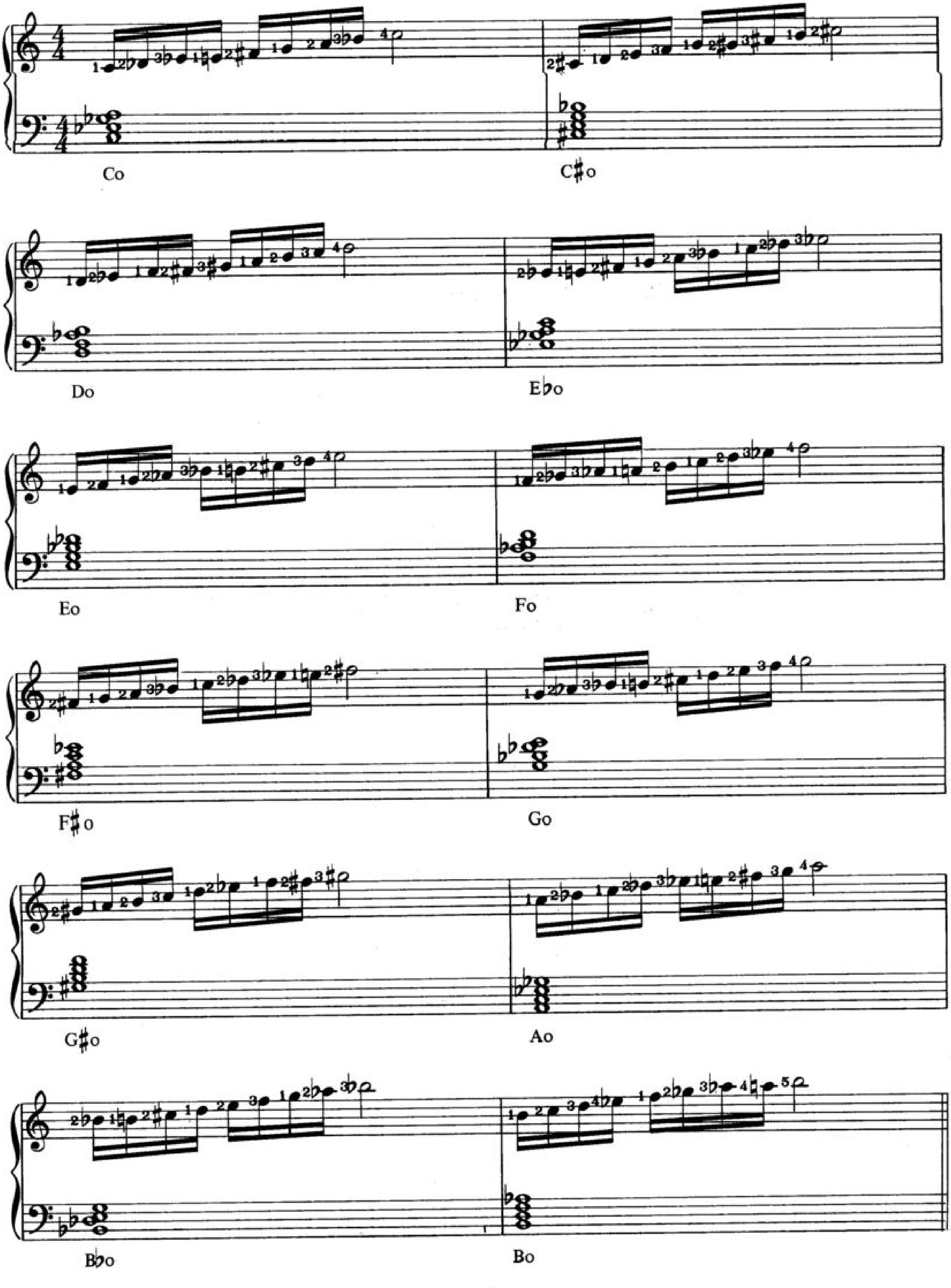
Fig. 8

Eo Fo

F♯o Go

A♭o Ao

B♭o Bo

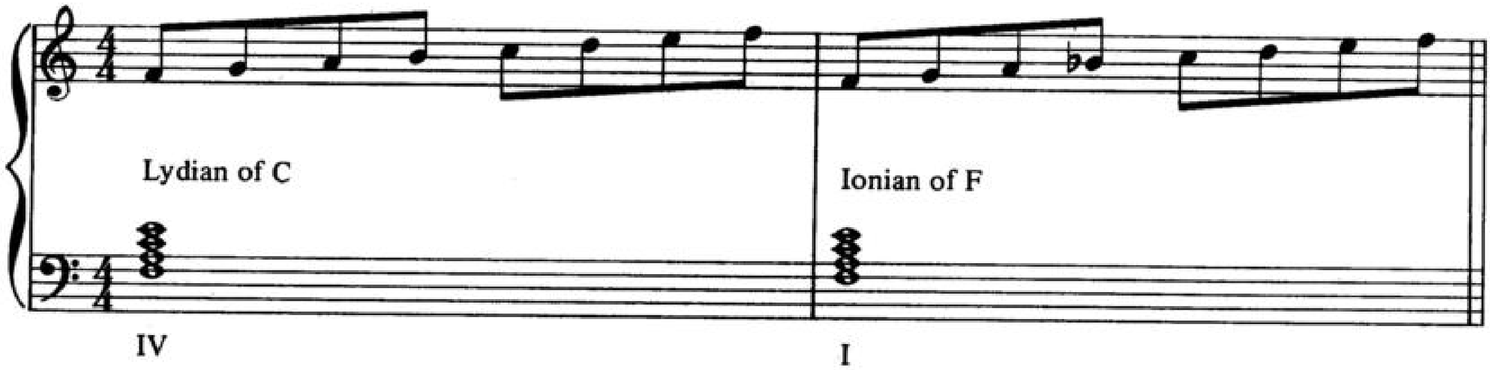
Fig. 9 illustrates the twelve 012121212 diminished scales. The numbers indicate suggested fingerings.

Fig. 9

Modal Improvisation (Part 2)

To complete the modal system we must deal with the three modes (Phrygian, Lydian, Aeolian) that were temporarilly put aside in Chapter Seventeen.

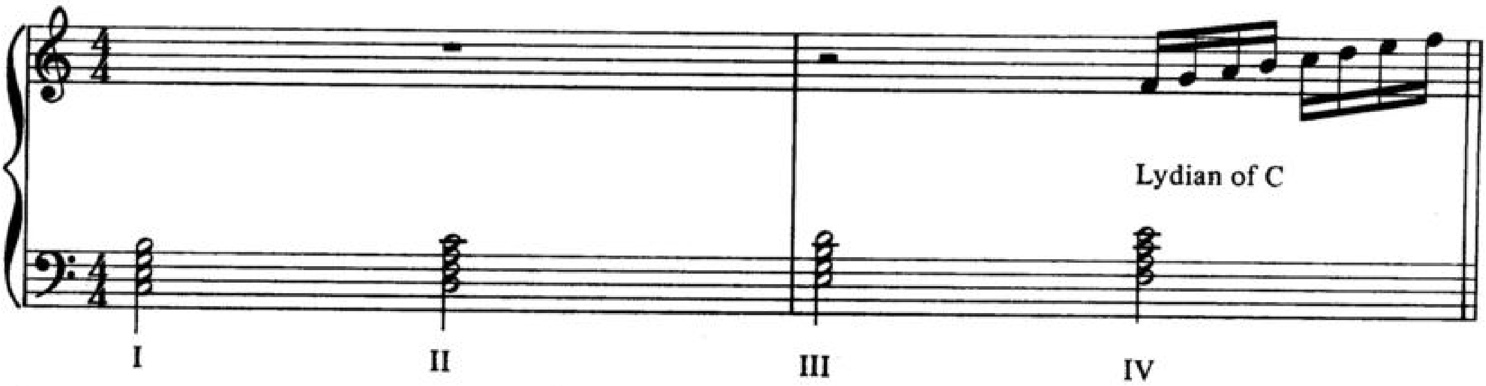
The IV chord may be treated as IV or the I of a new key. See Fig. 1

Fig. 1



What determines the status of the IV chord is the preceding harmony. In Fig. 2, the harmony is centered around the I chord so that IV would assume its natural role and take the Lydian mode.

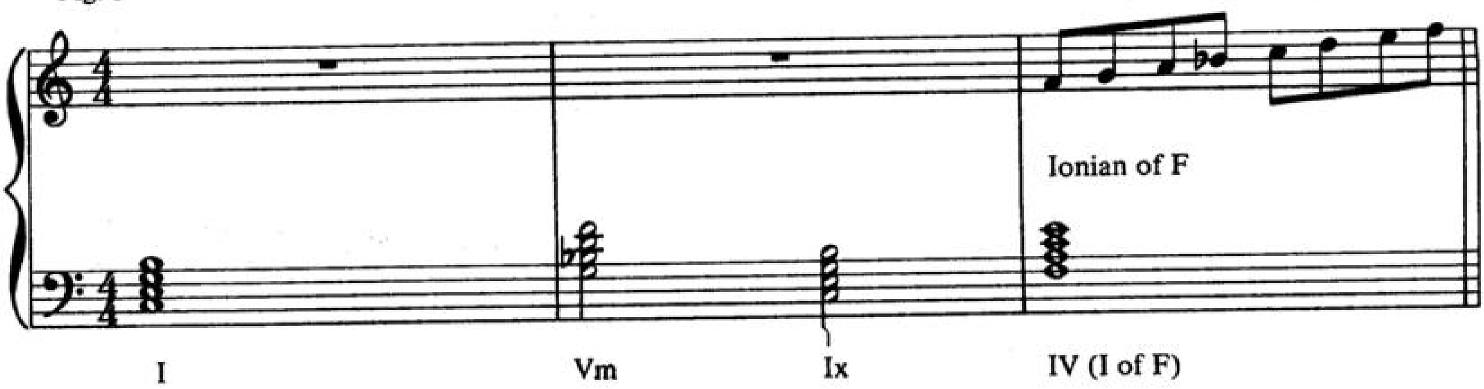
Fig. 2



In Fig. 3, the key center around I has been weakened by the Vm and Ix and, as a result, the IV becomes the I of F.

As with all these modal conflicts, the student should make the decision concerning the "status" of the chord.

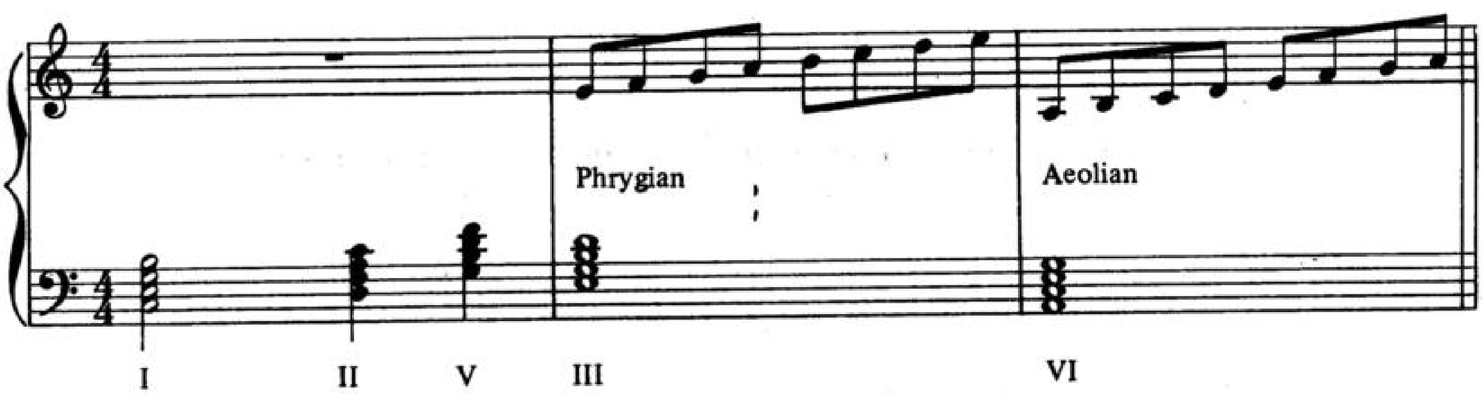
Fig. 3



The III chord and the VI chord may be the III or VI of the original key or the II of a new key.

In Fig. 4, the strong tonal center establishes III as III and VI as VI.

Fig. 4



In Fig. 5, the secondary functions in the case of III (IVm, ♭VIIx) and VI (VIIm, IIIx) establish the III as the II of D and the VI as the II of G.

Fig. 5

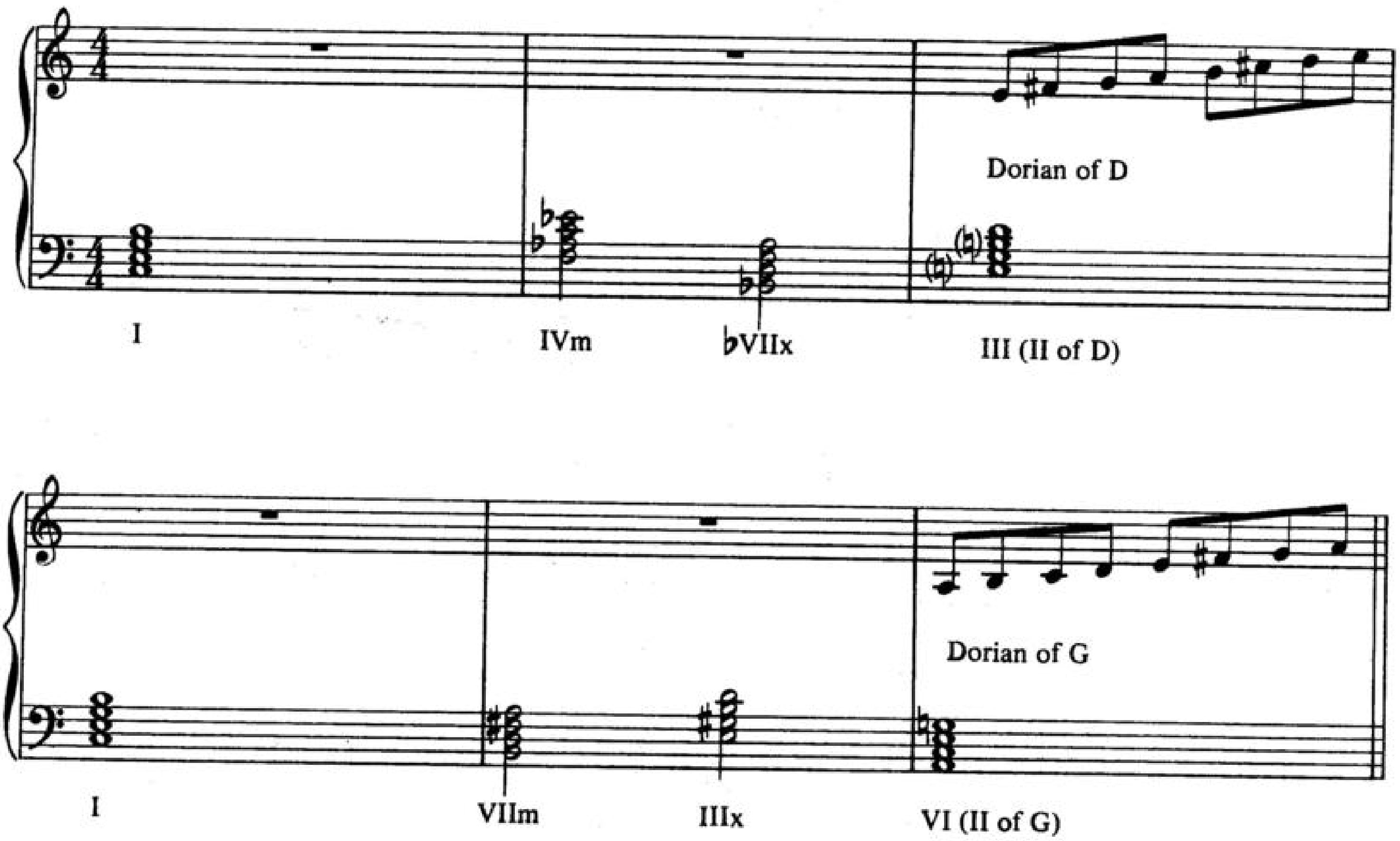



Fig. 6 illustrates the application of modal improvisation to "Polka Dots and Moonbeams" in the key of F. The III - IV and VI chords have been indicated as to status.

The bass line for Fig. 6 is as follows:

Introduction

(F) I VI / II ♭Vm VIIx // I VI/ IV II VIIm ♭VIIx/VI II$\phi\frac{4}{3}$ /VI$_2$ IV III ♭III/

(F) II V VII$\frac{4}{3}$ /III VI II V / I VI / II ♭Vm VIIx/

(F) I VI/ IV II VIIm ♭VIIx/ VI II$\phi\frac{4}{3}$ / VI$_2$ IV III ♭III/

(F) II ♭IIx / I^{+6} (A) IIϕ ♭IIx/I ♯Io/ II V /

(A) III VI / II ♭IIx / I ♯Io / II V //

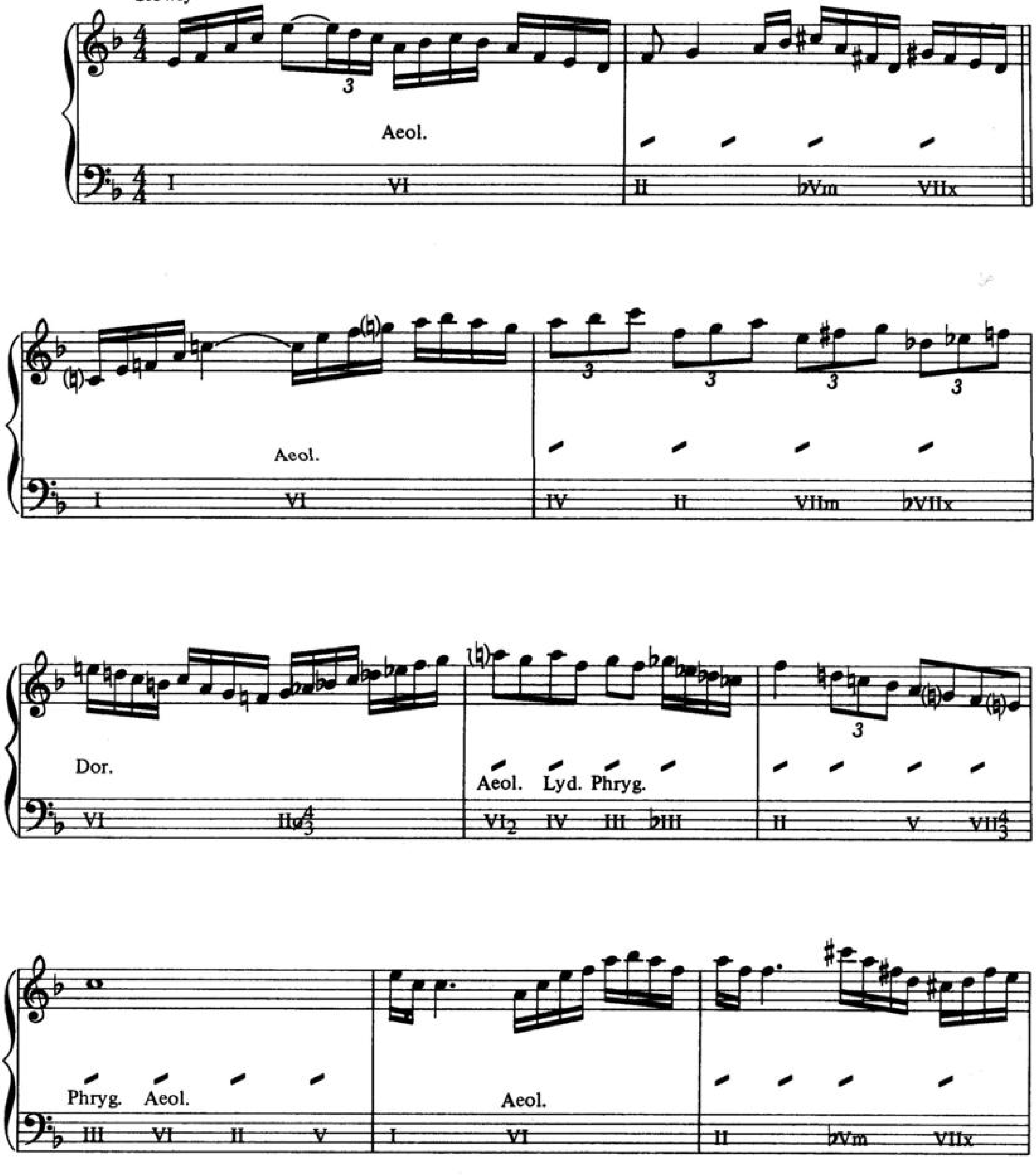
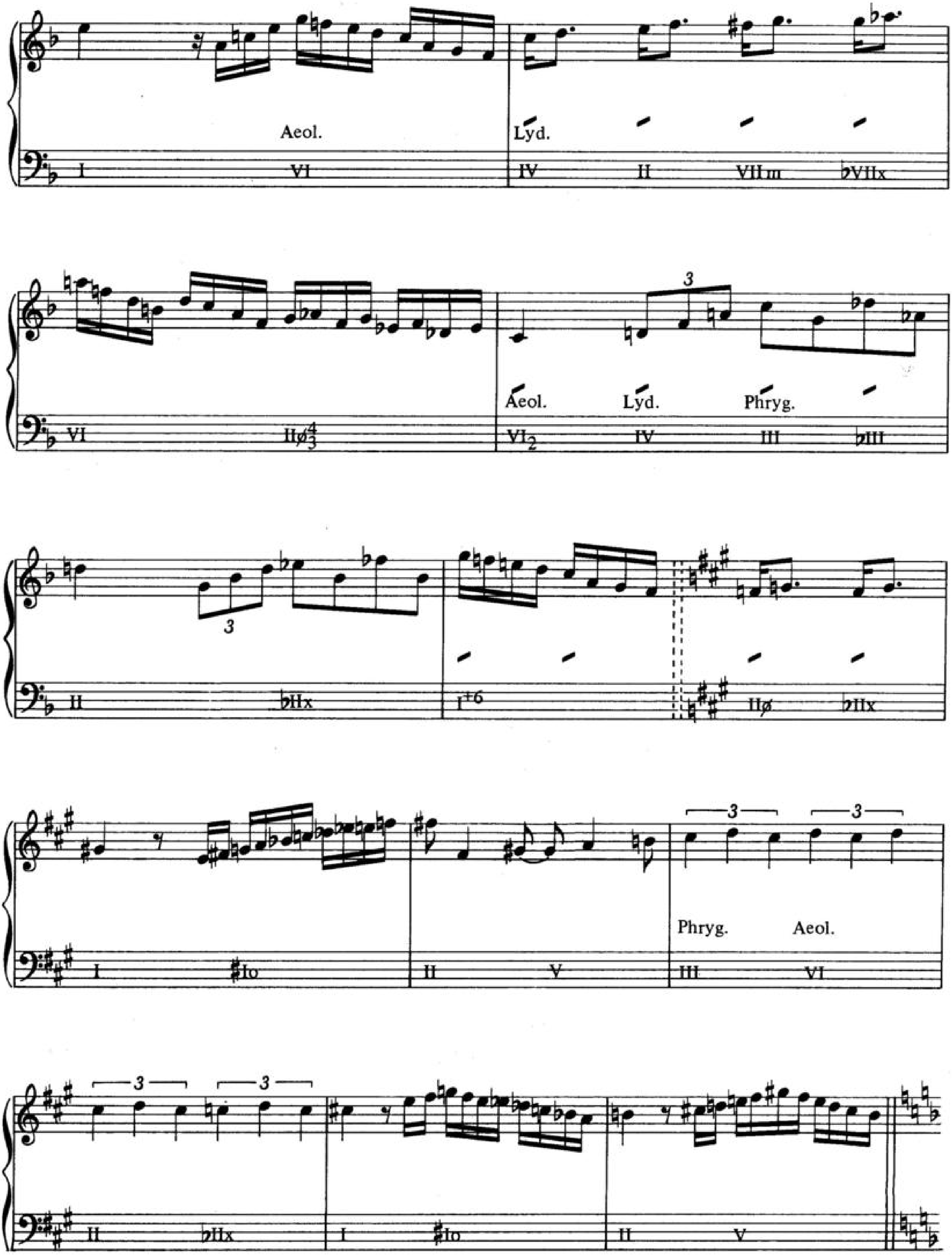
(F) III VIx /II V / I VI / II ♭Vm VIIx /

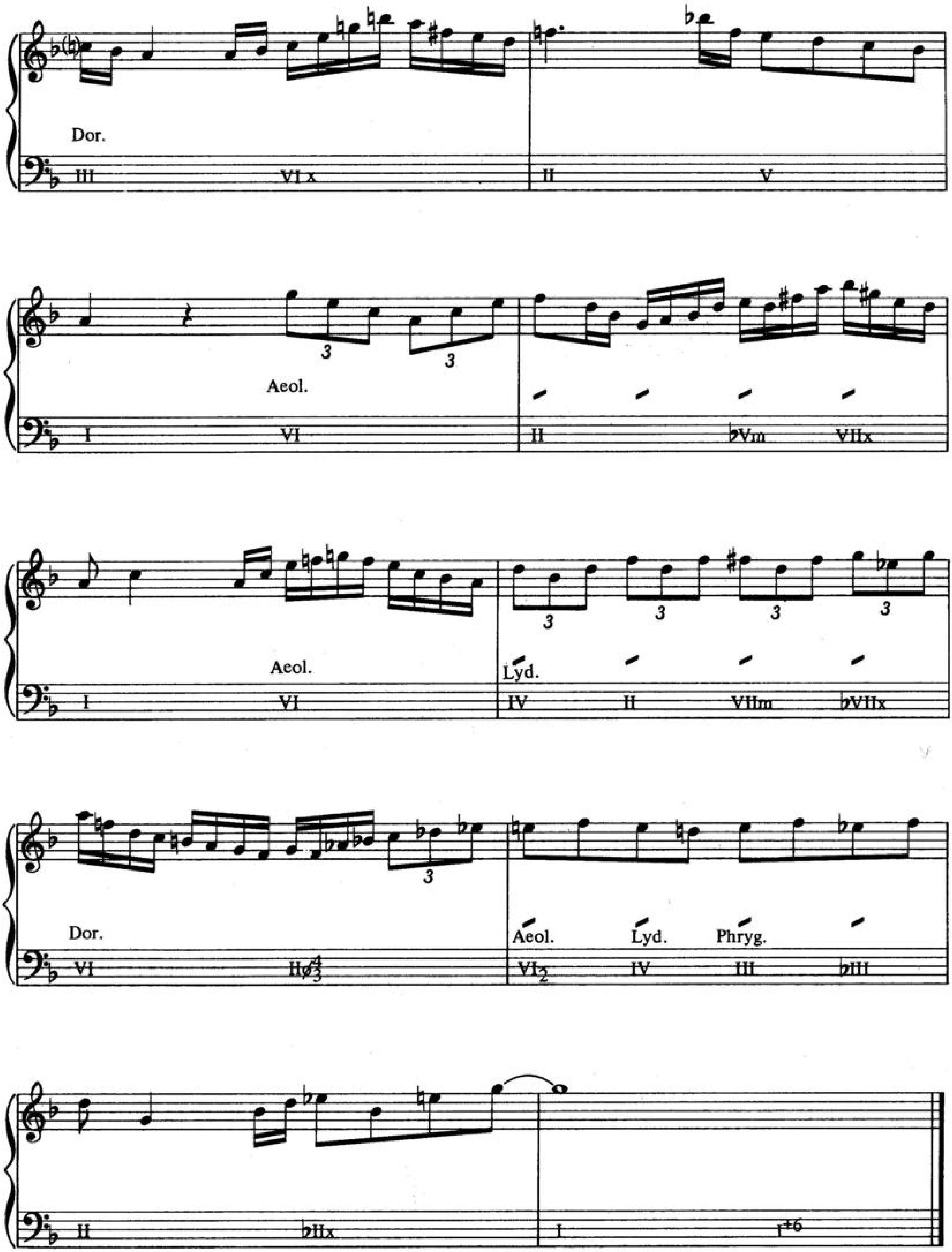
(F) I VI/ IV II VIIm ♭VIIx/VI IIϕ $\frac{4}{3}$ / VI$_2$ IV III ♭III /II ♭IIx / I //

Polka Dots and Moonbeams

Fig. 6 Key of F

words and music by
Johnny Burke and James Van Heusen

Introduction
Slowly


Aeol.
I
VI
Lyd.
IV
II
VIIm
♭VIIx
VI
IIø4/3
Aeol.
Lyd.
Phryg.
VI2
IV
III
♭III
II
♭IIx
I+6
IIø
♭IIx
I
♯Io
II
V
Phryg.
Aeol.
III
VI
II
♭IIx
I
♯Io
II
V


Dor.
III
VI x
II
V
Aeol.
I
VI
II
♭Vm
VIIx
Aeol.
Lyd.
I
VI
IV
II
VIIm
♭VIIx
Dor.
VI
II∅4/3
Aeol.
Lyd.
Phryg.
VI2
IV
III
♭III
II
♭IIx
I
I+6

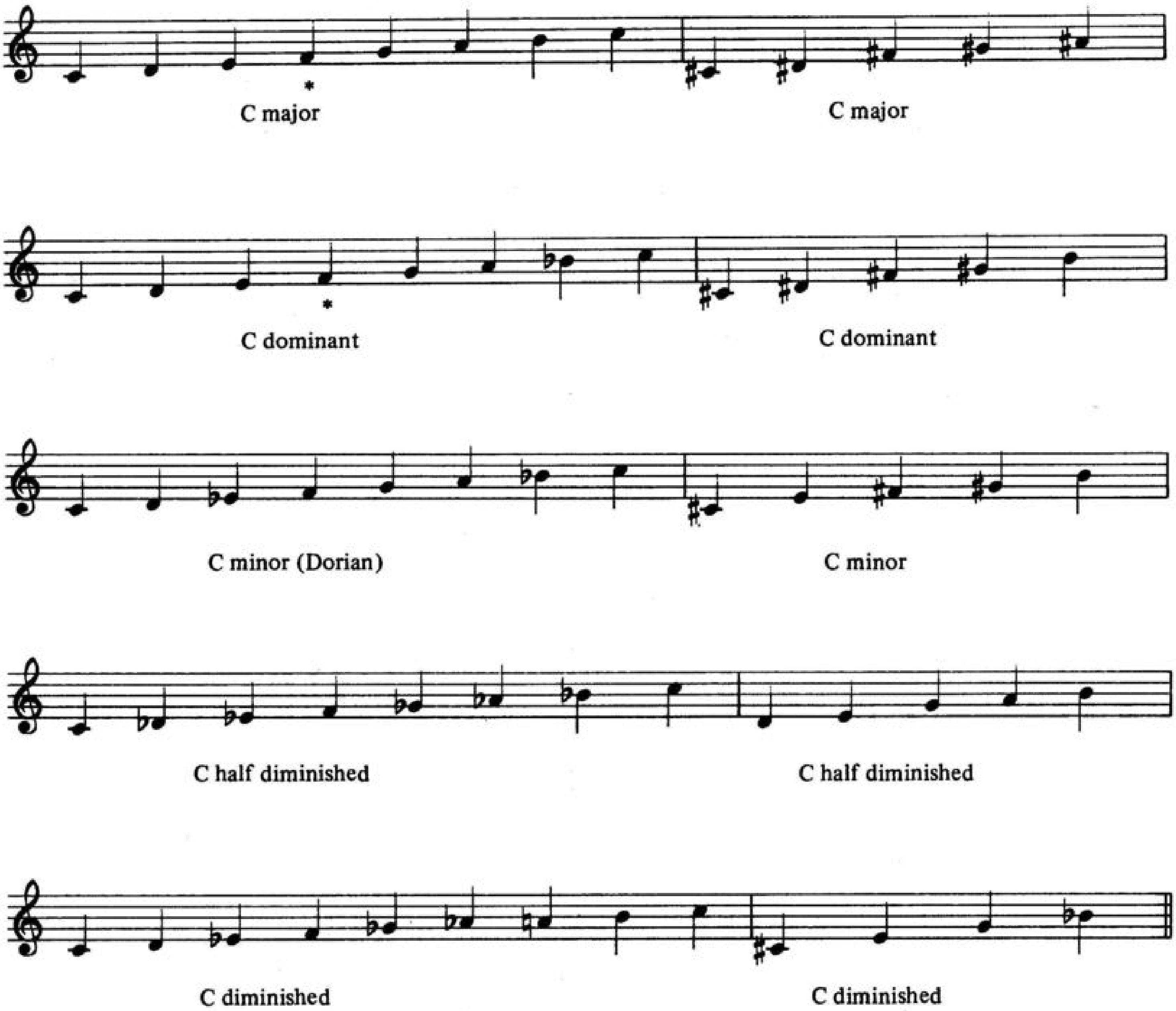
The Non-modal Tones

The non - modal tones, often referred to as "blue notes", represent an important element in jazz improvisation since the tension created by these tones can add enormous excitement to a jazz performance.

It is often said that since Charlie Parker, there is no such thing as a "wrong" note, only the performer's ability to make it sound "right". However, the performer must keep a proper balance between the tension of the non - modal tones and the release of the modal tones.

Fig 1. illustrates the non - modal or, in the case of the diminished scale, non - scale tones relating to the five qualities.

Fig. 1 Modal Tones Non - modal Tones



* The fourth step of both the major and dominant scales is often considered a tension tone unless the 3rd in the chord is raised to form an octave.

The non-modal tones in Fig. 1 break down into two categories

1. Passing tones
2. Ornamental tones

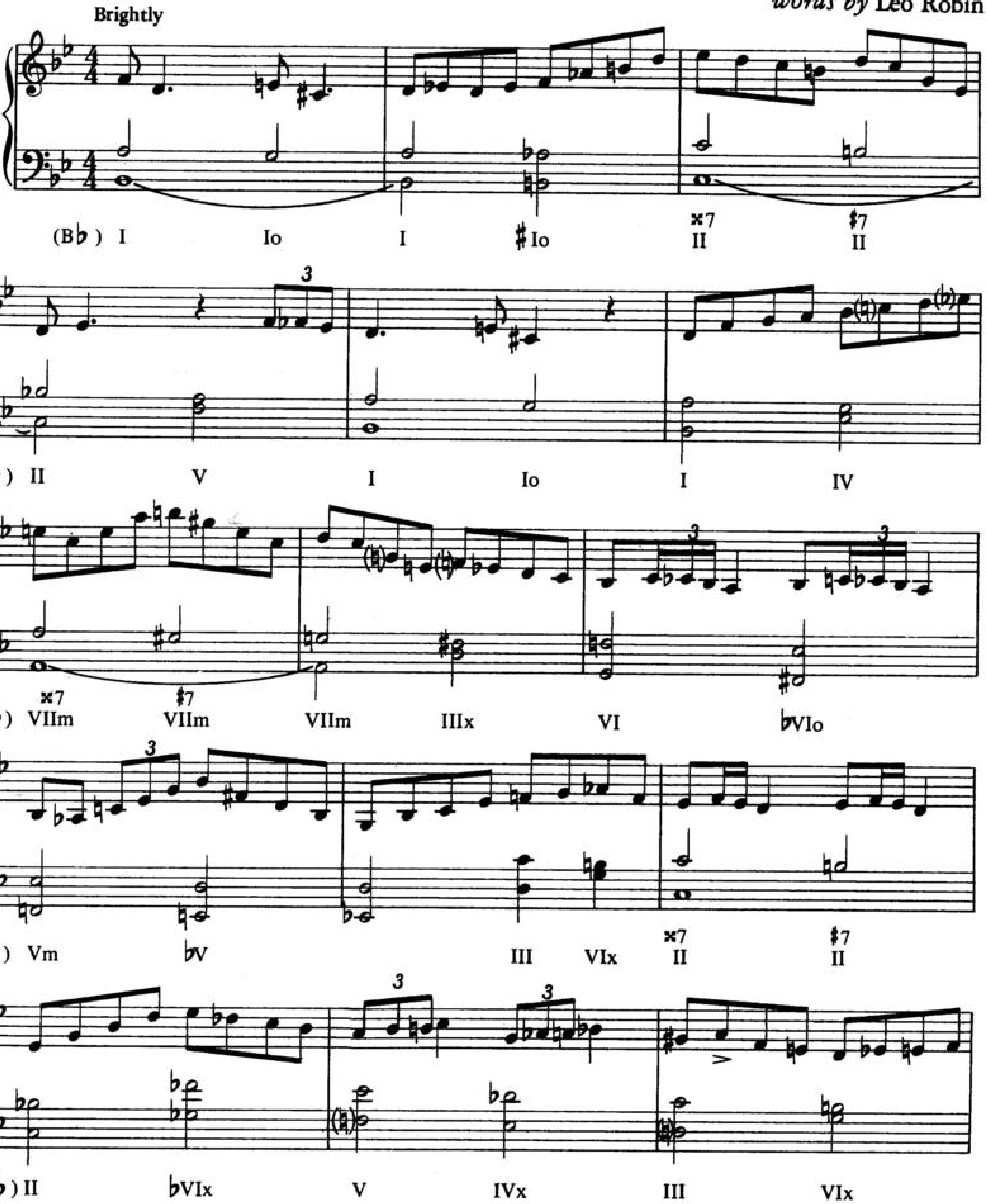
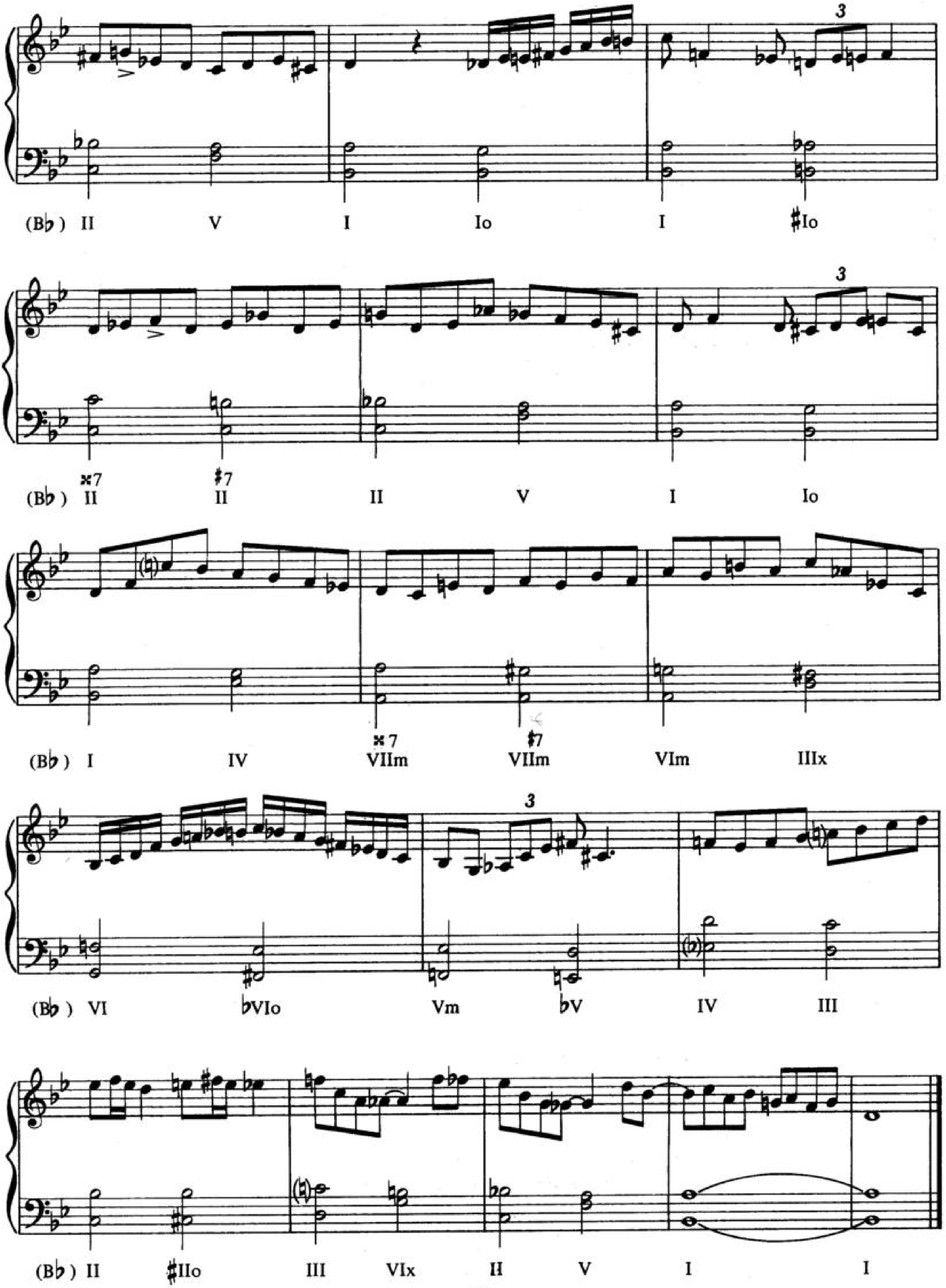
Passing tones	Ornamental tones
C major: C♯ D♯ A♯	F♯ = augmented 11th G♯ (if also raised in chord to form M7♯5)
C dominant: B	C♯ (D♭) = flatted 9th D♯ = augmented 9th F♯ = augmented 11th G♯ (A♭) = flatted 13th
C minor: C♯ E F♯ G♯ B	
C half diminished: E G A B	D = 9th
C diminished: C♯ E G B♭	

The use of ornamental tones in harmony will be thoroughly studied in a succeeding chapter. Fig. 2 illustrates the use of both passing tones and ornamental tones as they apply to the improvised line on "Bye Bye Baby". The following is the bass line for "Bye Bye Baby" in B♭.

```
                          x7  ♯7
(B♭) I   Io/ I  ♯Io / II   II / II   V /
                      x7        ♯7
(B♭) I   Io/ I   IV/ VIIm    VIIm / VIIm   IIIx /
                                  / / /    /       x7    ♯7
(B♭) VI  ♭VIo / Vm  ♭V / IV   III   VIx  / II    II  /

(B♭) II  ♭VIx / V   IVx  / III   VIx  / II   V /
                         x7   ♯7
(B♭) I    Io  /I  ♯Io  / II    II   / II   V /
                             x7         ♯7
(B♭) I    Io   / I   IV   / VIIm    VIIm    / VIm  IIIx /

(B♭) VI   ♭VIo  / Vm    ♭V   / IV    III  / II   ♯IIo  /

(B♭) III    VIx  / II    V   / I      / I        //
```

Bye, Bye Baby

Fig. 2

music by Jule Styne
words by Leo Robin


(B♭) II V I Io I ♯Io
×7 ♯7
(B♭) II II II V I Io
×7 ♯7
(B♭) I IV VIIm VIIm VIm IIIx
(B♭) VI ♭VIo Vm ♭V IV III
(B♭) II ♯IIo III VIx II V I I

Chapter 20

Early Contemporary Left Hand Voicings

As was apparent in the transition from swing to bop piano (Chapters eleven and twelve) and again from bop to early contemporary (Chapters twelve and thirteen), revolutionary changes took place in the left hand structures employed in jazz piano.

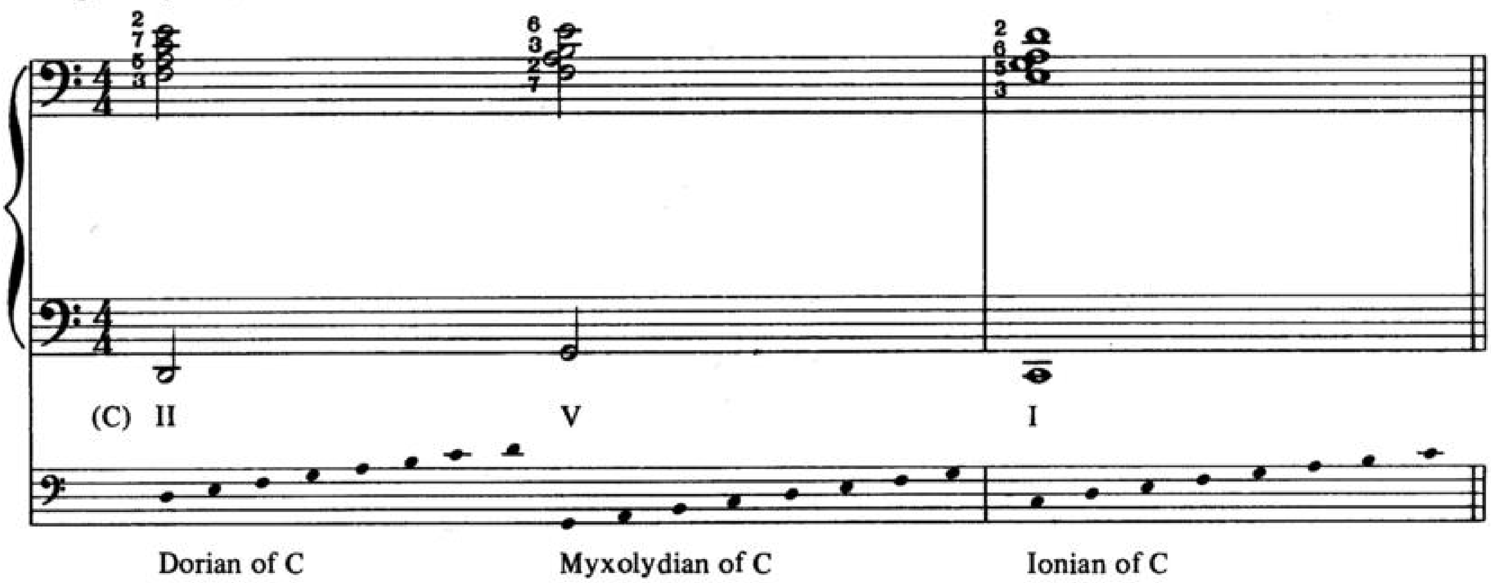
Early contemporary left hand voicings began with two structures associated with classical piano. The earlier structure (referred to in this text as the (A) form) is usually attributed to Chopin and can be found extensively in his piano compositions. The more modern structure (referred to in this text as the (B) form) is usually attributed to the French impressionists, especially Maurice Ravel.

The following table describes the basic II-V-I procedure for the (A) form employing the Dorian, Mixolydian and Ionian modes.

II - 3572 - Dorian
V - 7236 - Mixolydian
I - 3562 - Ionian
See Fig. 1

The (A) Form

Fig. 1 Key of C



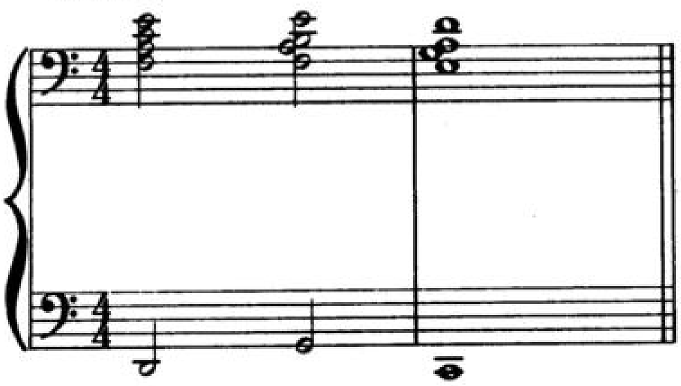
In the initial drill (Fig. 2), the voicings are played by the right hand in the middle C area; the root (which eventually would be assumed by the bass player in a group) is played by the left hand in the deeper range of the bass clef.

The II chord in each case creates a minor ninth chord; the V chord in each case creates a dominant nine thirteen chord; the I chord in each case creates a major ninth chord with an added sixth.

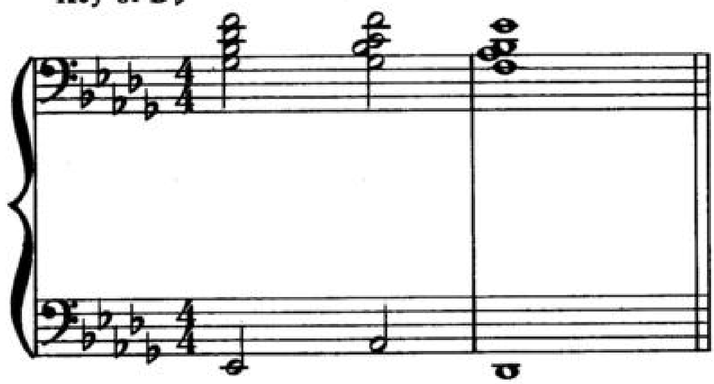
The (A) form will be studied in the keys of C, D♭, D, E♭, E and F.
This is to ensure that the register of the voicings is always around middle C.

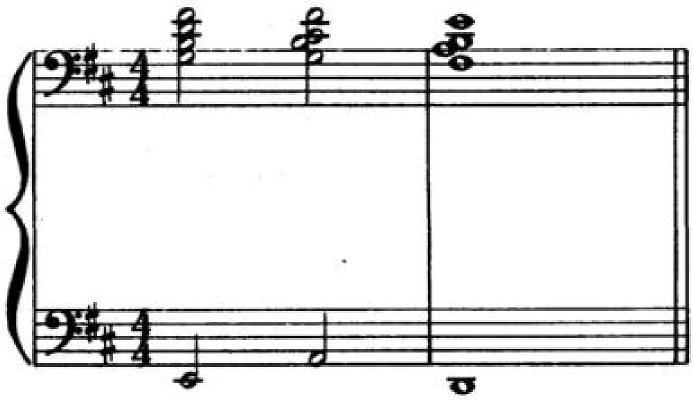
Fig. 2 Drill

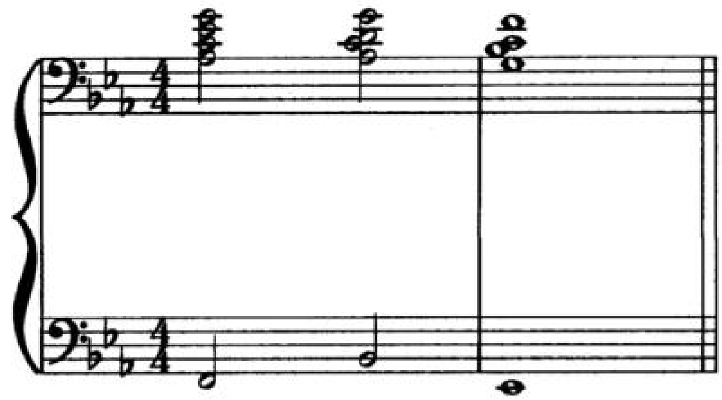
Key of C

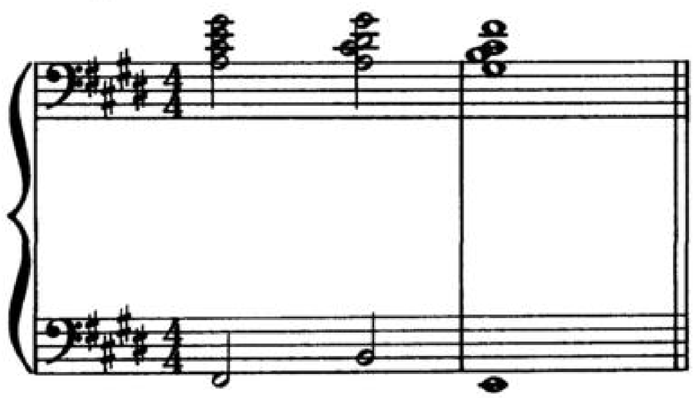


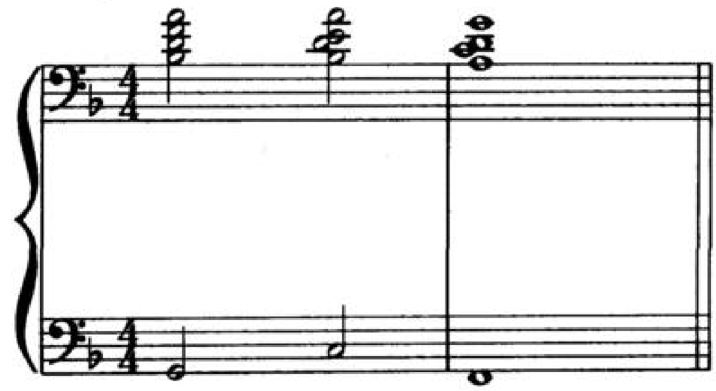
(C) II V I

Key of D♭

(D♭) II V I

Key of D

(D) II V I

Key of E♭

(E♭) II V I

Key of E

(E) II V I

Key of F

(F) II V I

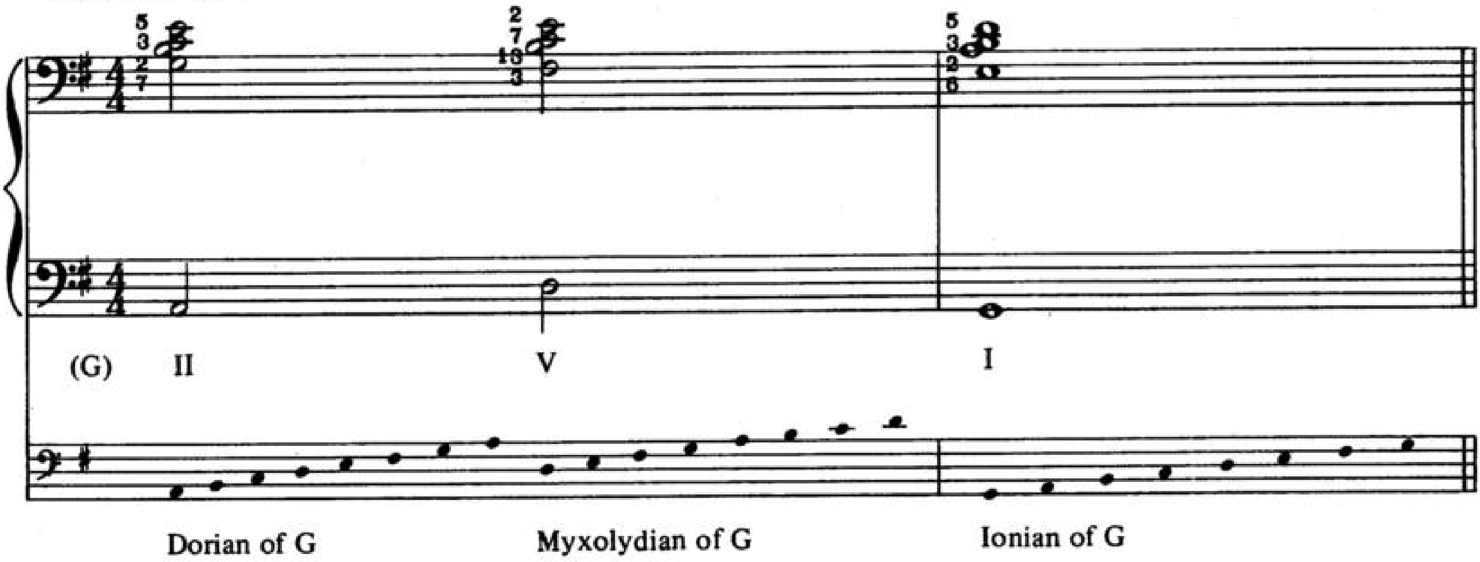
The following table describes the basic II - V - I procedure for the (B) form employing the Dorian, Mixolydian and Ionian modes.

II	-	7 2 3 5	-	Dorian
V	-	3 13 7 2	-	Mixolydian
I	-	6 2 3 5	-	Ionian

See Fig. 3

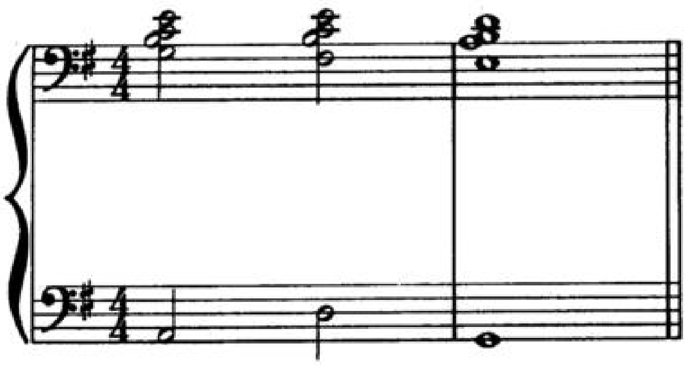
The (B) Form

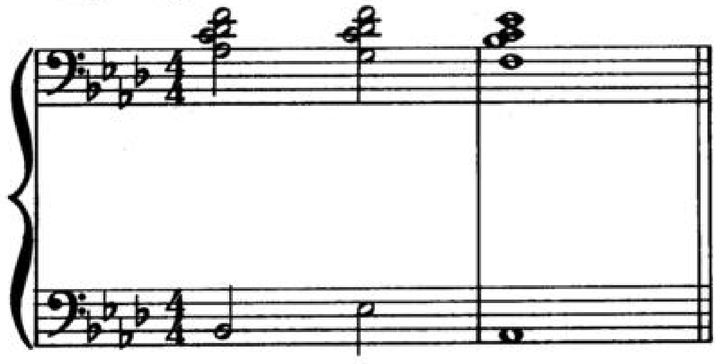
Fig. 3 Key of G

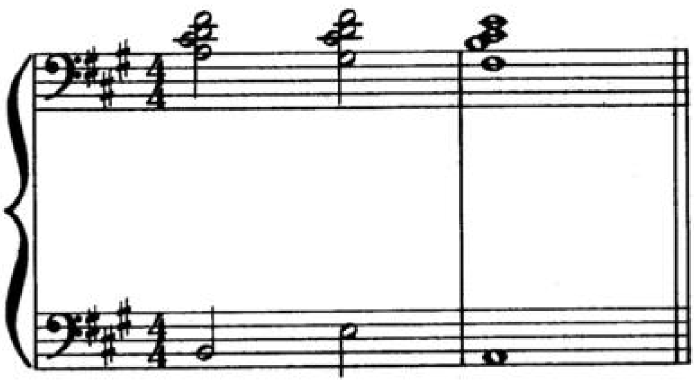


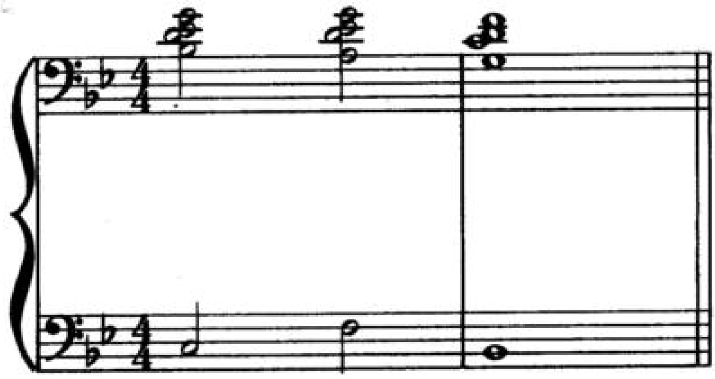
In the initial drill (Fig. 4), the (B) form will be studied in the keys of G, A♭, A, B♭, B and F♯. This is to ensure that the register of the voicings is always around middle C.

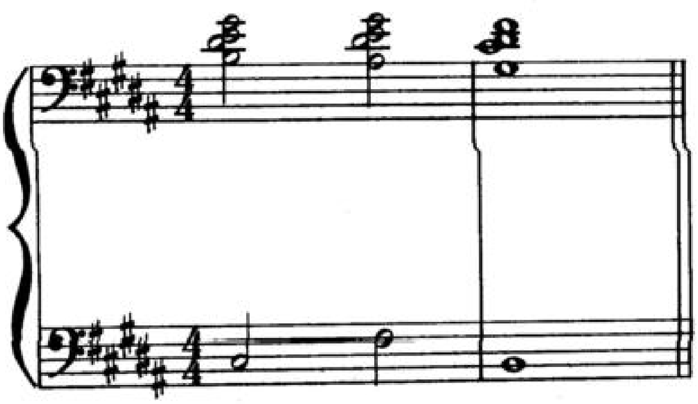
Fig. 4 Drill

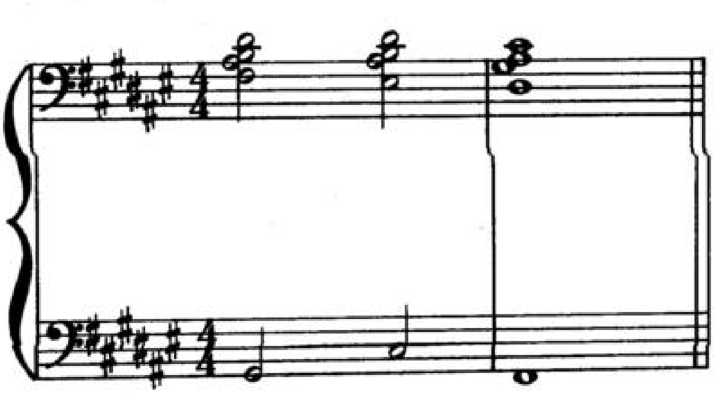
Key of G

(G) II V I

Key of A♭

(A♭) II V I

Key of A

(A) II V I

Key of B♭

(B♭) II V I

Key of B

(B) II V I

Key of F♯

(F♯) II V I

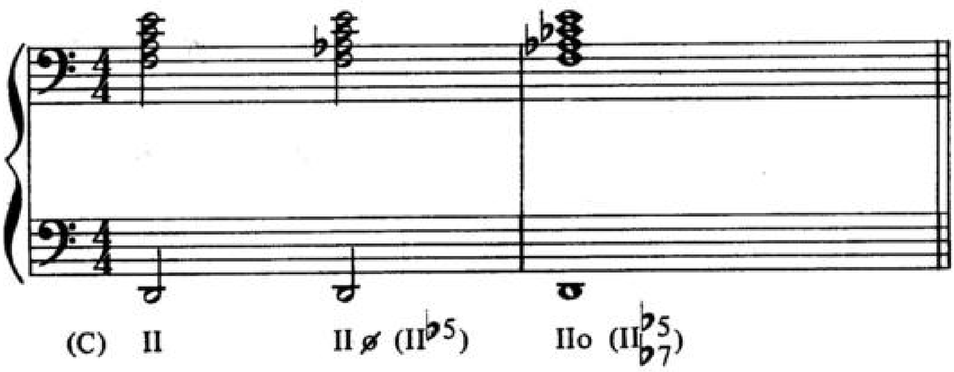
The use of II - V - I is due to its elemental role in jazz improvisation. *The problem now is to break open the II - V - I capsule in order to* accommodate the Sixty Chord demands of jazz

Therefore:

All major chords are I
All dominant chords are V
All minor chords are II
All half diminished chords are $II^{\flat 5}$] See note
All diminished chords are $II^{\flat 5}_{\flat 7}$

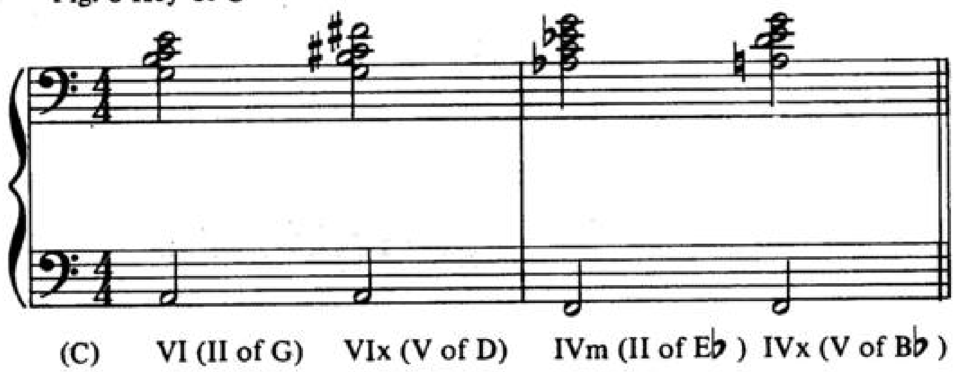
Note: In the case of half diminished and diminished chords, the voicings are derived from the chord (minor) with the most similar intervals to ø and o. (See Fig. 5)

Fig. 5 Key of C



If the student attempts to play the (A) form in the (B) form keys or vice versa, it will be noticed immediately that the voicing is too low or too high and removed from the middle C area. To avoid this the following rule is applied:
If the parent key of the chord occurs between C and F (C, D♭, D, E♭, E, F), use the (A) form ; if the parent key occurs between F♯ and B (F♯, G, A♭, A, B♭, B), use the (B) form.
For example, VI in the key of C (a minor chord) becomes the temporary II of G and takes the (B) form (G is a (B) form key). On the other hand, VIx in the key of C (a dominant chord) is the temporary V of D and takes the (A) form (D is an (A) form key). (See Fig. 6)

Fig. 6 Key of C



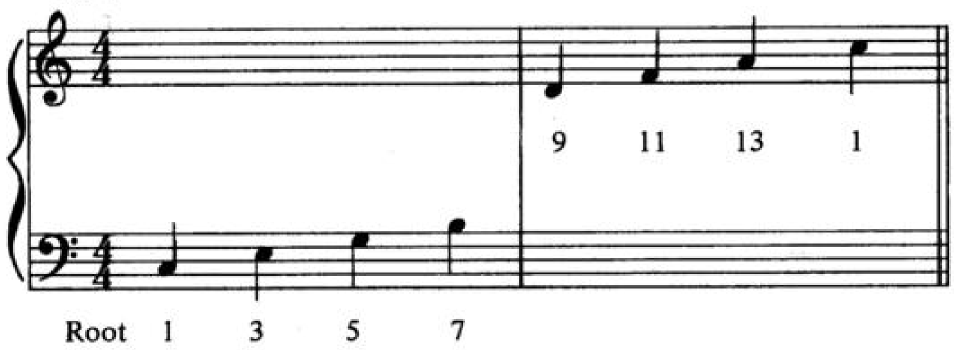
The use of voicings in this manner automatically offers the student the following:

Proper register (keyboard area)
Proper voice - leading
Automatic ornamentation
Contemporary sound

Author's note; It is absolutely essential that the student memorize an automatic facility with the twelve II - V - I patterns in Figs. 2 and 4.

The Basic Theory of Intervals

Fig. 7



In Fig. 7 the basic theory of all intervals is illustrated.
Intervals are traditionally conceived in alternate steps with odd numbers (1, 3, 5, 7, etc.); however, when building structures, 9 can be identified for convenience as 2, 11 as 4 and 13 as 6;but these tones still retain their original status or function.

The exception to this is the sixth tone which, as the following table will indicate, takes on different values depending upon the quality of the particular chord.

The Sixth Tone:

Major 7th chord = added 6th
Dominant 7th chord = 13th
Minor 7th chord = added 6th
Half diminished 7th chord = non-functioning
Diminished 7th chord = 7th of the chord

The unique quality of the 13th in the dominant chord results from the combination of the major 3rd and the minor 7th in the dominant chord.

Chapter 21

Contemporary Left Hand Voicings
Scales

Figures 1 through 13 illustrate the voicing system through the twelve major scales. Note that the II - V - I parent key system has been used in order to determine the (A) or (B) form status of each voicing.

Fig. 1 Key of C

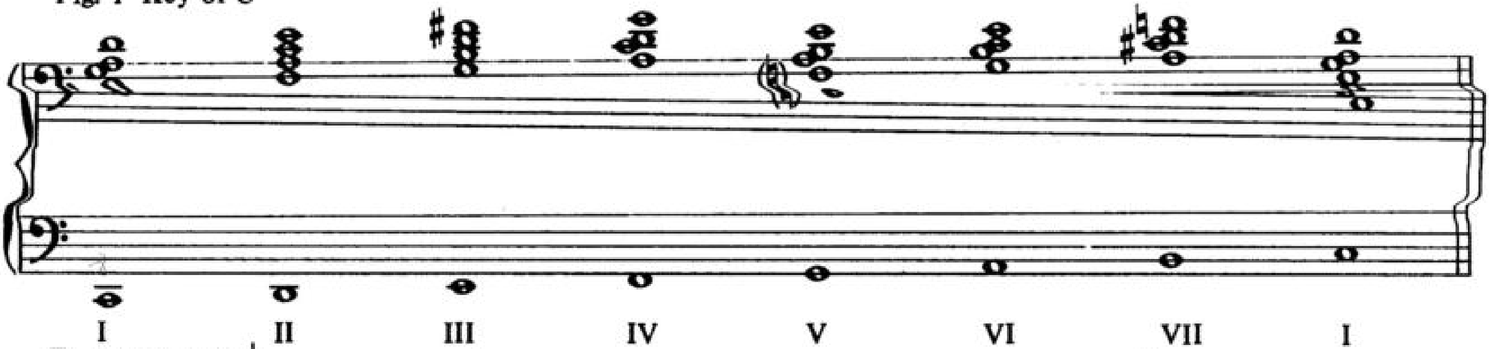


Fig. 2 Key of D♭

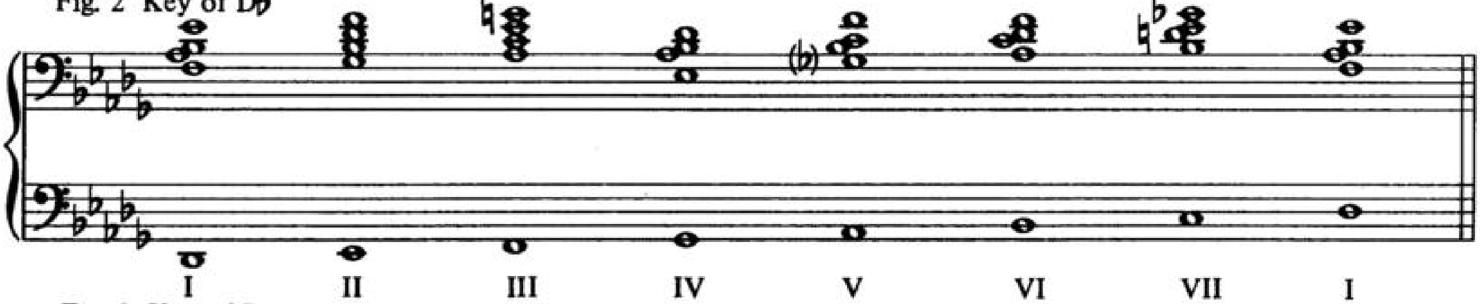


Fig. 3 Key of D

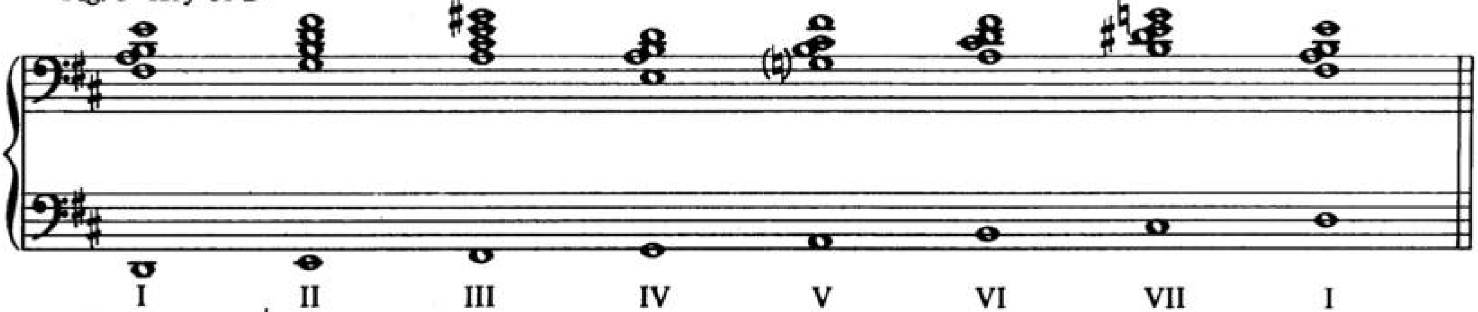


Fig. 4 Key of E♭

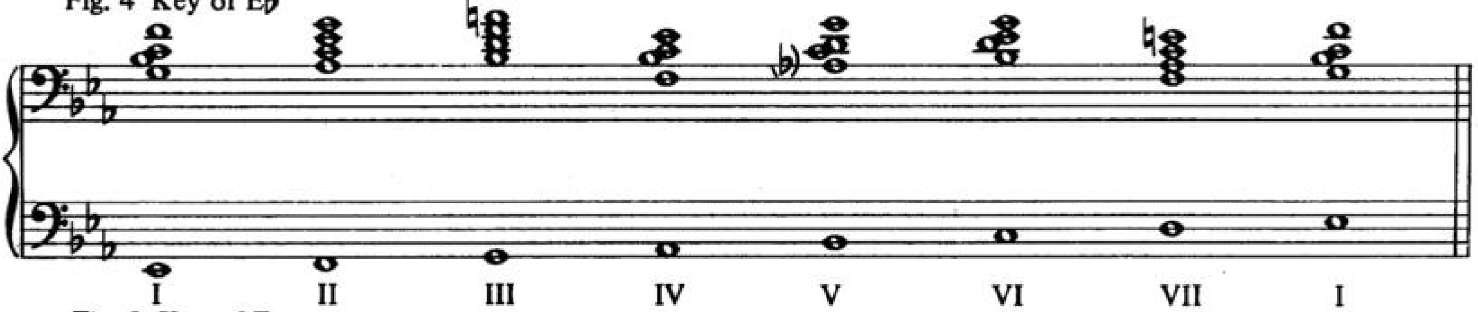


Fig. 5 Key of E

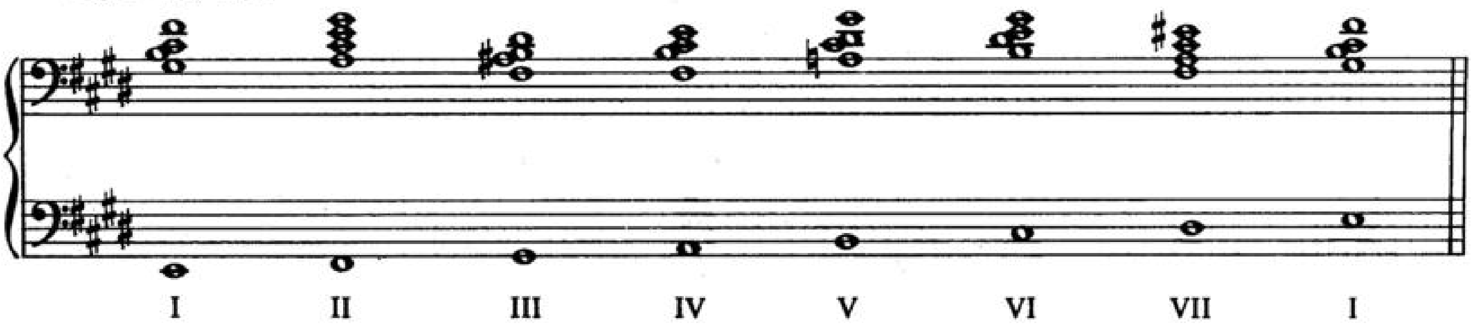


Fig. 6 Key of F

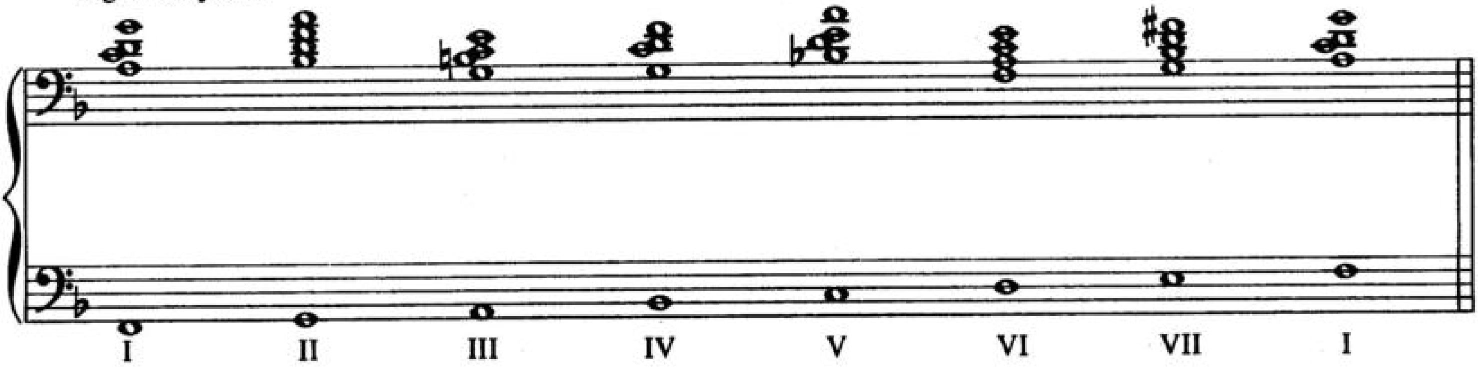


Fig. 7 Key of F♯
(Enharmonic of G♭)

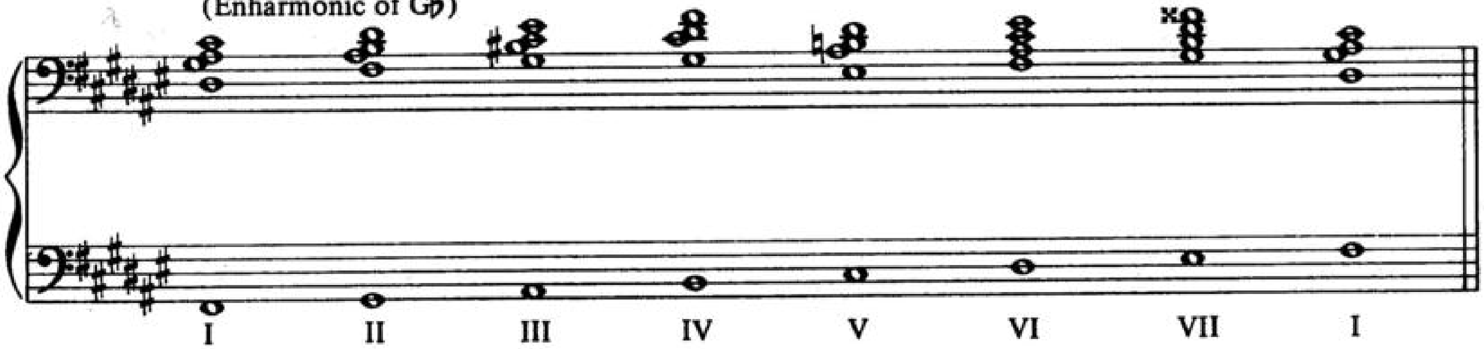


Fig. 8 Key of G♭
(Enharmonic of F♯)

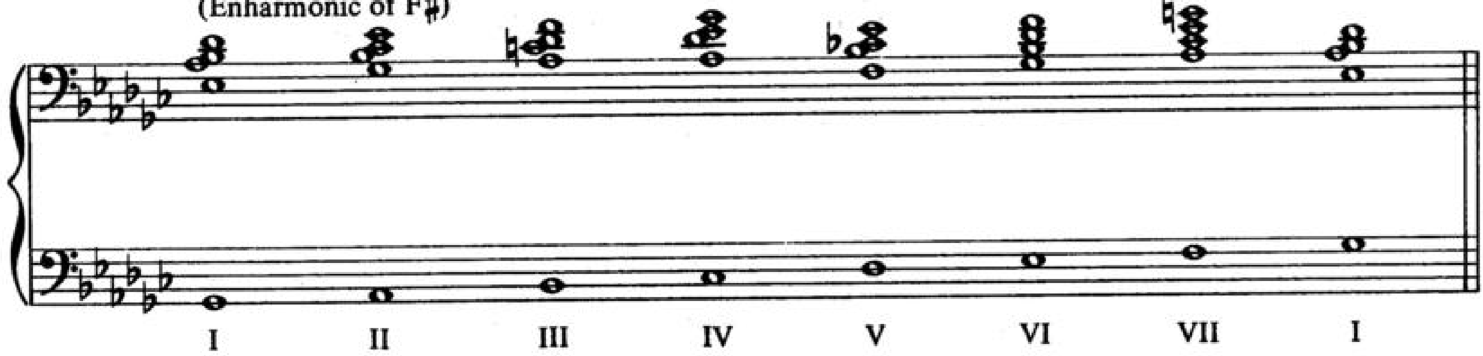


Fig. 9 Key of G

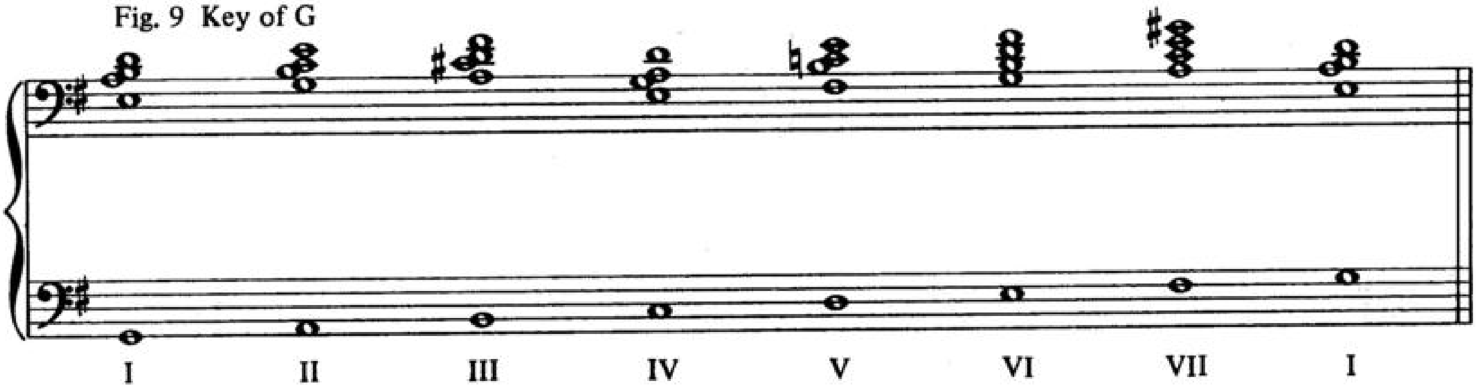


Fig. 10 Key of A♭

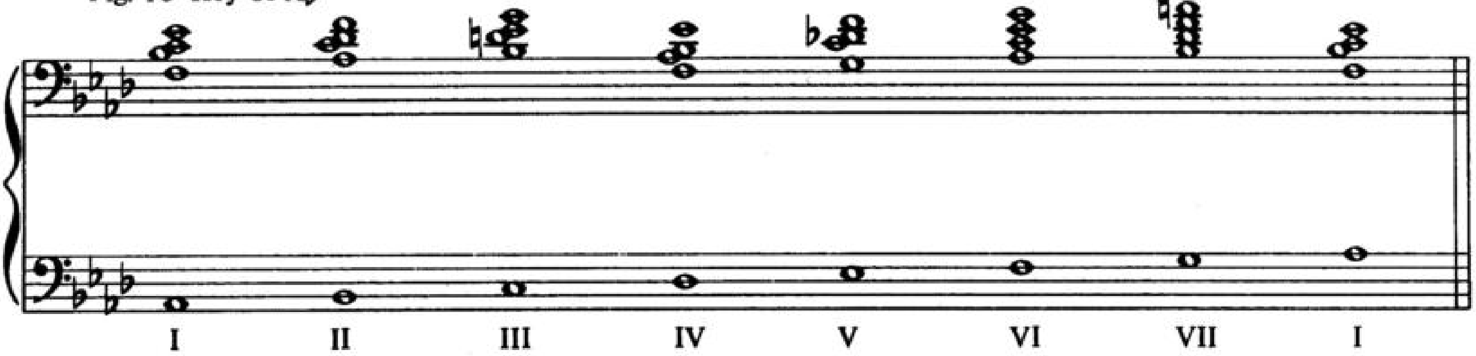


Fig. 11 Key of A

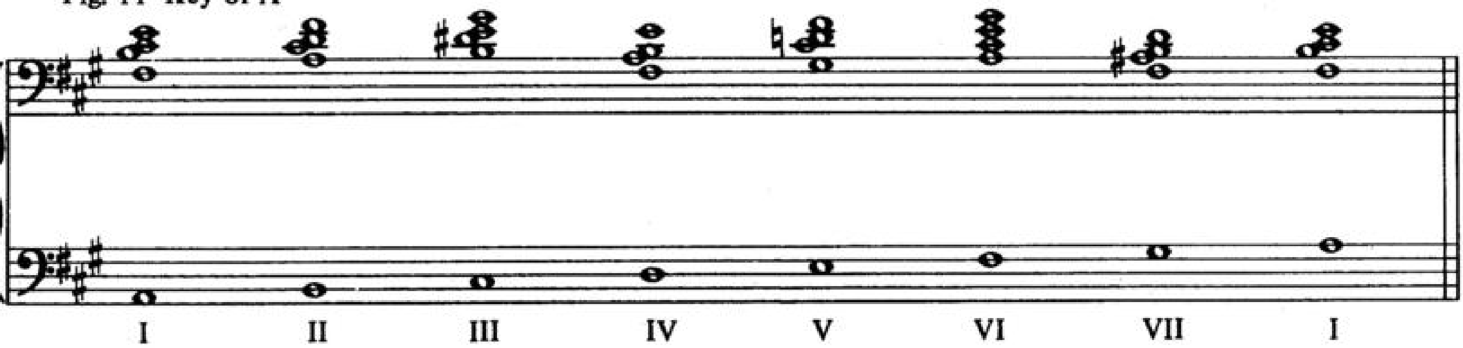


Fig. 12 Key of B♭

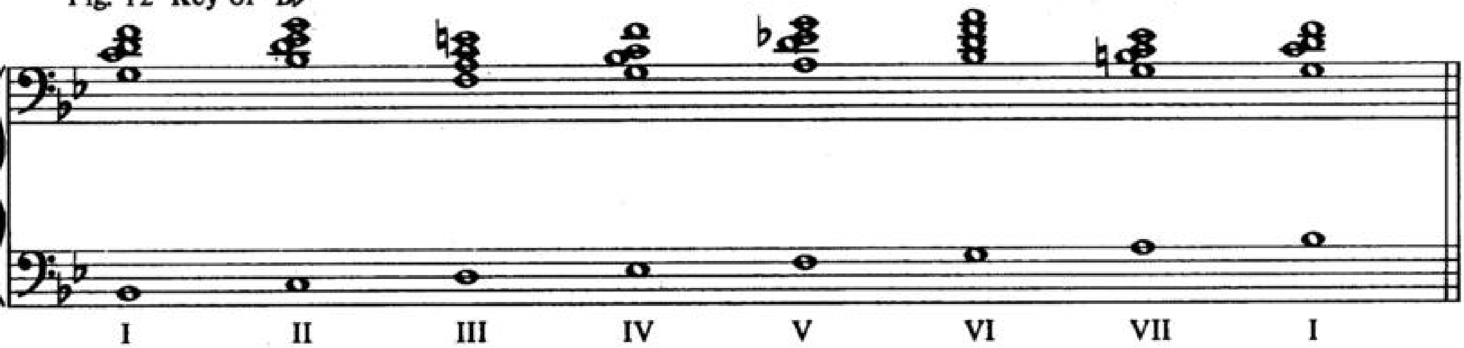
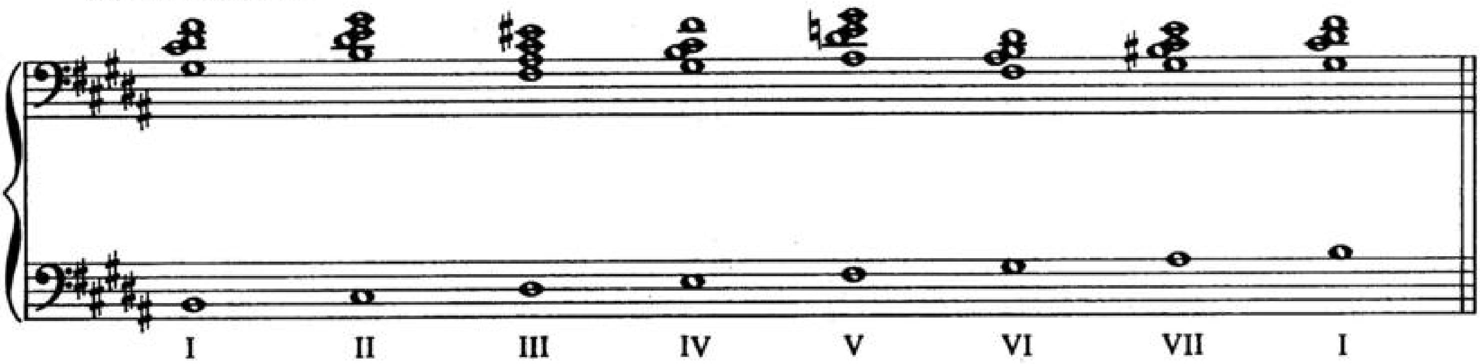



Fig. 13 Key of B

Contemporary Left Hand Voicings
Five Qualities

Figures 1 through 12 illustrate the voicing system applied to the five chord qualities.

Fig. 1

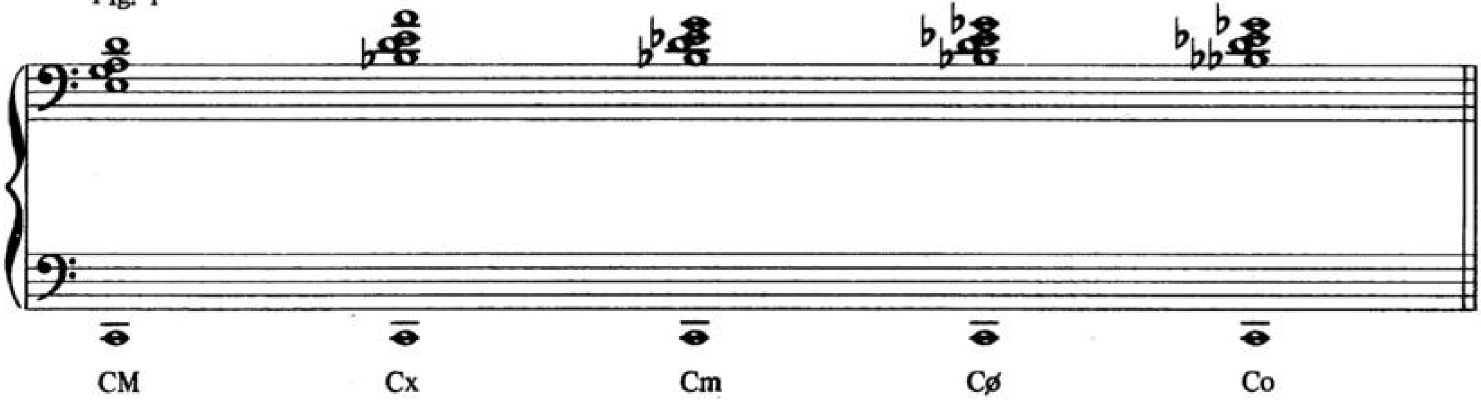


Fig. 2

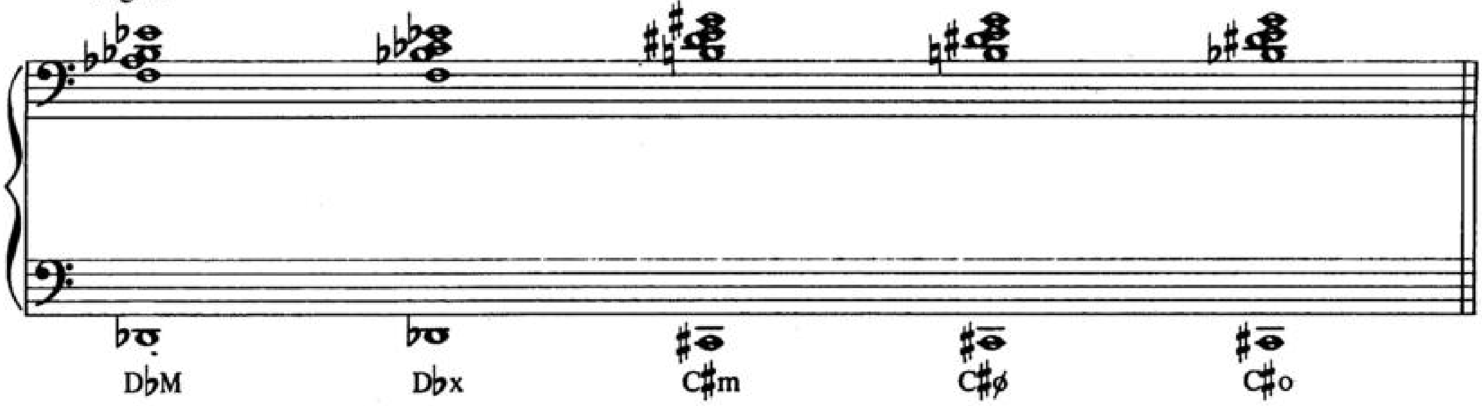


Fig. 3

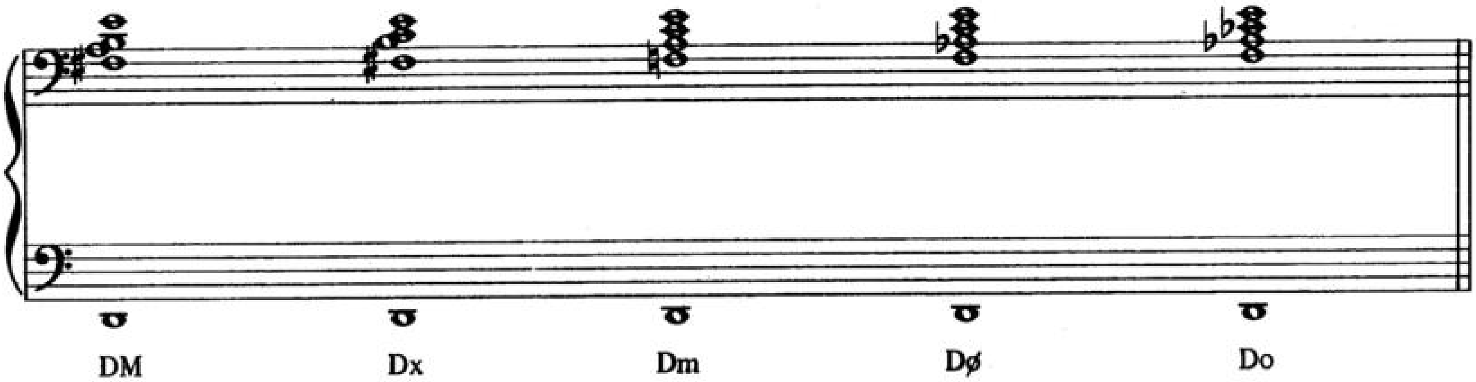


Fig. 4

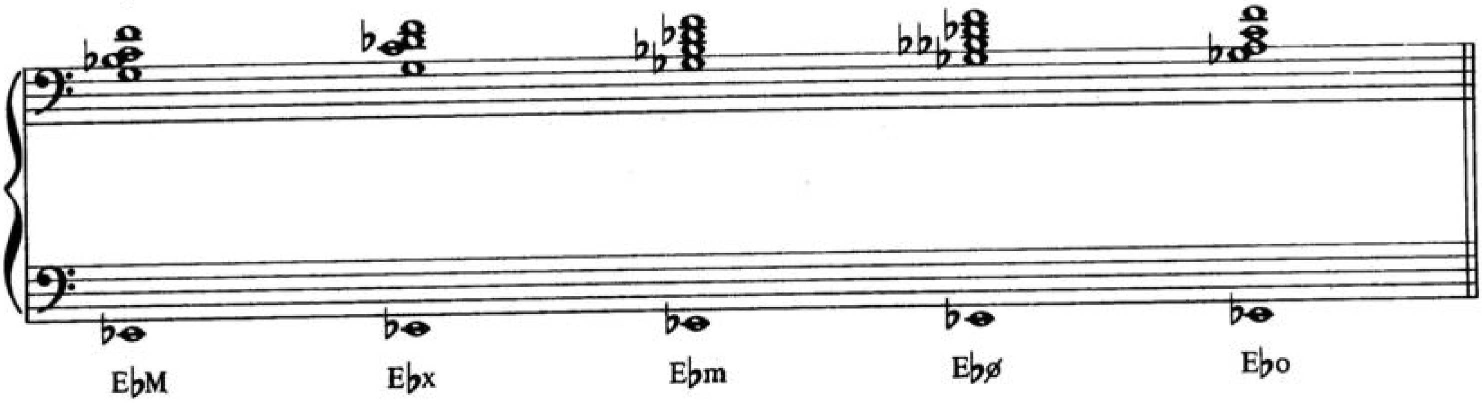


Fig. 5

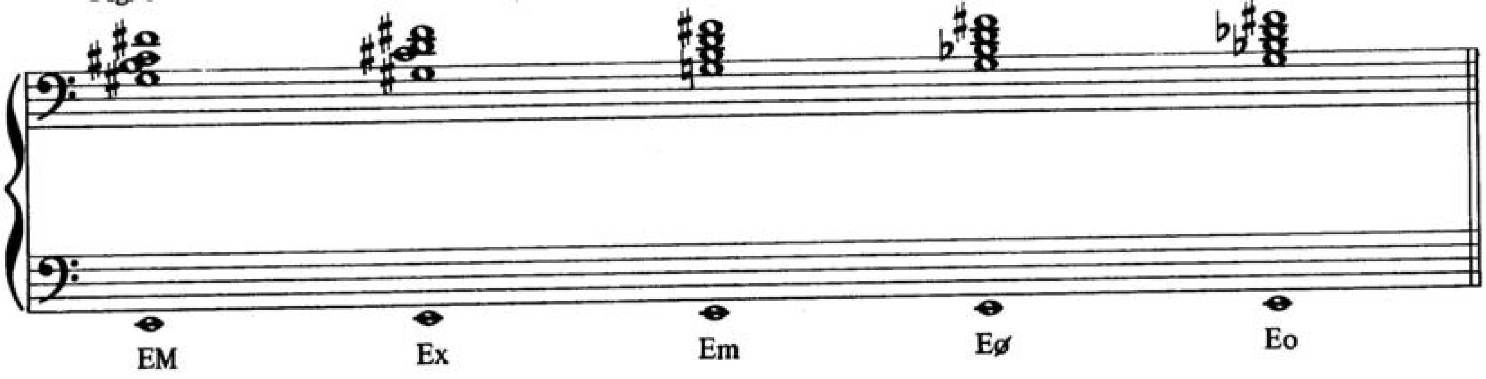


Fig. 6

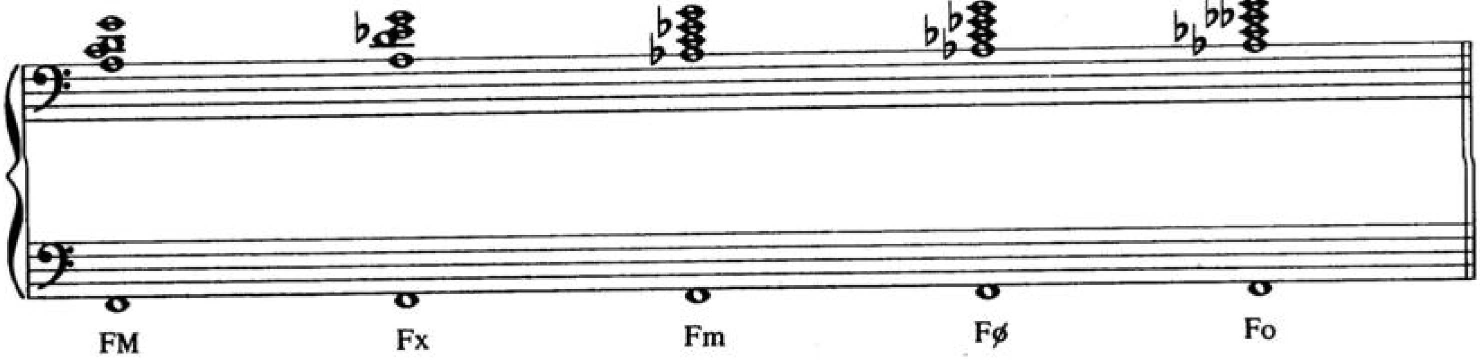


Fig. 7

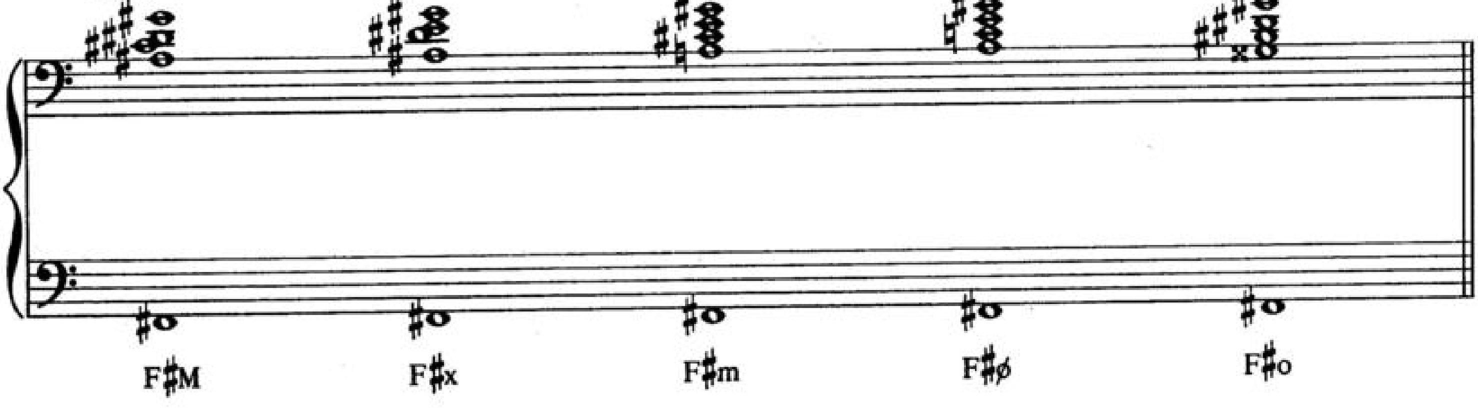


Fig. 8

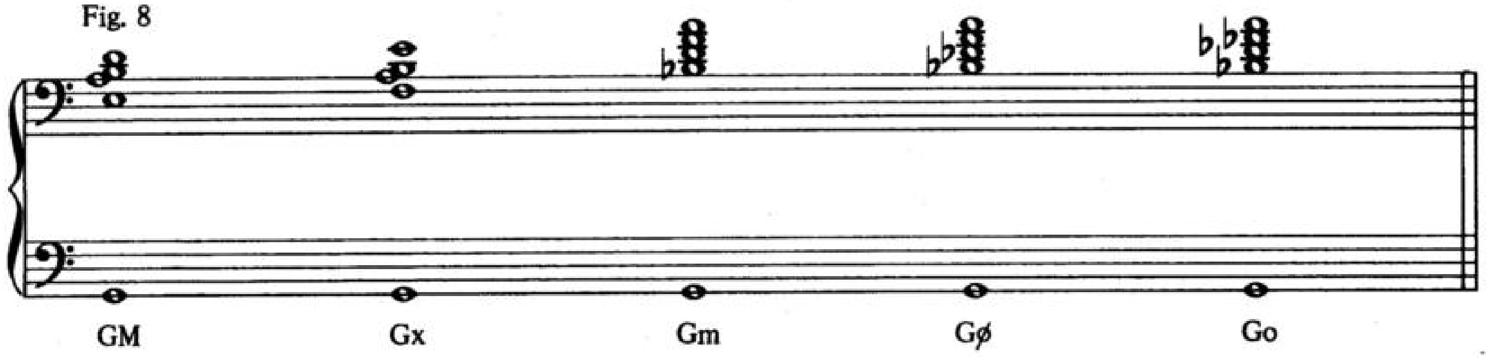


Fig. 9

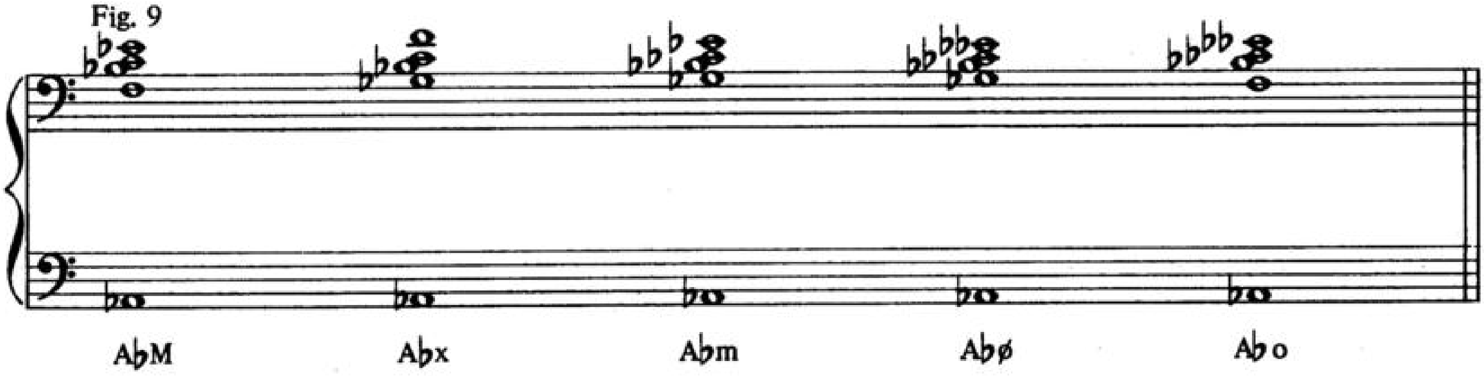


Fig. 10

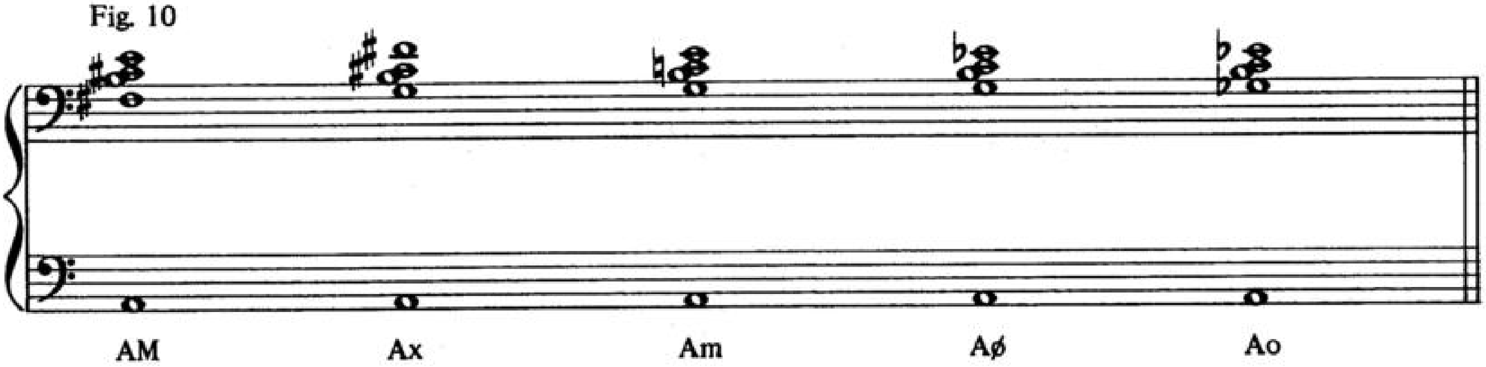


Fig. 11

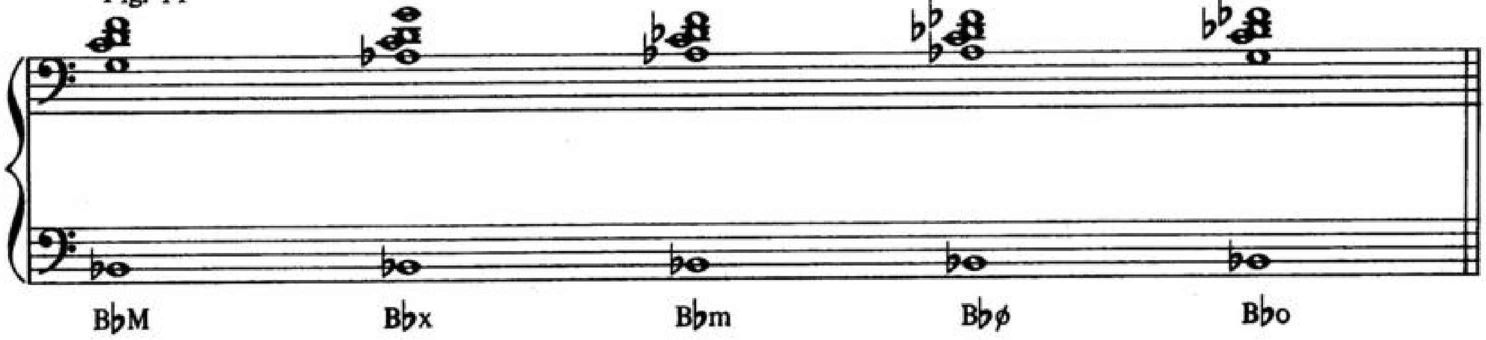
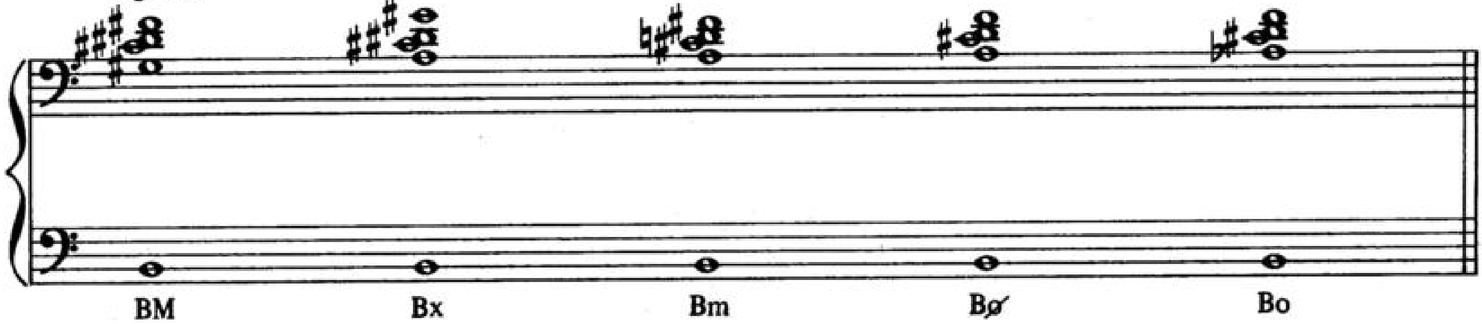


Fig. 12



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